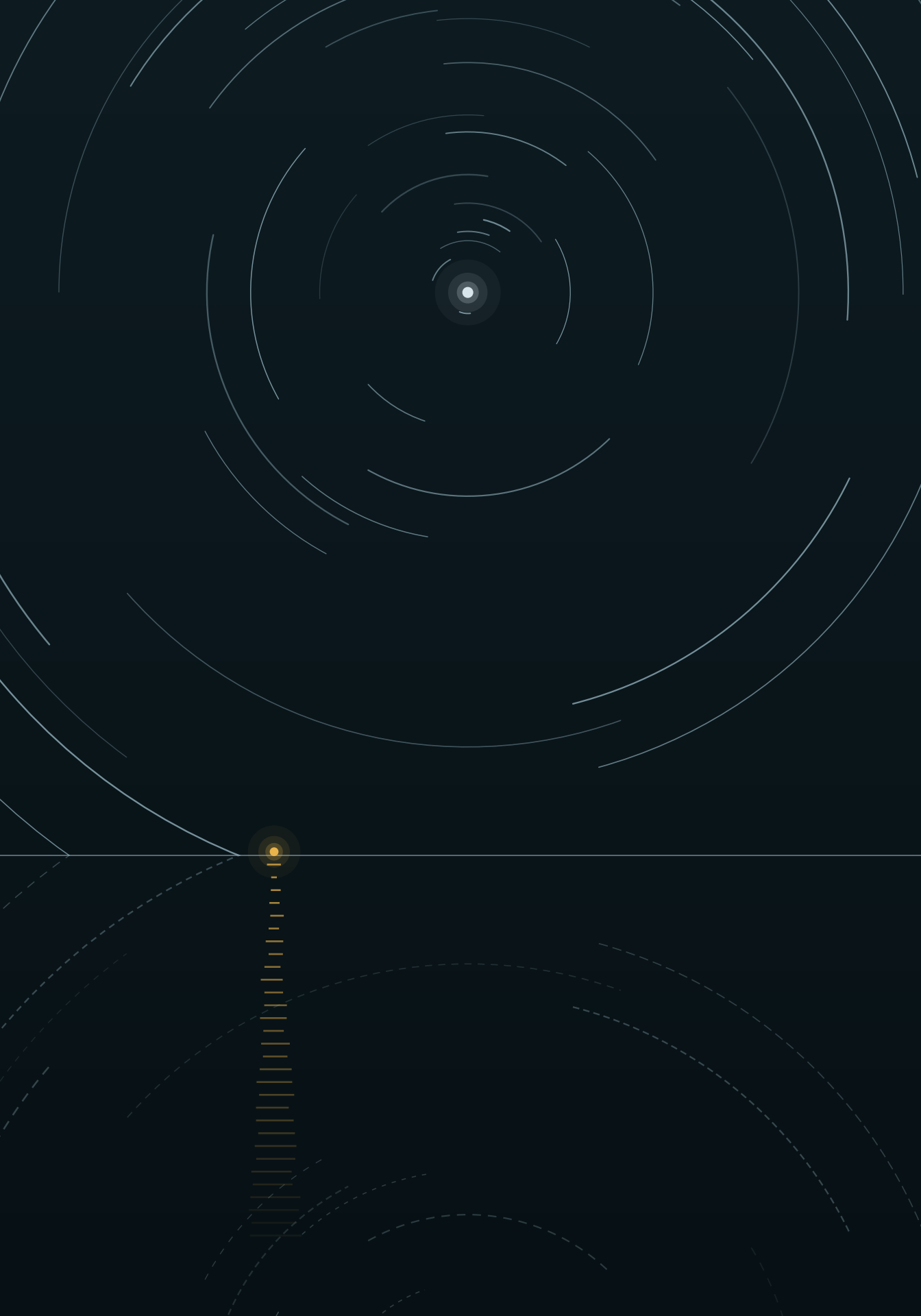
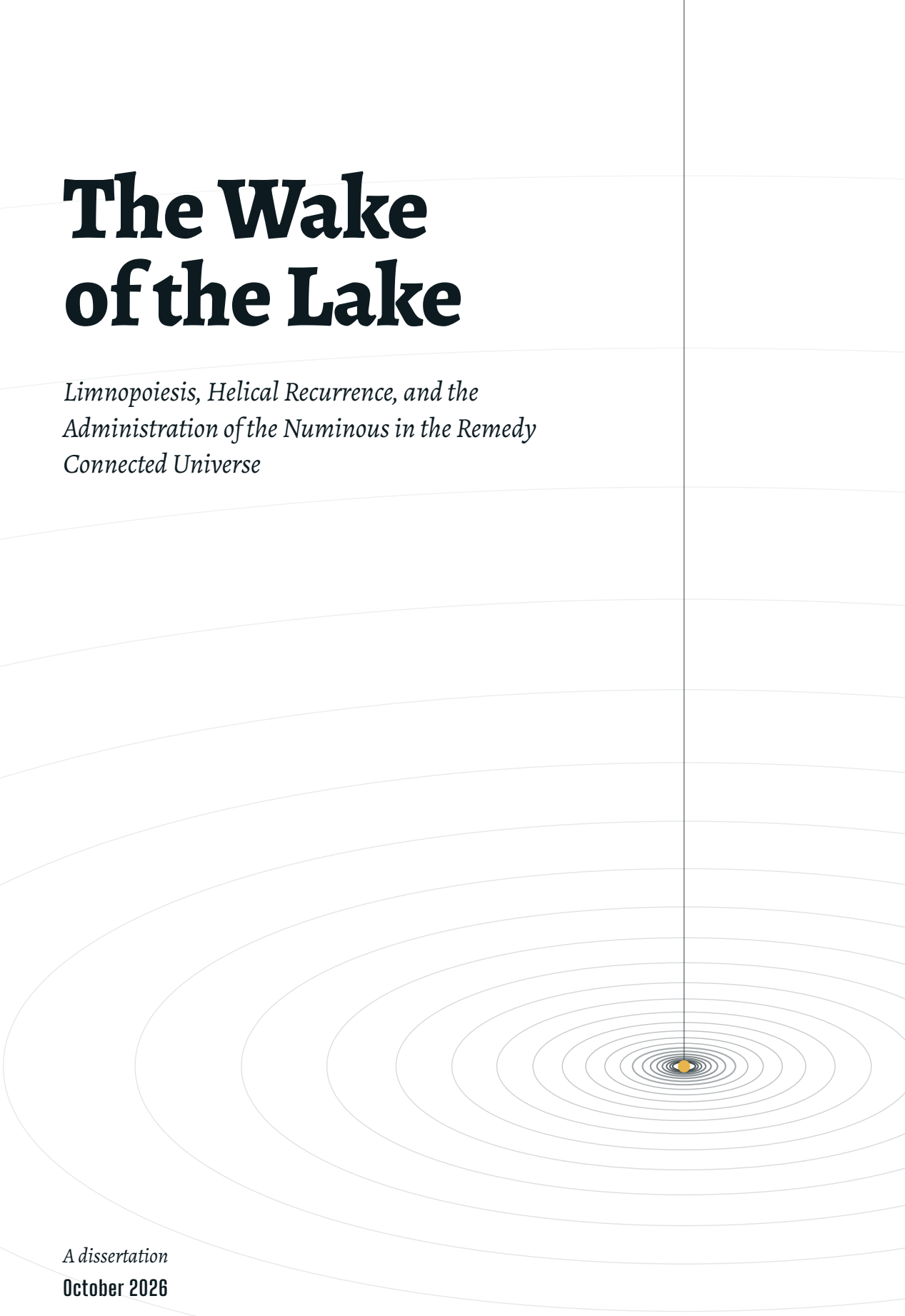


The Wake of the Lake



The Wake of the Lake

Limnopoiesis, Helical Recurrence, and the Administration of the Numinous in the Remedy Connected Universe



A dissertation

October 2026

The Wake of the Lake: Limnopoiesis, Helical Recurrence, and the Administration of the Numinous in the Remedy Connected Universe. October 2026.

Set in Alegreya and Alegreya Sans, designed by Juan Pablo del Peral for Huerta Tipográfica, with Big Shoulders Display and Courier Prime. The plates and figures were drawn for this edition from three primitives: the loop, the axis, and the spiral.

This is an independent study. The games, characters, and names it discusses belong to their respective owners, who are not affiliated with it and have not endorsed it.

And deeper than did ever plummet sound
I'll drown my book.

William Shakespeare, *The Tempest*, V.i

Alph, the sacred river, ran
Through caverns measureless to man
Down to a sunless sea.

Samuel Taylor Coleridge, "Kubla Khan" (1816)

The mind is its own place, and in itself
Can make a Heav'n of Hell, a Hell of Heav'n.

John Milton, *Paradise Lost*, l.254–255

Turning and turning in the widening gyre

W. B. Yeats, "The Second Coming" (1920)

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Abstract

This dissertation advances a systematic philosophical reading of the Remedy Connected Universe (RCU), the shared fictional cosmos developed by the Finnish studio Remedy Entertainment under the creative direction of Sam Lake across *Alan Wake* (2010) and its expansions *The Signal* and *The Writer* (2010), *Alan Wake's American Nightmare* (2012), *Control* (2019) and its expansions *The Foundation* and *AWE* (2020), *Alan Wake 2* (2023) with its *Final Draft* revision and its *Night Springs* and *The Lake House* expansions (2024), the cooperative *FBC: Firebreak* (2025), and the action role-playing sequel *Control Resonant* (2026). Against a critical habit that treats the RCU as an accomplished pastiche of Stephen King, David Lynch, H. P. Lovecraft, and the SCP Foundation, it argues that the corpus constitutes a coherent mythopoetic system: a cosmogony of the lake, whose object is the generation of reality from a receptive darkness by acts of form.

Proceeding by a method of constellation and amplification adapted from Walter Benjamin, Aby Warburg, and C. G. Jung, a method the corpus itself enacts procedurally in Saga Anderson's case board, the study reconstructs the RCU's literary genealogies (the Norse substrate of *Max Payne*, King's writer-protagonists, *Twin Peaks*, the Weird, English Romanticism, and the Finnish *Kalevala* tradition) and its mythic substrates (the monomyth's departure, initiation, and return; the poetic cauldrons of Norse and Welsh myth; Arthurian sovereignty; Baba Yaga; Orpheus; Gnostic and Lurianic cosmogony; Finnic sky-cosmology). It then formalizes four axioms.

The *Lacustrine Axiom* holds that reality is precipitated at the illuminated surface of a dark receptacle that is at once Plato's *khôra*, Böhme's *Ungrund*, Schelling's ground, Winnicott's potential space, and Lévi-Strauss's floating signifier, and that this receptacle hungers for form. The *Helical Axiom* holds that every act of form recurs, but that recurrence becomes revision only when displaced along an axis supplied by a reader: the loop of compulsion (Freud's acting-out, Nietzsche's eternal return of the same, the typescript of Kubrick's *The Shining*) becomes the spiral of working-through only when it is read. The *Equilibrial Axiom* holds that every creation exacts a cost proportionate to its reach, so that the ethics of making is an ethics of contraction (Luria's *tzimtzum*, Weil's decreation, Le Guin's Equilibrium, Mauss's gift), and that the institutions which would capture this economy (the clinic, the cult, the laboratory, the Federal Bureau of Control) reproduce the hubris they are built to contain. The *Auto-mythographic Axiom* holds that the RCU writes the conditions of its own production into its cosmology, from the author's birth surname (Järvi, Finnish for "lake") to the thirteen

years that separate the two *Alan Wake* games, the boundaries of intellectual property that silently define its multiverse, and the figure of a governing Board common to bureau and corporation alike.

Taken together, these axioms yield what the dissertation terms a *helical pharmacology of fiction*. The RCU's answer to the oldest question of poetics, whether poetry is remedy or poison (the Platonic *pharmakon*), is that it is both, and that the difference lies not in substance but in dosage (balance) and in direction (spiral). The study concludes that the RCU represents a distinctively twenty-first-century, Finnish-inflected form of transmedia myth, a Sampo that grinds worlds from the fragments of other worlds, and proposes *helical mythopoetics* as a critical category for serial fiction in the age of the franchise.

A Note on Corpus, Canon, and Citation

The corpus

The primary corpus comprises the works Remedy Entertainment has explicitly gathered under the designation "Remedy Connected Universe": *Alan Wake* (2010) with *The Signal* and *The Writer* (2010); *Alan Wake's American Nightmare* (2012); *Control* (2019) with *The Foundation* and *AWE* (2020), the latter of which formally sutured the two franchises by placing the Bright Falls catastrophe of 2010 within the case files of the Federal Bureau of Control; *Alan Wake Remastered* (2021); *Alan Wake 2* (2023), its *Final Draft* mode (2023), and its *Night Springs* and *The Lake House* expansions (2024); *FBC: Firebreak* (2025); and *Control Resonant*, announced at The Game Awards in December 2025, co-produced and co-financed by Annapurna Pictures, and released digitally on 24 September 2026 (Hitmarker; KitGuru). *Control Resonant* follows Dylan Faden, released after years of confinement by the Bureau into a "perception-bending" Manhattan that reflects his psyche, where the Hiss and the Mold have spread beyond the Oldest House and where he is reunited with Jesse, now Director. Released one month before this dissertation's completion, it is treated here at the level of premise, structure, and paratext rather than exhaustive close reading; its premise, as Chapter Nine argues, is nonetheless precisely what the dissertation's model predicts.

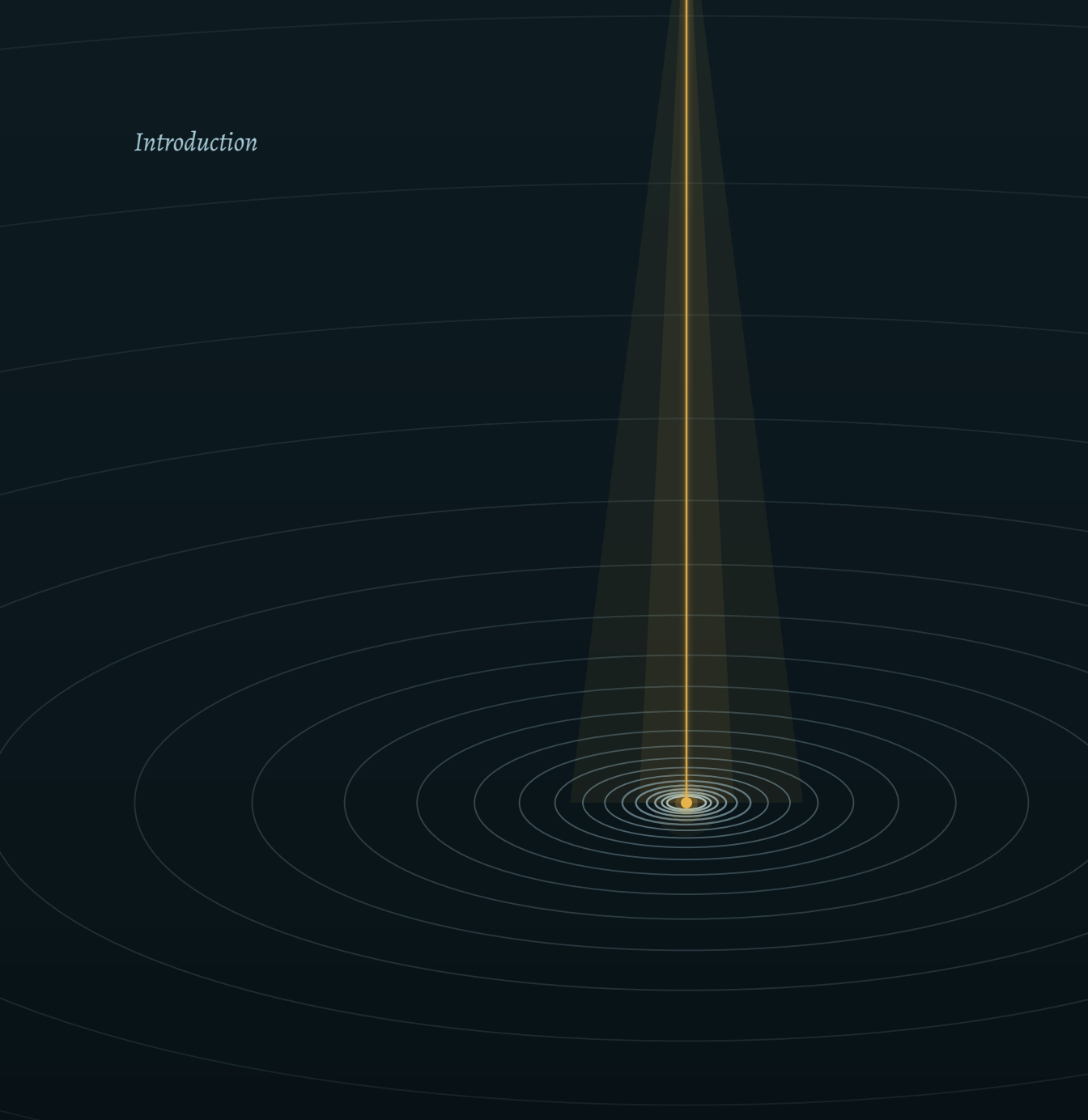
Two bodies of work stand at the corpus's edge. The *Max Payne* games (2001, 2003), written by Lake and owned by Rockstar Games, constitute an anterior mythos: outside the RCU's canon, yet the source of its Norse substrate, its in-world television, and the face that returns in *Alan Wake 2* as Alex Casey. *Quantum Break* (2016), whose intellectual property remains with Microsoft, occupies a juridically indeterminate position, sharing the RCU's preoccupations and its allusions while standing outside its declared borders. The dissertation treats both indeterminacies not as noise but as evidence for its fourth axiom (Chapter Nine). Ancillary transmedia (the live-action prequel series *Bright Falls* (2010), the in-world recordings of Poets of the Fall performing as the Old Gods of Asgard, in-game manuscripts, case files, broadcasts, and live-action interpolations) are read as integral to the corpus rather than as supplements to it.

Conventions

Games are cited by title and year of first release. "Lake" functions throughout as a metonym for the collective authorship of Remedy's writing and directing teams, among them Mikael Kasurinen, director of *Control* and creative director of *Control Resonant*; the metonym is defended, rather than merely assumed, in Chapters Six and Nine. In ac-

cordance with the norms governing quotation of copyrighted material, dialogue is quoted only in the briefest formulae (chiefly the two taglines on which the argument turns, "It's not a lake, it's an ocean" and "It's not a loop, it's a spiral"), song lyrics are characterized rather than reproduced, and post-1929 poetry and prose are paraphrased. Public-domain texts are quoted directly. "The Lake" (capitalized) designates Cauldron Lake as an ontological medium rather than a geographical feature. Onomastic resonances are treated as data: where a resonance is demonstrably intended it is so described, and where it is fortuitous it is flagged as such and admitted only as what Jung called amplification, an enrichment of a symbol by its parallels rather than a claim about authorial intention. Community exegesis is distinguished throughout from textual evidence and authorial paratext, and is cited only as the former's reception.

Where this study names collaborators, it follows the credits: *Alan Wake* 2, for instance, credits Sam Lake, Clay Murphy, Tyler Burton Smith, and Sinikka Annala as its writers, and Lake and Kyle Rowley as its directors (Wikipedia). Where harm occurs in the corpus or in its comparanda, it is described without graphic detail but with precision as to what was done and by whom.



The Lake Is Not a Lake

I.1 A universe connected by a theory of connection

I.2 Two corrections

I.3 Method: the dissertation as case board

I.4 The argument: four axioms

I.5 Plan of the work

ϕ I.I A universe connected by a theory of connection

The shared fictional universe is older than its corporate apotheosis. Balzac's *personnages reparaissants* bound the ninety-odd works of *La Comédie humaine* into a single social organism; Faulkner's Yoknapatawpha County gave a region a genealogy; Lovecraft, by inviting Clark Ashton Smith, Robert E. Howard, and Robert Bloch to borrow his entities, inaugurated the first open-source cosmology; Michael Moorcock, who popularized the very word "multiverse" in fiction, bound his Eternal Champion's incarnations under a Cosmic Balance between Law and Chaos; Stephen King's *Dark Tower* cycle converted an entire bibliography into the spokes of a single wheel. The Marvel Cinematic Universe industrialized the form, and in doing so fixed its dominant grammar: continuity of characters, convergence of plots, escalation toward a shared antagonist. The connective tissue of such universes is diegetic. Characters cross; events echo; a villain gathers.

The Remedy Connected Universe is connected otherwise. What binds *Alan Wake* to *Control* is not chiefly a crossover (though the *AWE* expansion supplies one, and *Alan Wake 2* and *The Lake House* elaborate it) but a shared metaphysics: a theory of how representation acts upon what it represents. In Bright Falls, Washington, a typed manuscript precipitates the events it narrates. In the Oldest House, a Brutalist tower in Manhattan that most passers-by cannot see, mass-produced objects (a rubber duck, a refrigerator, a slide projector, a telephone) are charged with paranatural power by the sediment of collective attention, and the Bureau that contains them names their catastrophes Altered World Events. The RCU is thus a universe connected by its own theory of connection: its unifying premise is not a character or a war but a poetics. That is the first and most general claim of this dissertation, and it explains why criticism that inventories the RCU's sources (King, Lynch, Lovecraft, the SCP Foundation, *House of Leaves*) without asking what system digests them has so consistently mistaken an argument for an anthology.

The charge of pastiche deserves a precise answer. Fredric Jameson defined pastiche as blank parody, the imitation of dead styles without parody's satirical impulse, the nostalgia mode of a culture that has lost its grip on history. The RCU certainly quotes: its diner is Lynch's, its blocked novelist King's, its bureau the SCP Foundation's, its shifting house Danielewski's. But quotation in the RCU is never inert. Each borrowed form is subordinated to a single question (what is the relation between making a story and making a world?) and each is revised in the light of the answer. Harold Bloom's term for the strongest form of influence, *apophrades*, the return of the dead in which the latecomer so possesses the precursor that the precursor seems to imitate him, is closer to the mark. After *Alan Wake 2*, King's writer-protagonists read like drafts of Alan Wake; after *Control*, the SCP Foundation reads like an archive awaiting its Director.

ϕ 1.2 Two corrections

The RCU has, conveniently for its exegete, condensed its philosophy into two formulae spoken thirteen years apart. The first closes *Alan Wake* (2010): "It's not a lake, it's an ocean." The second becomes the refrain of *Alan Wake 2* (2023): "It's not a loop, it's a spiral." Their shared grammar is diagnostic. Each is a correction, a negation of a smaller figure in favour of a larger one, and each correction concerns a different dimension of the same system. The first corrects *scale*: what seemed a bounded body of water, a local and personal unconscious, is revealed as continuous with a boundless collective depth. The second corrects *time*: what seemed a closed circuit of repetition is revealed as an ascending, or descending, displacement. The RCU's grammar is therefore revisionary at its root; its master-trope is the second draft. This dissertation reads the two formulae as philosophical propositions in the strict sense, statements with entailments, and reconstructs from them, together with a third principle the corpus repeatedly names ("balance"), the axiomatic structure of the whole.

> It's not a lake, it's an ocean.
>
> Alan Wake, 2010

> It's not a loop, it's a spiral.
>
> Alan Wake 2, 2023

ϕ 1.3 Method: the dissertation as case board

In *Alan Wake 2*, the FBI profiler Saga Anderson retreats at will into a Mind Place, a cabin-like office whose central furnishing is a case board on which photographs, documents, and testimonies are pinned and joined by red string until a pattern discloses itself. The image is the most widely circulated emblem of investigative reasoning in contemporary culture, and its intellectual pedigree is distinguished. Its scholarly ancestor is Aby Warburg's *Mnemosyne Atlas* (1924–1929), whose black panels arranged photographs of antique and Renaissance images so that their juxtaposition might disclose the *Nachleben*, the afterlife, of pagan formulae in Christian Europe. Its epistemological charter is Walter Benjamin's insistence, in the prologue to his study of German tragic drama (1928), that ideas stand to things as constellations stand to stars: not as their concepts or their laws, but as the configurations in which they become legible. Its logic is that of Charles Sanders Peirce's abduction, the inference to a hypothesis that would render surprising facts expected, which Umberto Eco and Thomas Sebeok traced through Dupin, Holmes, and Peirce himself in *The Sign of Three* (1983), and which Carlo Ginzburg, in "Clues: Roots

of an Evidential Paradigm" (1979), located at the common root of connoisseurship, detection, and psychoanalysis. Its hermeneutic is Jung's amplification, the enrichment of a symbol by assembling its parallels across myth, religion, and art until its field of meaning becomes visible.

The present study adopts this method deliberately and names its risk explicitly. The case board is also the conspiracy board, which Jameson famously described as the poor person's cognitive mapping, the desperate attempt to figure a totality that exceeds representation. Apophenia, the perception of pattern in noise, is the occupational disease of both the profiler and the comparatist. Three safeguards discipline the argument. First, evidence is stratified into the *textual* (what the games show and say), the *paratextual* (what their makers have said, and what their production histories document), and the *resonant* (parallels admitted as amplification, not as influence). Second, claims of influence are confined to sources the corpus explicitly cites or that its makers have acknowledged; claims of structural homology are argued from the structures themselves. Third, where a resonance is fortuitous, it is flagged as such. A thesis about a fictional universe in which coincidence is a physical force must at least be honest about its own coincidences.

ϕ I.4 The argument: four axioms

The dissertation's central contention is that the RCU constitutes a coherent mythopoetics, a cosmogony whose object is the generation of reality from a receptive darkness by acts of form, and that this cosmogony can be reconstructed as four axioms.

The **Lacustrine Axiom** states that reality is precipitated at the illuminated surface of a dark receptacle that hungers for form. The Lake is not a symbol of the unconscious; it is a medium prior to the distinction between symbol and thing, and its nearest philosophical analogues are Plato's *khôra*, the receptacle of becoming in the *Timaeus*; Jakob Böhme's *Ungrund*, the groundless abyss prior to God; Schelling's dark ground, the longing in God that is not God; D. W. Winnicott's potential space, the intermediate area in which play and culture occur; and Claude Lévi-Strauss's floating signifier, the empty term that can absorb any meaning. The Dark Presence is this receptacle's appetite. The dissertation names the resulting ontology *limnopoiesis*, making-from-the-lake.

The **Helical Axiom** states that every act of form recurs, but that recurrence becomes revision only when displaced along an axis, and that the axis is supplied by a reader. A text without a reader loops: this is the condition of Kubrick's Jack Torrance, typing one sentence into infinity, and of Freud's patient, who repeats in action what he cannot remember. A text that is read spirals: this is the condition of working-through. The dual-protagonist architecture of *Alan Wake 2*, in which an author generates drafts and a profiler reads them, is the formal embodiment of this axiom.

The **Equilibrial Axiom** states that every creation exacts a cost proportionate to its reach, and that the ethics of making is therefore an ethics of contraction. Its analogues are Isaac Luria's *tzimtzum*, God's withdrawal to make room for the world; Simone Weil's decreation; Ursula K. Le Guin's Equilibrium; and Marcel Mauss's gift, whose spirit demands return. Its corollary is institutional: every apparatus that would capture the economy of creation without paying its price (Hartman's clinic, the Cult of the Tree, the Bureau's laboratories) reproduces the hubris it was built to contain.

The **Auto-mythographic Axiom** states that the RCU writes the conditions of its own production into its cosmology. Sam Lake was born Sami Järvi, and *järvi* is Finnish for "lake"; the protagonist who bears the name Wake is, onomastically, the trace that an author leaves on water. Alan Wake's thirteen years in the Dark Place coincide with the thirteen years separating the two *Alan Wake* games, years in which the franchise's rights and the studio's fortunes were themselves held in a kind of abeyance. The borders of the RCU's multiverse coincide not with any metaphysical boundary but with the borders of intellectual property. The corpus is, in short, a myth about the making of myths that is also a myth about the making of itself.

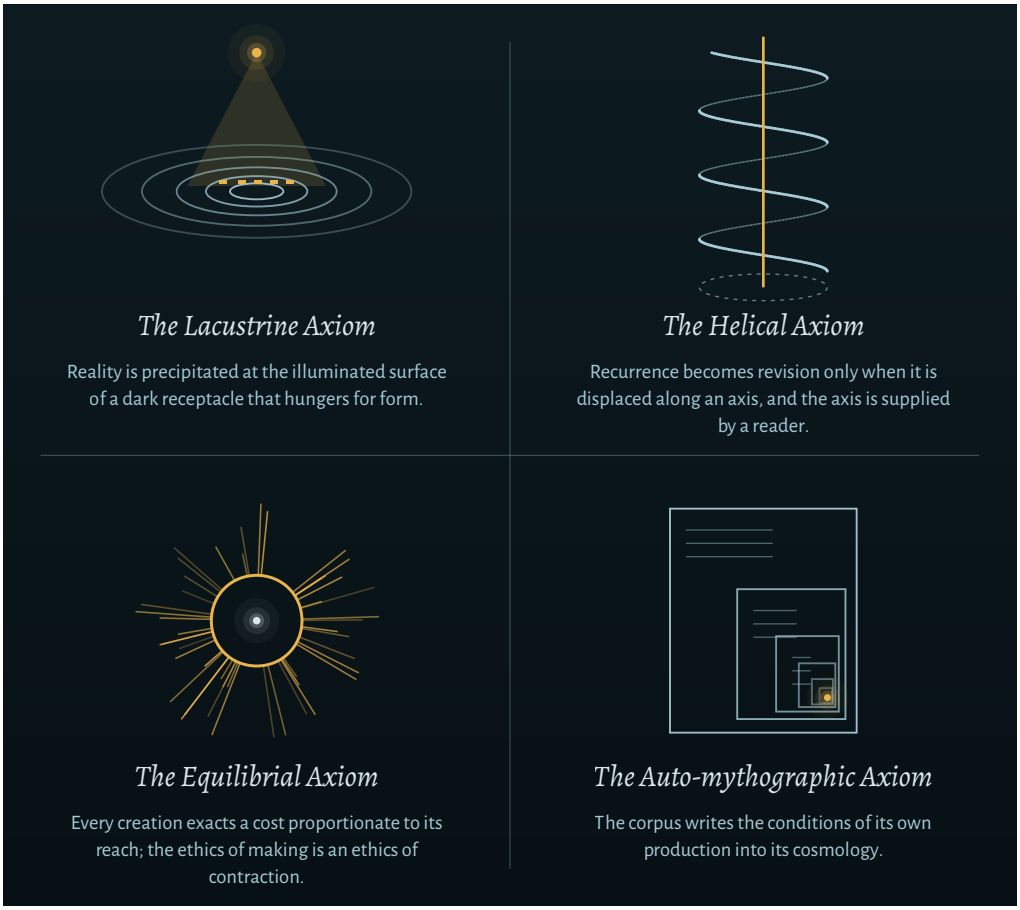


Figure I.1 The four axioms of the dissertation, each drawn from the three primitives used for every figure in this book: the loop, the axis, and the spiral.

Together the axioms yield a *helical pharmacology of fiction*. Plato's *Phaedrus* stages the invention of writing as the gift of a *pharmakon*, a word that means both remedy and poison, and Jacques Derrida built a philosophy of writing on that ambivalence. A studio called Remedy has built a universe on it. The RCU's answer to the oldest question of poetics, whether art heals or harms, is that it does both, and that the difference lies not in its substance but in its dosage (balance) and its direction (spiral).

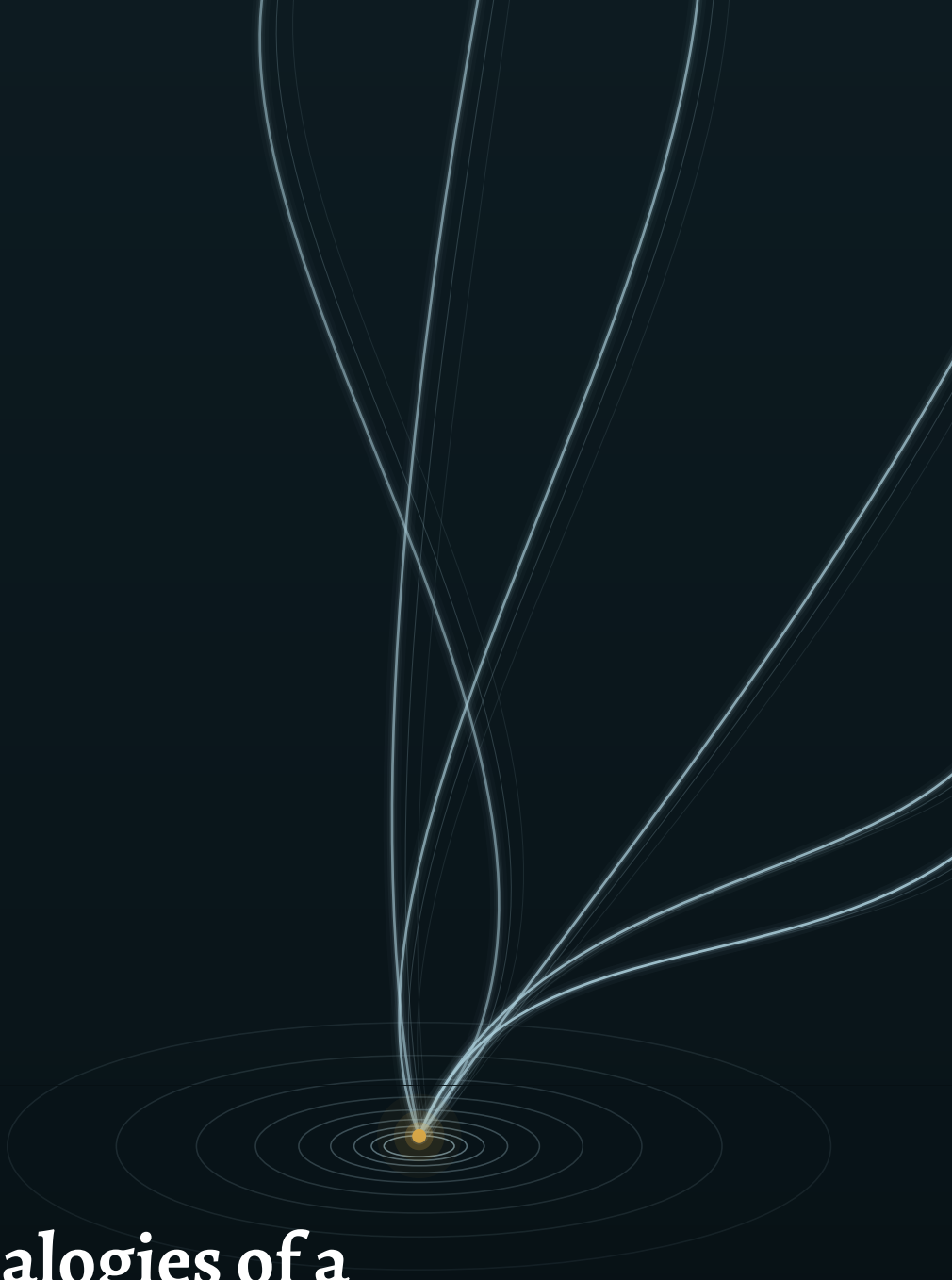
ϕ I.5 Plan of the work

Chapter One reconstructs the genealogy of Lake's imagination across six inheritances: the Norse noir of *Max Payne*; Stephen King's writer-protagonists; Lynch and Frost's *Twin Peaks*; the Weird tradition from Chambers and Lovecraft to VanderMeer and the SCP Foundation; English Romanticism's theory of the imagination; and the Finnish tradition of the *Kalevala*, runosong, and Tove Jansson. Chapter Two excavates the RCU's mythic

substrates: the monomyth's departure, initiation, and return; the poetic cauldrons of Norse and Welsh myth; Arthurian sovereignty; Baba Yaga; Orpheus; Gnostic and Lurianic cosmogony; Finnic sky-cosmology; and the gods of thresholds. Chapter Three formalizes limnopoiesis and the RCU's metaphysics of light. Chapter Four examines the RCU's theory of narrative causation against the philosophy of fiction, the law of genre, and the media archaeology of its typewriters, televisions, and projectors. Chapter Five develops the Helical Axiom through a typology of recurrence running from Nietzsche and Eliade to Freud, Dante, Deleuze, and the New Game Plus. Chapter Six reads the double and the author-function: Mr. Scratch, Alex Casey, Saga Anderson, and the repertory of faces through which the RCU stages authorship. Chapter Seven analyses *Control* and its successors as a political theology of the administered numinous. Chapter Eight develops the pharmacology of the Remedy into an ethics of creation. Chapter Nine articulates the original thesis in full and proposes helical mythopoetics as a category for serial fiction. A coda, two appendices, and a list of works cited complete the study.

Chapter One

1



Genealogies of a Lacustrine Imagination

1.1 Norse noir: *Max Payne* as anterior mythos

1.2 The King inheritance: the writer as protagonist

1.3 The Lynch–Frost inheritance: the small town and the Lodge

1.4 The Weird inheritance: from the King in Yellow to the Bureau

1.5 The Romantic inheritance: imagination as ontological power

1.6 The Finnish inheritance: runosong, the lake, and the lamp

1.7 Convergence: the maker in the dark with a light

The RCU is the confluence of six inheritances, each of which supplies a structural element of the mature system, and each of which the system revises. This chapter reconstructs them in roughly the order in which they enter Lake's work, and closes by naming the figure in which they converge.

ϕ 1.1 Norse noir: *Max Payne* as anterior mythos

Lake's first major work already encodes the mythic grammar of the later universe. *Max Payne* (2001) stages a New York police detective's revenge against a pharmaceutical conspiracy as an allegory of the Norse end of days. The corporation is Aesir; the designer drug at its centre is Valkyr; the one-eyed senator who guides Max through the conspiracy is Alfred Woden, which is to say Odin; the corporation's chief executive, Nicole Horne, bears a name that has been read as an allusion to Gjallarhorn, the horn that announces the end of the world; the nightclub at the centre of one of its pivotal shootouts is Ragna Rock; the action unfolds through a blizzard presented as the worst of the century, which functions as the Fimbulwinter preceding Ragnarök. Three formal innovations accompany this mythic code. The first is the graphic-novel panel, which introduces into the action game a second representational layer, drawn rather than rendered, and thereby establishes a habit of nesting media within media. The second is in-world television: *Max Payne 2* (2003) fills its apartments with screens broadcasting *Address Unknown*, a Lynchian serial whose plot uncannily shadows Max's own, alongside the soap opera *Lords and Ladies* and the cartoon *Captain Baseball Bat Boy*. *Night Springs*, the Twilight Zone pastiche that Alan Wake once wrote for, is these shows' direct descendant. The third is the nightmare level: Max's Valkyr-induced dreams, in which the corridors of his murdered family's home stretch into blood-trails (his wife and infant daughter were killed by three Valkyr test subjects whom Horne sent to the house), are the first Dark Places in Lake's oeuvre, zones where trauma rewrites architecture. And then there is the face. Lake's own features, photographed for Max's likeness, inaugurate a practice of authorial self-insertion that culminates two decades later in Alex Casey (Chapter Six). Even the musical bond that will become the Old Gods of Asgard begins here: Poets of the Fall's "Late Goodbye," which closes *Max Payne 2*, grew from a poem of Lake's.

The documentary record confirms and sharpens this account. Lake, born Sami Antero Järvi, handed Marko Saaresto a poem to be made into a song for *Max Payne 2*; "Late Goodbye" became the game's ending theme and a recurring motif, sung and whistled by its characters (Wikipedia; Wikipedia), a song that migrates from the credits into the world, as the Old Gods' songs will. Saaresto himself appears inside the game's soap opera, as the model for Lord Valentine in *Lords and Ladies* (Giant Bomb): the singer of the band that will become the Old Gods of Asgard is already, in 2003, a face in Lake's repertory. The Norse code is equally precise. Woden is one-eyed, like the god who gave

an eye for wisdom; the snowstorm has been read as Fimbulwinter and Horne's name as Gjallarhorn (Viking Rune); and the murders that set the story in motion were Horne's doing, carried out by Valkyr test subjects she sent to the Payne home (Giant Bomb).

The televisions are not décor; they are the first draft of the RCU's double. *Address Unknown*, a Lynch pastiche that begins in *Max Payne* and runs to seven episodes across both games, shows a player who is guiding a man framed for murder a man who looks like Max, framed for murder by his double, John Mirra (GamesRadar). In the finale the hunted man looks into a restroom mirror and sees that he was Mirra all along; the face in the mirror is modelled on Sam Lake's (Max Payne Wiki). One of the sequel's levels takes place in an abandoned funhouse built on the show, where Mona Sax hides (PC Gamer); another programme, *Dick Justice*, parodies Max's own life (Ludo); and the cartoon breaks into the world as a weapon when Vladimir Lem traps Vinnie Gognitti in a Captain Baseball Bat Boy costume rigged with explosives and detonates it, killing him (Giant Bomb). The later architecture is all present in 2003: the author's face on a man who discovers that he is his own killer, and fictions that leak out of their frames and kill. *Alan Wake* records the debt. Alan's third Casey novel is called *Return to Sender*, after the marathon under which *Max Payne* 2 aired *Address Unknown*; a toilet stall bears the graffito "MIRRA WAS HERE"; and Alan can catch on television the end of his own interview on *The Harry Garrett Show*, where his fellow guests are Sam Lake and the three members of Poets of the Fall (Alan Wake Files). The author sits beside his creature as a guest in its world thirteen years before Alan becomes the guest of Mr. Door's talk show.

What *Max Payne* lacks is the RCU's governing premise. Its Norse mythology is allegorical, not ontological; Valkyr is a drug, not a god. The later work will take the allegory at its word.

ϕ 1.2 The King inheritance: the writer as protagonist

Alan Wake opens with an epigraph attributed to Stephen King on the antagonism between nightmare and explanation, and its debt to King is structural rather than decorative. King made the writer the protagonist of popular horror and the act of writing its haunted vocation. *The Shining* (1977) isolates a blocked writer in a hotel that feeds on him; Kubrick's adaptation (1980) supplies the emblem against which the RCU defines itself, Jack Torrance's manuscript of a single proverb typed over hundreds of pages. *The Dark Half* (1989) gives the pseudonym a body: George Stark, the violent nom de plume of the novelist Thad Beaumont, rises from his mock grave to kill, and is finally carried off by sparrows that the novel names psychopomps, the soul-bearing birds whose possessed descendants are the crows that harry Alan Wake through the Pacific Northwest. *Secret Window, Secret Garden* (1990) pairs a lake-cabin novelist with an accusing double. *Misery* (1987) gives the reader teeth in Annie Wilkes, self-declared "number one fan," a title that

returns in *Night Springs* as the name of the episode in which the waitress Rose Marigold becomes the heroine of her own fan fiction. *Bag of Bones* (1998) sends a widowed, blocked novelist to a haunted lake. *Lisey's Story* (2006) imagines Boo'ya Moon, a realm reached by a novelist in which a pool supplies the stories writers fish for and a monstrous presence waits at its edge. *Duma Key* (2008) gives a painter's canvases the power to act on the world. *The Dark Tower* cycle (1982–2012) writes King himself into the story and ends by returning its gunslinger to the desert where he began, with one difference, the Horn of Eld, that makes the circle a spiral. King's Maine even supplies the RCU's toponymic register: Jesse Faden's hometown, scene of the Altered World Event that shapes her life, is called Ordinary, which most of the franchise's paratexts place in Maine (a minority of summaries give Wisconsin).

Lake inherits from King the writer's ambivalent power, the small town as pressure vessel, and the conviction that popular genre can carry metaphysical freight. He revises King at one decisive point. King's writers confront monsters that are external (the Overlook), psychological (Stark as repressed violence), or both; their writing is the occasion of horror, not its mechanism. In the RCU, writing is the mechanism. The manuscript does not describe the monster; it summons it.

ϕ 1.3 The Lynch–Frost inheritance: the small town and the Lodge

Bright Falls is unthinkable without Twin Peaks. The logging town in the Pacific Northwest, the diner with its pie and coffee, the radio host who knows everyone, the outsider arriving to investigate a death, the eccentric woman who carries a sacred object (Lynch's Log Lady, Lake's Cynthia Weaver, who guards a room kept permanently lit), the spirit that inhabits townspeople (BOB, the Dark Presence), the other place where doubles are made (the Black Lodge, the Dark Place): the correspondences are so dense that they constitute a declared genealogy. *Fire Walk with Me* (1992) supplied the image of a magician chanting between two worlds; *Twin Peaks: The Return* (2017) supplied, six years before *Alan Wake 2*, the narrative of an FBI agent imprisoned for twenty-five years in an extradimensional realm while his double walks the earth, and an ending in which the attempt to rewrite the past yields a new reality rather than a restored one. *Alan Wake 2*'s division of its chapters into "Return" and "Initiation" cannot be innocent of the subtitle of Lynch and Frost's revival. Saga Anderson is Dale Cooper redistributed: Cooper's Tibetan method, his trust in dreams and intuition, becomes Saga's Mind Place. The year 2010 even produced a twin: Hidetaka Suehiro's *Deadly Premonition*, another Twin Peaks game about an FBI agent in a Pacific Northwest town, released within months of *Alan Wake*.

Lake's revision of Lynch is the most consequential of his revisions and the least remarked. Lynch's uncanny is principled in its refusal of explanation; his Lodge obeys no rules a viewer can learn. The RCU submits the Lynchian uncanny to the logic of a game

system, which is to say to law. Light burns away darkness; a manuscript must be plausible to take effect; a story must balance. The RCU is Lynch with a rulebook: a dream that has acquired a physics.

The makers confirm the genealogy: Lake has said that the sequel drew specifically on *Twin Peaks: The Return*, as the first game had drawn on the original series (Wikipedia). The RCU's revision of Lynch can then be measured in a single line. The incantation of *Fire Walk with Me* places its magician between two worlds; the *Final Draft* ending of *Alan Wake* 2 has Alan, freed from the loop, proclaim himself master of not just two worlds but many. Lynch's binary of lodge and town becomes in the RCU a plurality: the dream that acquired a physics becomes a multiverse with a law.

ϕ 1.4 The Weird inheritance: from the King in Yellow to the Bureau

The RCU's third inheritance is the Weird, and it arrives in two waves. The first is the dangerous text. Robert W. Chambers's *The King in Yellow* (1895) imagined a play whose second act drives its readers mad. Lovecraft, in "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928), made artists and poets the first receivers of a sleeping god's transmissions, his sculptor Wilcox shaping in clay the dreams that R'lyeh broadcasts; the story's opening sentence, that the most merciful thing in the world is "the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents," could stand as the motto of every redacted Bureau document. "The Music of Erich Zann" (1922) made art a dike against the void, a violinist playing frantically to hold back something outside his window, precisely the function of the Old Gods of Asgard's music during the stage battle at the Anderson farm in *Alan Wake*. August Derleth's later moralization of the Mythos into a war between Elder Gods and Great Old Ones survives in the title of the Old Gods' anthem, "Children of the Elder God." The decisive precursor, however, is John Carpenter's *In the Mouth of Madness* (1994), in which a horror novelist's books make his fictional town real, the investigator discovers that he is a character in the novelist's latest work, and the film ends with him watching the film of his own story. *Alan Wake* is, in the most literal sense, an expansion of Carpenter's premise into a world.

The second wave is bureaucratic. Jeff VanderMeer's *Southern Reach* trilogy (2014) paired an expedition into a transformative zone with, in its second volume, *Authority*, an anatomy of the dysfunctional agency charged with it; its Crawler writes living words on the walls of a descending tower. The collaborative SCP Foundation (from 2008) perfected the clinical genre of the containment file, with its object classes, its procedures, and its black bars of redaction. Behind these stand the Strugatsky brothers' *Roadside Picnic* (1972), with its Zone of alien artifacts; Grant Morrison's *Doom Patrol* (1989–1993), with its Bureau of Normalcy devoted to removing weirdness from the world; Mike Mignola's Bureau for Paranormal Research and Defense; Charles Stross's *Laundry Files* (from 2004), where cosmic horror is a branch of the British civil service; the miniseries *The Lost Room*

(2006), in which the objects of a single motel room acquire uncanny powers; and Mark Z. Danielewski's *House of Leaves* (2000), whose house is larger on the inside and whose most dangerous passages are struck through. Mark Fisher's *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016) supplies the theory: the weird is that which does not belong, the eerie a failure of absence or of presence. The Oldest House, with its abandoned cubicles and its humming silence, is the eerie office; Bright Falls at night, its forests full of murmuring figures, is the eerie town.

Lake revises the Weird at its metaphysical core. Lovecraft's outside is indifferent to us; its horror is our insignificance. The RCU's outside is not indifferent. It is hungry, and what it hungers for is specifically our stories. This dissertation calls the result the *narrative Weird*: a cosmos whose alien dimension is not beyond meaning but ravenous for it.

ϕ 1.5 The Romantic inheritance: imagination as ontological power

The RCU's theory of creation is Romantic, and it takes the Romantics more literally than they took themselves. Coleridge's preface to "Kubla Khan" (1816) narrates a poem composed in sleep, transcribed upon waking, and lost when a person on business from Porlock interrupted its transcription, leaving only scattered lines and images: it is the founding scene of *Alan Wake*, whose novelist awakens from a lost week to find pages of a manuscript he does not remember writing. The poem itself descends, through caverns measureless to man, to a sunless sea, and ends by warning its hearers to weave a circle round the inspired poet thrice, for he has drunk the milk of Paradise: the poet as a quarantined danger. The *Biographia Literaria* (1817) defines the secondary imagination as the power that "dissolves, diffuses, dissipates, in order to re-create," a precise description of what the manuscript does to Bright Falls. "Dejection: An Ode" (1802) mourns the loss of "my shaping spirit of Imagination": the canonical poem of writer's block, two centuries before Edmund Bergler gave the condition its clinical name. Shelley's *Defence of Poetry* (written 1821) declares that "Poets are the unacknowledged legislators of the world"; in Bright Falls they are its acknowledged ones. Blake's Los forges systems lest he be enslaved by another man's, and his Spectre, the rationalizing double that torments the creative self, is a sketch of Mr. Scratch. Keats's chameleon poet, who has no identity because he is continually filling some other body, describes the author dissolving into his characters; Rimbaud's "Je est un autre" names the alienation of the self in its own writing.

The Romantics exalted the imagination as the human participation in divine creativity. The RCU accepts the premise and draws the consequence the Romantics resisted: if imagination is a real power, it is also a resource, and resources attract extraction. Hartman's clinic, the Cult of the Tree, and the Bureau's laboratories are the industrial sequel to Romantic inspiration.

ϕ 1.6 The Finnish inheritance: runosong, the lake, and the lamp

The sixth inheritance is the least discussed and, this dissertation argues, the deepest. Remedy is based in Espoo; its creative director was born Sami Järvi, and the surname he translated into English is the common Finnish word for the landform that covers roughly a tenth of his country's surface. Finland's relation to light and darkness is not metaphorical but seasonal: the polar night (*kaamos*) of the far north and the nightless summer (*yötön yö*) make illumination a matter of calendar rather than symbol, and a culture so placed knows that darkness has duration, texture, and weight.

The Finnish national epic, Elias Lönnrot's *Kalevala* (1835; expanded 1849), supplies the RCU's theory of creative power in three ways. First, its magic is verbal: Väinämöinen, the eternal singer, defeats his rival by singing him into a swamp, and the folk-magical principle of *synty*, knowledge of a thing's origin, grants power over it (the ninth poem recites the origin of iron to staunch a wound iron made). In the RCU, to defeat the Dark Presence one must write its history. Second, its plot turns on missing words: Väinämöinen, building a boat by song, lacks three words to finish it and must descend into the belly of the dead sage Antero Vipunen to obtain them, a precise image of a writer seeking the words that will complete a vessel of escape. Third, its ending is a departure that promises return: in the fiftieth poem, Väinämöinen sails away in a copper boat, leaving his kantele and his songs behind and vowing to return when he is needed. *Departure* is the title of the manuscript in *Alan Wake*; *Return* is the name of half of *Alan Wake 2*. The epic also supplies Ahti, god of the waters, whose name is borne by the Finnish-speaking janitor of the Oldest House; Tuonela, the underworld reached across a black river, where Lemminkäinen is killed and from which his mother rakes his scattered body to restore it; and the Sampo, the magic mill whose theft, shattering, and scattered fragments the conclusion of this dissertation takes as its emblem. Beneath the epic lies the runosong tradition from which Lönnrot assembled it, whose defining device is parallelism: each line is followed by a variant that restates it with a difference, often sung by a second singer to the lead's first. Chapter Five argues that this device is the prosody of the spiral.

The modern Finnish imagination supplies a second, unexpected precursor. Tove Jansson's *Moominpappa at Sea* (1965) sends a father in crisis about his own significance to a lighthouse island whose lamp has gone dark, where he obsessively studies the moods of a sea that behaves like a living being, while his son is visited each night by the Groke, a cold and lonely creature who freezes the ground where she sits and who comes not to destroy the lantern but because she longs for its light. It is the closest analogue in world literature to *Alan Wake*: an artist-father's crisis, a lighthouse, a sentient water, and a darkness that is not malicious but starved. Chapter Three takes the Groke's hunger as a key to the Dark Presence. Finally, Finland's deadpan tradition, from the films of Aki Kaurismäki to the melancholy of the Finnish tango, supplies the RCU's tonal signature,

audible whenever Ahti hums or the Koskela brothers' commercials interrupt the horror of *Alan Wake 2* with absurd sincerity.

The sequel makes the point audible. Ahti, the Finnish-speaking janitor of the Oldest House, turns up in the town of Watery serenading a crowd (PCGamesN), and the cast listing credits the performance to "Ahti and the Janitors" singing "Nightless Night" (IMDbPro), the English for *yötön yö*, the Finnish summer night in which darkness never falls. A water god turned custodian sings, in a horror game about the dark, of a night without darkness.

ϕ 1.7 Convergence: the maker in the dark with a light

The six inheritances converge on a single figure: a maker, alone in the dark, holding a light. Max in the blizzard with his painkillers; King's writer at his desk; Cooper in the Red Room; Lovecraft's sculptor dreaming R'lyeh; Coleridge waking from his vision; Moominpappa in the dark lighthouse. The RCU's achievement is to have converted this figure from a type into a cosmology, in which the maker's light is the form that reality takes, and the darkness is the matter that receives it.

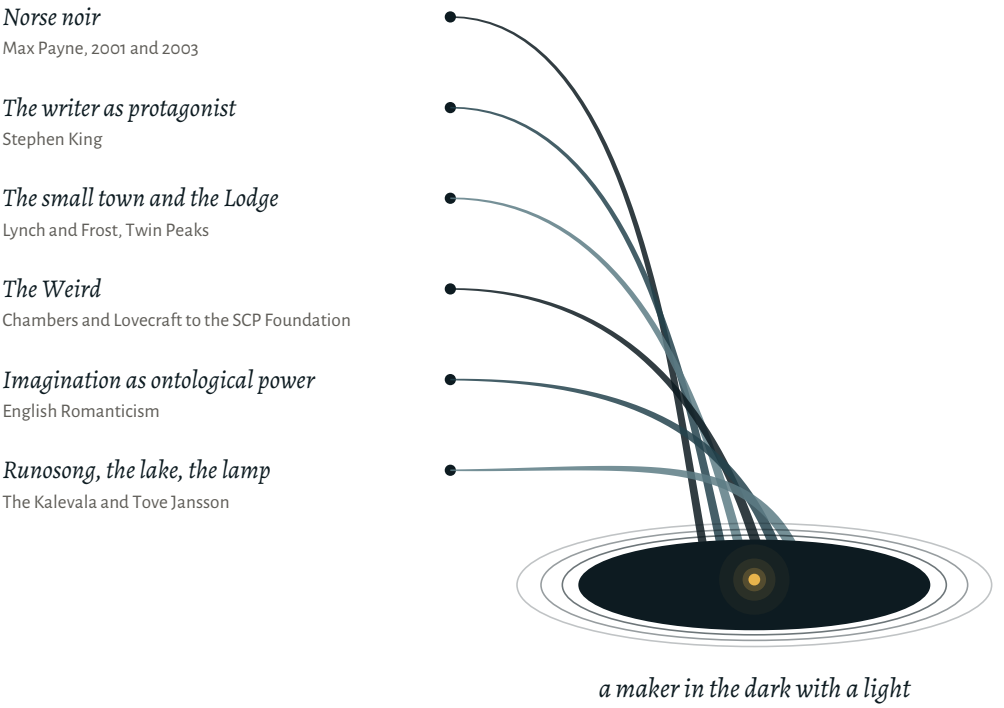


Figure 1.1 Six inheritances converge on one figure: a maker, alone in the dark, holding a light.

Chapter Two

2

Mythic Substrates

2.1 Departure, Initiation, Return

2.2 The cauldron: inspiration, resurrection, prophecy, transmutation

2.3 The Lady of the Lake and the sword that chooses

2.4 Baba Yaga's hut

2.5 Orpheus inverted, Alice through the glass

2.6 Norse onomastics: old gods, Sága, and the tree

2.7 Gnostic and Kabbalistic templates

2.8 The Nail of the North

2.9 Gods of the threshold

2.10 The mythic syntax of the RCU

Beneath its literary genealogies the RCU rests on mythic structures older than any of its acknowledged sources. This chapter excavates nine of them. The claim is not that Lake consulted Snorri or Scholem (though he may have) but that the RCU's narrative constraints, the rules its stories must obey, reproduce with unusual fidelity the constraints of these older systems, and that the parallels therefore illuminate why the RCU's stories take the shapes they do.

ϕ 2.1 Departure, Initiation, Return

Joseph Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949) reduced the world's hero-myths to a single sequence of separation or departure, initiation, and return, itself an adaptation of Arnold van Gennep's tripartite structure of the rite of passage (*séparation*, *marge*, *agrégation*) in *Les Rites de passage* (1909). The RCU's chapter architecture spells the sequence out. The manuscript that drives *Alan Wake* is titled *Departure*. The two halves of *Alan Wake 2* are titled "Initiation" (Alan's chapters in the Dark Place) and "Return" (Saga's chapters in the Pacific Northwest). Thirteen years and two games are required to complete one monomyth.

The distribution of the phases is more revealing than their presence. Campbell's hero departs, is initiated, and returns bearing the boon. In the RCU, the hero who departs and is initiated is not the one who returns: the return belongs to Saga, a second protagonist, who must carry the boon (the manuscript, the means of escape) back across the threshold. The monomyth has been split across two persons, and the split is the first structural sign of the Helical Axiom: the cycle closes only through another. Victor Turner's celebrated essay on the liminal phase, "Betwixt and Between" (1964), described the initiand as structurally invisible, neither what he was nor what he will be. *Alan Wake 2* gives that phase a presiding deity and a television format: *In Between with Mr. Door*, the talk show on which Alan, in the Dark Place, is interviewed about a life he cannot leave.

ϕ 2.2 The cauldron: inspiration, resurrection, prophecy, transmutation

The body of water at the centre of *Alan Wake* is named Cauldron Lake, and four mythic cauldrons converge in it. The first is Norse. Snorri Sturluson's *Skáldskaparmál* tells how the gods, sealing their truce, spat into a vessel and from the spittle made Kvasir, the wisest of beings; how two dwarves murdered Kvasir and brewed his blood with honey into the mead of poetry, kept in a cauldron called Óðrerir and two crocks; and how Odin won the mead by seduction and theft, flew home in eagle's form, and spat it into the gods' vessels, some of it spilling behind him as the portion of bad poets. Poetry in Norse myth is born of a peace treaty and a murder, and its possession is always stolen. The

second is Welsh. In the tale of Taliesin, the witch Ceridwen brews for a year and a day a cauldron of *awen*, poetic inspiration, intended for her son; three drops fall on the servant boy Gwion Bach, who is transformed through a chase of shapes into Taliesin, the greatest of bards. The third is also Welsh, and darker: in the Second Branch of the *Mabinogi*, the *Pair Dadeni*, the cauldron of rebirth, restores dead warriors to fighting life but returns them without the power of speech. Cauldron Lake's revenants, the Taken, return precisely so: animated, violent, and capable only of the fragmentary echo of their former speech. The fourth is Shakespeare's. In *Macbeth*, IV.i, the witches' cauldron ("Double, double toil and trouble; / Fire burn and cauldron bubble") produces the apparitions whose prophecies come true because Macbeth acts on them. The cauldron is the vessel of the self-fulfilling prophecy, and *Departure* is a self-fulfilling prophecy in manuscript.

Behind all four stands the alchemical *vas hermeticum*, the sealed vessel in which matter is dissolved into the *nigredo*, the blackening, in order to be recomposed. Cauldron Lake performs all five functions: it grants inspiration (artists come to Bright Falls for it), resurrection (Thomas Zane writes the drowned Barbara Jagger back to life), prophecy (the manuscript foretells), and transmutation (the Taken), and it begins every transformation in blackness. A fortuitous resonance may be admitted under the protocol of amplification: the Welsh *awen*, inspiration, sounds within the Bureau's acronym for the events the Lake causes, AWE.

ϕ 2.3 The Lady of the Lake and the sword that chooses

The Arthurian matter supplies the RCU's theory of sovereignty. In Malory's *Le Morte d'Arthur* (1485), the sword drawn from the stone proclaims the rightful king, and Excalibur is given by an arm rising from a lake and, at the end, returned to it by Bedivere. Legitimacy comes from an object that chooses its bearer and that belongs, finally, to the water. *Control*'s Service Weapon is an Excalibur in the idiom of federal procurement: a shape-shifting Object of Power through which the Board chooses the Bureau's Director, so that whoever the Board chooses to wield it is, by default, Director. Jesse Faden becomes Director not by appointment but by election, in the old sense of being chosen, when the weapon accepts her. The Arthurian ending supplies the RCU's eschatology as well: Arthur is carried by boat to Avalon, the once and future king, as Väinämöinen sails away in his copper boat. Both are departures under promise of return, and the RCU's own hero sits for thirteen years beneath a lake as a once and future writer. Barbara Jagger is the Lady of the Lake in her malign aspect, the woman of the water who arms the wrong hand; Cynthia Weaver, keeper of the lit room, is her benign counterpart.

ϕ 2.4 Baba Yaga's hut

The cabin on Diver's Isle in which Alan and Alice stay is the Bird Leg Cabin, and its antagonist is Barbara Jagger. The phonetic and iconographic echo of Baba Yaga, the witch of Slavic folklore whose hut stands on chicken legs in the forest, is generally taken to be deliberate, and the folklore illuminates the plot. In Alexander Afanasyev's "Vasilisa the Beautiful," all the lights in a house are extinguished and the heroine is sent into the forest to Baba Yaga to fetch fire; she returns bearing a skull whose eyes blaze, and its light burns her persecutors to ash. The quest for light from the witch of darkness is the plot of *Alan Wake* reduced to its kernel. Vladimir Propp, in *Historical Roots of the Wonder Tale* (1946), read Baba Yaga's hut as the threshold of the realm of the dead and her tests as the residue of initiation rites: the hero who reaches her has entered the liminal zone that the RCU stages as the Dark Place. The hut must be addressed with a formula (turn your back to the forest, your front to me) before it can be entered; the RCU's thresholds likewise yield only to the right words.

ϕ 2.5 Orpheus inverted, Alice through the glass

The Orphic myth, in Virgil's fourth *Georgic* and the tenth and eleventh books of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, tells of a poet who descends to the underworld to recover his wife by the power of song, loses her by looking back, and is later torn apart by maenads, his severed head floating down the Hebrus still singing. *Alan Wake* is the Orphic myth inverted. The writer descends into dark water to recover his wife by the power of writing; he succeeds, but the price of her return is that he remain below. Eurydice ascends; Orpheus stays. And Orpheus's singing head is the manuscript: a voice that continues to arrive from below, detached from a body that cannot follow it. The wife's name compounds the allusion. Lewis Carroll's *Through the Looking-Glass* (1871) closes with a chapter titled "Which Dreamed It?", in which Alice cannot determine whether she dreamed the Red King or he dreamed her. The question of who dreams whom, who writes whom, is the question of *Alan Wake 2*, and the Lake, which reflects before it swallows, is its looking-glass.

ϕ 2.6 Norse onomastics: old gods, Sága, and the tree

The Norse code of *Max Payne* becomes in Bright Falls a pantheon in retirement. Odin and Tor Anderson, once the heavy-metal band the Old Gods of Asgard, whose albums encode the lore of the Lake, live in *Alan Wake 2* in the Valhalla Nursing Home. Neil Gaiman's *American Gods* (2001), in which immigrant deities survive in diminished American forms for as long as belief sustains them, is the obvious comparison, and the RCU shares its theology: gods are real in proportion to the attention paid them, which is also the theory of the Objects of Power. The FBI profiler who comes to Bright Falls bears a name that

completes the pantheon. In the eddic *Grímnismál*, Sága is the goddess whose hall is Sökkvabekkr, the "sunken bench," where cool waters flow and where she and Odin drink every day from golden cups. A goddess named Story, who dwells by the water and keeps company with Odin, arrives in a town on a lake and learns from Tor and Odin Anderson that they are her grandfather and grand-uncle, and that her intuitive gift, the capacity to perceive reality as the manuscript rewrites it, is their inheritance. Odin's own myth supplies the RCU's theory of the cost of writing: in the *Hávamál* he hangs nine nights on the wind-swept tree, wounded by his own spear, given to himself, to win the runes. The script is bought by self-sacrifice in suspension, between worlds; Alan buys his power to write reality by self-sacrifice beneath the Lake, and the sequel's murderers call themselves the Cult of the Tree. Odin's ravens, Huginn and Muninn, Thought and Memory, return as the possessed crows of the first game, assaulting a writer who has lost his memory. And Heimdall, who sounds Gjallarhorn to herald Ragnarök, finds his inversion in the musical number of *Alan Wake 2* in which Alan and Mr. Door perform the Old Gods' "Herald of Darkness," a hymn to the double who heralds the dark. Lake's first villain, Nicole Horne, bears a name that has been read as an allusion to the same horn (§1.1).

ϕ 2.7 Gnostic and Kabbalistic templates

Three esoteric cosmogonies illuminate the RCU's account of a creation that has gone wrong. The first is the Gnostic *Hymn of the Pearl*, preserved in the apocryphal *Acts of Thomas*. A prince is sent from the East into Egypt to retrieve a pearl from the sea, where a serpent guards it; he puts on Egyptian garments, eats Egyptian food, and forgets who he is; his parents send a letter that flies to him and becomes a voice commanding him to awake; he remembers, subdues the serpent by speaking his father's name, takes the pearl, and returns, where he is clothed in a robe in which he sees himself as in a mirror. Amnesia, a letter from beyond, a command to wake, a serpent in the depths, a reconciliation with one's double: the *Hymn* is the Gnostic outline of *Alan Wake*. That it belongs to the *Acts of Thomas*, and that the poet who dove into Cauldron Lake was Thomas Zane, is a resonance to be flagged as fortuitous and kept.

The second is the Sethian myth of Sophia in the *Apocryphon of John*. Sophia, the lowest of the divine emanations, conceives without her consort, and her unpaired thought becomes Yaldabaoth, the ignorant demiurge who believes himself the only god and imprisons spirit in matter. Creation without a partner produces a monster. When Thomas Zane writes Barbara Jagger back from the Lake alone, out of grief and without balance, he repeats Sophia's error, and what returns is the Dark Presence wearing a beloved form.

The third is the Lurianic Kabbalah of sixteenth-century Safed, as reconstructed by Gershom Scholem. To make room for the world, the infinite contracts (*tzimtzum*), leaving a void; into the void it emanates light; the vessels meant to hold the light shatter

(*shevirat ha-kelim*), and sparks of light fall into the world trapped in husks or shells (*kelipot*); the human task is repair (*tikkun*), the liberation of the sparks. The Taken of *Alan Wake* are exactly such husked sparks: human cores encased in a shield of darkness that light must burn away before they can be met at all. The Bureau's cleansing of Control Points in the Oldest House is *tikkun* as administrative procedure, and the Objects of Power are shards of broken vessels still holding their light. The Kabbalistic golem, animated by the word *emet* (truth) inscribed on its brow and stilled when the first letter is erased to leave *met* (dead), is the Taken's ancestor: a body animated by writing and undone by its revision. And the *Sefer Yetzirah*'s cosmos, built from the permutations of twenty-two letters, is the cosmology the RCU takes for granted.

ϕ 2.8 The Nail of the North

The entity bonded to Jesse Faden since childhood is called Polaris, and the name opens onto a cosmology the Finnic peoples shared before Christianization. In that worldview the firmament rested on a gigantic pillar, tree, or mountain around whose top the sky turned; Estonians imagined the sky as an upturned cauldron with a nail fixed to its bottom, on which it revolved, and called that nail, identified with the North Star, *põhjanael*, "the nail of the north" (Britannica; Estonian Folklore Archives). In Finnish the North Star is *Pohjantähti*, and the world pillar was thought to rest on it (Wikipedia); a Sámi name for the pole star has been recorded as *boahenavlle*, glossed as "the nail of the north" (arXiv: 0910.0560). *Control*'s vertical cosmology reproduces the scheme with remarkable exactness: the Board above, in the Astral Plane; the Foundation below, where the *Foundation* expansion is organized around an immense structure called the Nail; the House between them as world-pillar; and Polaris, the guiding light, at the apex. The *Kalevala*'s Sampo completes the parallel: its churning, star-studded lid has been read as the celestial vault turning on the world's axis, and the mill itself as that axis, a cosmic pillar whose name may be cognate with the Sanskrit *skambha*, "pillar" (Britannica; Wikipedia). Mircea Eliade's *axis mundi*, the sacred centre where heaven, earth, and underworld communicate, is the comparative category, and *Control* is its most rigorous instance in contemporary fiction. That an episode of *Night Springs* centred on a figure called the Sister is titled "North Star" confirms that the star is a name and not merely a light.

The Finnic cosmos has a lower half as well, and it belongs to *Alan Wake*. In the tradition reconstructed, according to a tertiary summary that this study has not been able to check against the originals, by E. N. Setälä (*Sammon arvoitus*, 1932) and Martti Haavio (*Väinämöinen*, 1950), the North Star is the nail joining the sky's dome to the world pillar, whose foot stands in the Arctic sea; the pillar's rotation churns there a great whirlpool, Kinahmi, through which one may descend to Tuonela, the land of the dead (Simple English Wikipedia). The two franchises thus divide a single cosmology between them. *Con-*

trol is the axis: nail, pillar, and star. *Alan Wake* is the cauldron and the vortex at the axis's foot: a dark water that opens downward onto the realm of the dead. The Estonian image of the sky as an upturned cauldron makes Cauldron Lake its precise inversion, a cauldron turned right side up, holding darkness where the sky holds stars. The Lake is the firmament's reflection, and its depth is the sky's underside.

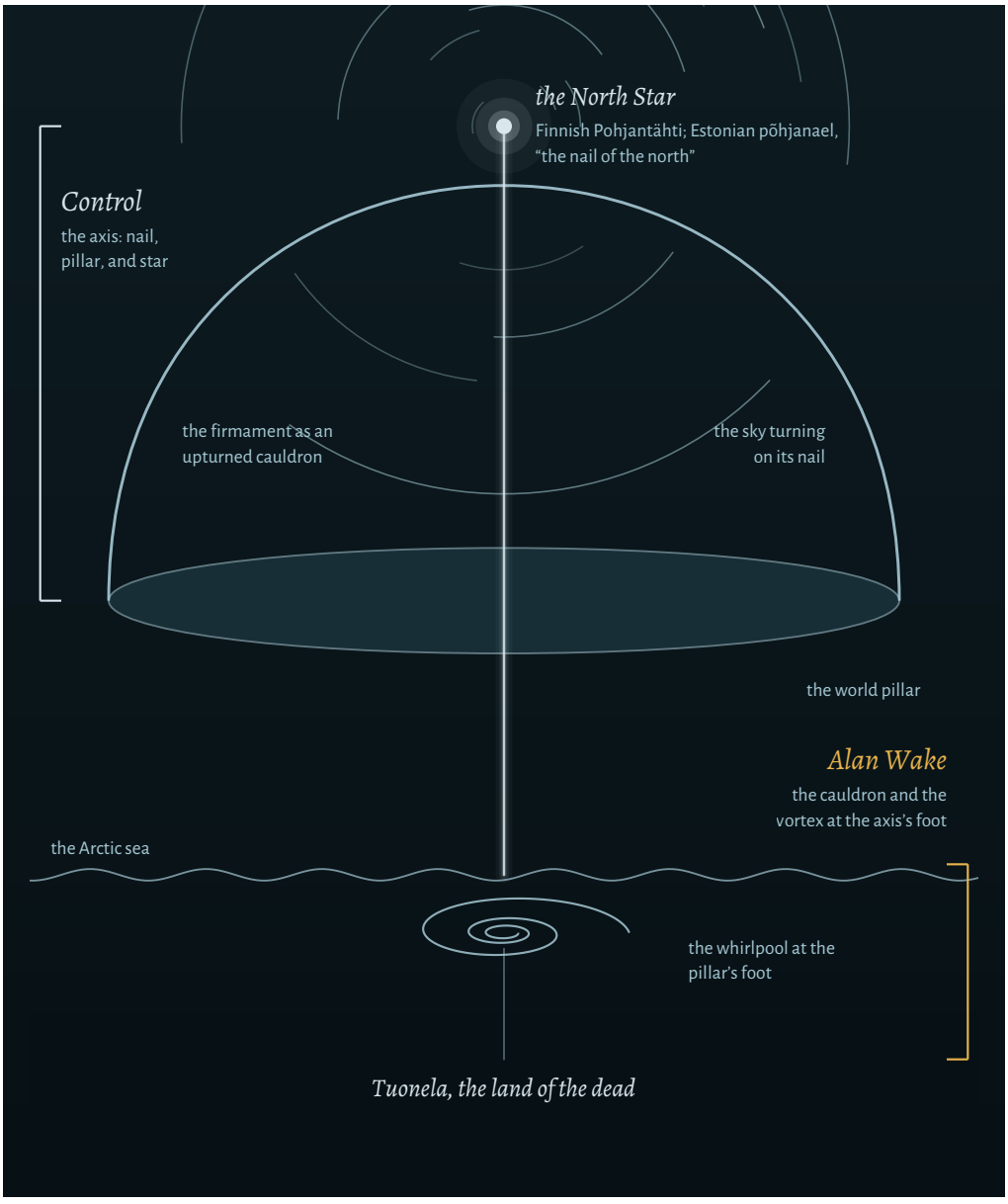


Figure 2.1 One cosmology, divided between two franchises. The sky turns on the North Star as on a nail; the world pillar descends to a whirlpool at its foot. *Control* takes the axis; *Alan Wake*, the cauldron and the vortex.

Tradition adds a rule that the RCU obeys to the letter: the living visited Tuonela to gather knowledge and spells, but once there they were not allowed to leave (Wikipedia). In the *Kalevala*, Väinämöinen descends to Tuonela in search of the words he lacks and escapes only by transformation; Alan descends for words and remains for thirteen years.

ϕ 2.9 Gods of the threshold

The RCU is crowded with doorkeepers. Mr. Door, host of *In Between*, unites the Roman Janus, two-faced god of doorways, beginnings, and transitions, with Hermes, god of boundaries, messages, and the passage of souls. He also recalls Kafka's parable "Before the Law" (1915), in which a man waits his whole life before a door guarded by a doorkeeper, only to be told at death that the door was meant for him alone; the Oldest House, which admits only those it calls, is that door opened. Blake supplied the doorway's epistemology in *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell* (1790–1793): "If the doors of perception were cleansed every thing would appear to man as it is, infinite." Aldous Huxley borrowed the phrase for his account of mescaline (1954), and a band borrowed it from Huxley; Mr. Door's name inherits the whole lineage. The Oldest House has its own doorkeeper in Ahti, the water god who mops its floors, and here etymology seals the comparison: *janitor* derives from the Latin *ianitor*, doorkeeper, from *ianua*, door, the word that names Janus. The janitor of the Oldest House and the host of *In Between* are cognate figures, the RCU's two keepers of the threshold, one a god of the waters working as a custodian, the other a god of passages working as a host.

Mr. Door's most exact analogue, however, is Legba. In Haitian Vodou, Legba (Papa Legba) is the lwa of gates and crossroads, saluted first in every ceremony so that he will open the way for the other spirits; Maya Deren's *Divine Horsemen* (1953) describes him as the guardian of the gate between the human and the divine. His office is precisely that of a host who opens every broadcast by admitting those who cross onto his stage. The comparison carries a history that must be named rather than avoided. Missionary translation equated Legba's Yoruba cognate, Èṣù, with Satan, and a related demonization survives in the American legend of the Devil at the crossroads (§6.2). The RCU's Mr. Door, whose full name the sequel gives as Warlin Door and who is played by the Black British actor David Harewood, inherits the gatekeeper's office without the missionary's caricature. He is neither devil nor servant but a sovereign host, courteous, ambiguous, and entirely in command of his threshold, and the *Night Springs* episode "Time Breaker" makes him, with Alan, a master of many worlds (Wikipedia).

The sequel stages the etymology. In the first chapter of Alan's descent, Ahti, addressing Alan as "Tom," tells him that the writer left something in the basement that could help him and hands him the key; in the basement Alan finds the Angel Lamp (Alan Wake

Wiki). The janitor is the doorkeeper, and the key he hands over opens onto light. That he calls the author by the name of the poet who preceded him is taken up in Chapter Six.

ϕ 2.10 The mythic syntax of the RCU

The nine substrates compose a syntax with five rules. A descent through water leads to an underworld of origins. A vessel at the bottom grants inspiration, prophecy, and resurrection, but only at a price. A sovereign object confers legitimacy on whoever it chooses. A keeper guards every threshold and must be answered correctly. And the return requires another, because the one who descends cannot come back unaided. These rules are not decoration. They are the constraints within which every RCU narrative must move, and Chapters Three through Five derive the RCU's ontology, its theory of fiction, and its temporality from them.

Chapter Three

3



Limnopoiesis

The Lake as Receptacle, Ground, and Appetite

3.1 Darkness as substance
3.2 The Lake as *khôra*
3.3 The dark ground
3.4 The hunger of the dark
3.5 Potential space and the floating signifier
3.6 Light as form, light as attention
3.7 From lake to ocean
3.8 Dark ecology: the Lake as hyperobject
3.9 Definition

This chapter formalizes the Lacustrine Axiom. It argues that the RCU's darkness is a substance rather than a privation; that the Lake is best understood as a receptacle in Plato's sense and a ground in Schelling's; that its defining property is appetite; that the RCU's light is the principle of form and, procedurally, of attention; and that the passage from lake to ocean names the RCU's own movement from authorship to audience.

ϕ 3.1 Darkness as substance

The dominant tradition of Western metaphysics denies darkness any being of its own. For Augustine, evil and its emblem darkness are *privatio boni*, the absence of a good that ought to be present; for Newton, darkness is the absence of light, and colour is light divided. The RCU belongs to the dissenting tradition. Goethe's *Theory of Colours* (1810), written against Newton, held that colour arises at the boundary of light and darkness, which are polar and equally active; darkness is not nothing but a pole. Milton's hell is lit by "No light, but rather darkness visible." Tolkien's Ungoliant, the spider who devours the light of the Two Trees in *The Silmarillion* (1977), weaves an Unlight that seems a thing with being of its own, which blinds and can be felt. The RCU's darkness is of this kind. It coats the Taken as a shield; it has thickness, since the beam of a flashlight must burn it away over measurable seconds before any bullet can wound; it has resistance, since stronger Taken carry deeper coats; it has mobility, since it possesses birds, machines, and furniture. The game's procedural rhetoric, in Ian Bogost's term for the arguments that systems make through their rules, asserts this ontology every time the player fights: darkness is a material with properties.

Yet the RCU's darkness is not a rival god. It has no form of its own, no face but those it borrows (Barbara Jagger's, Mr. Scratch's, Alan's), no voice but the echoes of the people it takes. It is Plotinus's matter, the formless darkness at the bottom of emanation that receives forms without possessing any, with one decisive amendment. Plotinian matter is inert. The RCU's darkness wants.

ϕ 3.2 The Lake as *khôra*

In the *Timaeus* (48e–52d), Plato is compelled to posit a third kind beside the eternal forms and their perishable copies: the receptacle, *khôra*, which he calls the nurse of becoming. It must itself be formless in order to receive all forms, as the base of a perfume must be odourless or the material for impressions smooth; it is likened to a mother; and it is apprehended not by reason or sensation but by a kind of bastard reasoning, as in a dream. Derrida's essay "Khōra" (1993) radicalized the figure: *khôra* gives place without being anything, resists every either/or, and cannot be appropriated by the concepts it makes room for.

Cauldron Lake is *khôra* given a shoreline. It is the place in which the manuscript's events become actual, while being itself nothing that the manuscript describes; it receives whatever form an artist gives it; it is apprehended as in a dream, which is to say as Alan apprehends the week he cannot remember and the manuscript he cannot recall writing. The *Timaeus*'s maternal figure is preserved too, in a form this dissertation criticizes in Chapter Six: the women of the RCU's first decade (Barbara Jagger, drowned and returned; Alice, taken into the water) are made to embody the receptacle rather than to act upon it.

ϕ 3.3 The dark ground

Plato's receptacle is passive. To explain the RCU's appetite, one must turn to the theosophical tradition that runs from Jakob Böhme to Schelling. Böhme's *Ungrund*, the groundless abyss prior to God, contains the will to self-manifestation from which both a dark fire and a light fire proceed; light can only reveal itself against darkness, which is not its enemy but its condition. Schelling's *Philosophical Investigations into the Essence of Human Freedom* (1809) transformed this vision into a theory of evil. In God, Schelling distinguishes existence from the ground of existence, a nature in God that is not God himself: a dark longing, *Sehnsucht*, to give birth to itself, which never wholly dissolves into understanding but persists as an irreducible remainder. Order consists in the subordination of the ground's particular will to the universal will of the word. Evil is not an independent substance but the inversion of this order: the ground's self-will raised above the word.

The Schellingian model resolves the RCU's apparent dualism. The RCU is not Manichaean; it does not stage a war between two substances. It stages one principle in two potencies, the dark ground and the illuminating word, whose *ordering* decides good and evil. The Dark Presence is the ground's longing for articulation. When articulation proceeds under balance, the longing becomes creation; when the ground's will governs the word (when Zane writes from grief, when Hartman writes from ambition, when Scratch writes from appetite), the result is the Taken, the cult, the double. Slavoj Žižek's *The Indivisible Remainder* (1996) read Schelling as the philosopher of the remainder that symbolic order can never absorb; the RCU's Lake is that remainder with a beach.

ϕ 3.4 The hunger of the dark

The property that distinguishes the RCU's darkness from its philosophical antecedents is appetite, and its fictional antecedents are instructive precisely where they differ. Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) imagines an ocean that reads the minds of the scientists orbiting it and returns their dead to them: Kelvin's wife, who had taken her own life, comes back imperfect, grows more human, and finally chooses her own unmaking. The ocean

returns Barbara Jagger to Thomas Zane in exactly this way. But Lem's ocean is the emblem of an intelligence that does not wish to be understood; its gifts are experiments, not desires. King's pool in *Lisey's Story* is a source from which writers draw; it does not draw them. The Pale of *Disco Elysium* (2019), an entropic grey that erodes reality and memory between the world's landmasses, is the Dark Place's nearest relative in game form, but it is erosion without longing.

The RCU's darkness hungers, and what it hungers for is narration. The appropriate figure is not Lem's but Jansson's: the Groke, who freezes the ground she sits on and comes to the lamp not to extinguish it but because she is lonely and wants its warmth. Psychoanalytically, the RCU inverts the Lacanian Real. Lacan's Real is what resists symbolization absolutely. The RCU's Real *demands* symbolization; it presses toward the writer and the singer because only in their forms can it exist at all. This is the precise content of the term introduced in Chapter One, the narrative Weird: a cosmos whose outside is not beyond meaning but famished for it. Its horror is not that we are insignificant but that we are indispensable.

ϕ 3.5 Potential space and the floating signifier

Two twentieth-century concepts complete the ontology. The first is D. W. Winnicott's. In "Transitional Objects and Transitional Phenomena" (1953), Winnicott described the infant's first "not-me" possession, the blanket or soft toy that is neither wholly inner nor wholly outer and about which the infant must never be asked whether it was created or found. In *Playing and Reality* (1971), he extended the concept to a potential space, an intermediate area of experience that persists in adult life in the arts, religion, imaginative living, and creative science. The RCU's emblematic weapon is a transitional object in the strictest clinical sense: the Clicker, a light switch that Alan's mother gave him as a child to ward off his fear of the dark, which becomes in both games the decisive instrument against the Dark Presence. And the Lake is a potential space that has become ontological. Winnicott's forbidden question (did you make this or find it?) is the question *Alan Wake* refuses to settle about its manuscript, which Alan both wrote and found.

The object's provenance deepens the point. In the first game's lore, the Clicker is a light switch cut from the Angel Lamp of the poet Thomas Zane, who left it in a shoebox in Cynthia Weaver's keeping and wrote that it would one day reach Alan and be used to banish the Dark Presence; a manuscript page in Zane's hand, left with it, narrates the very childhood gift by which Alan's mother gave him the switch at seven to help him sleep (Alan Wake Wiki; Alan Wake Wiki). The transitional object is authored by a precursor: the child's first defence against the dark appears in an older poet's writing. Harold Bloom's *apophrades* (Introduction) is here reversed with a vengeance. The dead poet

does not merely seem to imitate the latecomer; he has written the latecomer's childhood.

The second concept is Claude Lévi-Strauss's. In his *Introduction to the Work of Marcel Mauss* (1950), Lévi-Strauss argued that notions like *mana* function as floating signifiers: terms of zero symbolic value, empty in themselves, which can therefore receive any content and which make symbolic thought possible by absorbing the surplus of signification over signified. The Dark Presence is the floating signifier hypostatized. It has no content of its own and therefore takes any content a story gives it; it is the cosmos's zero term, the place-holder that allows meaning to circulate and that, ungoverned, absorbs every meaning into itself. Chapter Seven returns to Lévi-Strauss to explain the Objects of Power.

ϕ 3.6 Light as form, light as attention

Against this receptacle the RCU sets light, and its light is overdetermined. It is Plato's sun, which in the sixth and seventh books of the *Republic* makes things visible and knowable and stands for the Good. It is Robert Grosseteste's light in *De Luce* (c. 1225), the first corporeal form, which by diffusing itself from a point generates the dimensions of the cosmos. It is the light of Genesis, created by speech, so that light and word are coeval: the Clicker is *fiat lux* in the form of a switch. And it is Heidegger's *Lichtung*. In "The Origin of the Work of Art" (1935–1936), Heidegger described truth as unconcealment occurring in a clearing, the open region in which beings can show themselves, and he insisted on the German word's double sense of a forest clearing and a lighting. The flashlight of *Alan Wake* is a portable *Lichtung*: in the Pacific Northwest forest it opens a clearing in which beings are unconcealed, their shield of darkness burned off, before they can be encountered at all. The ordering of the combat (light first, then weapon) is a procedural statement of Heidegger's priority of disclosure over handling.

The RCU's light is also attention. To focus the beam is to concentrate regard, and the system rewards concentration with revelation. Simone Weil held that attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity; the RCU makes it the first form of power. *Control* generalizes the principle into a Berkeleyan physics. George Berkeley's *Principles of Human Knowledge* (1710) held that, for unthinking things, *esse* is *percipi*: to be is to be perceived. Among the Bureau's Altered Items is a rubber duck that will not stay where it is put and a 1960s "Arctic Queen" refrigerator kept under the unbroken gaze of an agent locked in a cell with it (§7.4), so that keeping a thing in its place becomes a form of continuous attention; attention is ontological maintenance. The keeper of light in *Alan Wake* bears a name that compresses the whole doctrine. Cynthia is an epithet of Artemis, the moon, light in darkness; Weaver recalls the Norns who weave fate at the well beneath the world-tree; and she guards a Well-Lit Room, a well filled not with water but with light.

ϕ 3.7 From lake to ocean

The closing line of *Alan Wake*, "It's not a lake, it's an ocean," is, read philosophically, the passage from the personal to the collective unconscious. Jung's personal unconscious is the sediment of an individual's repressions; the collective unconscious is the inherited depth of archetypes common to the species. *Control* makes the collective unconscious the explicit, in-world source of Altered World Events and Objects of Power: what was in *Alan Wake* the private power of one writer on one lake becomes, in the Oldest House, the public power of collective belief condensing into things. The line thus describes the RCU's own trajectory, from the authorial lake of the first game to the collective ocean of the Bureau. Coleridge's sacred river runs down to a sunless sea; Heinrich Zimmer's retelling of the Markandeya legend (1946) describes the sage falling from the mouth of Vishnu into the cosmic ocean, where he sees the god asleep, dreaming the world. The RCU's ocean is that dream-sea.

And here the Auto-mythographic Axiom first surfaces. The author's name is Lake. The ocean is everyone else. *Control* is, among other things, a theory of audiences: a world in which ordinary objects become sacred through the accumulated attention of multitudes, exactly as fandom sacralizes the props, cameos, and catchphrases of the works it loves. The tagline marks the moment the RCU understood that its power derived not from its author but from its readers.

ϕ 3.8 Dark ecology: the Lake as hyperobject

The Lacustrine Axiom has an ecological reading that the corpus invites. Bright Falls is a Pacific Northwest town of forests, a lake, and tourism, and its horror arrives from the landscape itself, in the tradition of Algernon Blackwood's "The Willows" (1907), in which two canoeists on the Danube sense an alien presence among the reeds, and "The Wendigo" (1910), Blackwood's settler borrowing of an Algonquian figure, in which a hunting guide is carried off by something in the northern woods. Timothy Morton's *Hyperobjects* (2013) named entities so massively distributed in time and space (global warming, radioactive waste) that they can be encountered only in local manifestations, and assigned them five properties: they are viscous, nonlocal, temporally undulating, phased, and interobjective. The Dark Presence has all five. It clings to what it touches; it is not located in the Lake so much as manifested there, and in the Oldest House, and in Manhattan; it acts across decades; it appears only in phases (a Taken, a possessed flock of crows, a possessed machine); and it exists only in the relations among the objects it animates.

Morton's *Dark Ecology* (2016) argued that ecological awareness has the form of a loop and the genre of noir, in which the detective discovers that he is the criminal, as Oedipus did. *Alan Wake 2* is that noir: the writer investigating a murderous double discovers that

the double is himself, and the profiler discovers that she has been written into the case. The Bureau's name for its catastrophes completes the reading. An Altered World Event is, literally, a change in the world produced by collective human mental activity: the Anthropocene in miniature, with the Bureau as its geoengineering agency, managing effects whose cause it shares with the species it protects.

ϕ 3.9 Definition

Limnopoiesis may now be defined. It is the precipitation of world at the illuminated interface between a receptive and appetitive darkness and a formal act (writing, singing, painting, filming, filing), under conditions of attention and at a cost. Its receptacle is *khôra*; its energy is the ground's longing; its forms are given by makers; its medium is light; its price is set by balance. Chapter Four examines the forms; Chapter Five, the time in which they recur; Chapter Eight, the price.



Figure 3.1 Limnopoiesis in section: the precipitation of world at the illuminated interface between a receptive, appetitive darkness and a formal act, under conditions of attention and at a cost.

Chapter Four

4

The Word Made World

Narrative Causation, Genre as Law, and the Gothic of Media

4.1 Logos, deed, spell
4.2 The philosophy of fiction, literalized
4.3 Hrönir and their kin
4.4 The law of genre
4.5 The Gothic of media
4.6 Summary: a theory of fiction in four propositions

If Chapter Three described the receptacle, this chapter describes the forms it receives. It situates the RCU's narrative causation within the long history of performative language, tests it against the analytic philosophy of fiction, isolates its most original feature (the subordination of narrative power to plausibility and genre), and reads its preference for obsolete analog media as a theory of the trace.

ϕ 4.1 Logos, deed, spell

The prologue of the Fourth Gospel opens with the word that was in the beginning, and the RCU belongs to the long tradition that takes this literally. In the Memphite Theology inscribed on the Shabaka Stone, Ptah creates by conceiving the world in his heart and pronouncing it with his tongue. The *Sefer Yetzirah* builds the cosmos from the permutations of letters. The *Kalevala* makes song the instrument of power. Goethe's Faust, alone in his study, retranslates the Gospel's first verse four times, rejecting Word, then Sense, then Power, and settling on Deed: *Im Anfang war die Tat*. The RCU's manuscript is the point at which Faust's alternatives cease to be alternatives; in Bright Falls, the word is the deed.

The occult tradition gives the convergence its technical vocabulary. The English "spell" names both the incantation and the act of ordering letters, and "grimoire" descends from the Old French *grammaire*: grammar and sorcery are etymological kin. Aleister Crowley defined magick as the art of causing change in conformity with will, and Alan Moore has repeatedly argued that art and magic are the same discipline, the manipulation of symbols to change consciousness and therefore the world. Grant Morrison described *The Invisibles* (1994–2000) as a hypersigil, a fiction composed to alter its author's life, and reported that it had done so. Alan Wake's manuscript is a hypersigil whose effects are not psychological but physical.

And yet the RCU's magic differs from all of these at a decisive point. Crowley's magick acts by will; Morrison's hypersigil by intention. The manuscript acts by *plausibility*. Alan cannot simply write that Alice is free; he must write a story in which her freedom follows, a story that the world will accept as coherent. The RCU's word is not sovereign. It is answerable to the logic of the story it inhabits.

ϕ 4.2 The philosophy of fiction, literalized

The analytic philosophy of fiction supplies a precise vocabulary for what the RCU does, and the RCU, in turn, supplies a thought experiment that strains that vocabulary to the limit. Kendall Walton's *Mimesis as Make-Believe* (1990) argued that fictions are props in games of make-believe, generating fictional truths by principles of generation: in a children's game a tree stump counts as a bear, and the stump's location makes it fictionally

true that a bear is there. The RCU is the world in which the stump becomes a bear. Its props generate actual truths; Walton's props are the ancestors of the Objects of Power.

John Searle's *The Construction of Social Reality* (1995) analysed institutional facts (money, property, borders, marriages) by the formula "X counts as Y in context C": a piece of paper counts as currency in the United States because collective intentionality assigns it a status function. The Oldest House is a context in which status functions become physical: a rubber duck counts as a teleporting entity, and it teleports. The sociologist W. I. Thomas had already stated the principle in 1928: if people define situations as real, they are real in their consequences. Robert K. Merton's self-fulfilling prophecy (1948), the false rumour of insolvency that causes the bank run it predicts, is the Thomas theorem's dynamic form, and *Departure* is a self-fulfilling prophecy that has been typed.

David Lewis, in "Truth in Fiction" (1978), proposed that what is true in a fiction is what would be true in the worlds closest to ours in which the story is told as known fact; his later modal realism in *On the Plurality of Worlds* (1986) granted all possible worlds equal reality. In Bright Falls the closest such world is the actual one, and the multiverse of *Night Springs*, in which a waitress, a sister, and an actor wander between versions of reality, is Lewis's plurality of worlds with a television schedule. Amie Thomasson's *Fiction and Metaphysics* (1999) defended fictional characters as abstract artifacts, created by authors and dependent on texts and readers for their persistence; Mr. Scratch is such an artifact that has acquired a body. Nelson Goodman's *Ways of Worldmaking* (1978) held that we make worlds by making versions of them; the RCU removes the metaphor. Hans Vaihinger's *Philosophy of "As If"* (1911) defended fictions as indispensable instruments that know themselves to be false; the RCU is the universe in which the "as if" has been deleted.

ϕ 4.3 Hrönir and their kin

The richest precursors of narrative causation are fictional. Jorge Luis Borges's "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) imagines a secret society that invents a planet and writes its encyclopedia, until objects from Tlön begin to appear in our world and our world begins to become Tlön. On Tlön itself exist *hrönir*, duplicate objects produced by expectation: searchers find what they expect to find. The *hrönir* are Objects of Power avant la lettre, and Borges's postscript, in which reality yields to a fiction because the fiction is orderly and the world is not, is the RCU's political warning in miniature.

Umberto Eco wrote two novels on the theme. In *The Name of the Rose* (1980), William of Baskerville hypothesizes that a series of murders follows the pattern of the Apocalypse; the hypothesis is wrong, but the murderer, learning of it, adopts it, so that interpretation produces the pattern it sought. In *Foucault's Pendulum* (1988), three editors invent an occult Plan as an intellectual game; believers take it seriously and kill for it. Ursula K. Le

Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971), whose protagonist's dreams alter reality retroactively and whose psychiatrist exploits them to improve the world, is so precise a precursor of *Alan Wake*'s clinic that Chapter Seven treats it at length. Julio Cortázar's "Continuity of Parks" (1956 or 1964; sources differ on its first edition) compresses the whole theme into a page: a man reading a novel in a green velvet armchair is approached from behind by the novel's murderer. Terry Pratchett's Discworld formalized the principle as *narrativium*, the element of story that bends events toward narrative shape, and *Witches Abroad* (1991) made its villain a fairy godmother who forces people into the roles their stories require.

Philip K. Dick wrote the darkest versions of the theme. In *Ubik* (1969), the members of a team who believe their employer killed in a bombing find their world regressing toward older forms while messages from him appear on washroom walls, matchbook covers, and television commercials: writing that arrives from across the border of death, as Alan's manuscript arrives from beneath the Lake. In *The Man in the High Castle* (1962), the inhabitants of an alternate history read a banned novel describing an Allied victory, and the oracle they consult tells them that the novel is truer than their world. In *VALIS* (1981), a Gnostic revelation discloses that the Roman Empire never ended and that history is a prison, the Black Iron Prison, from which only knowledge frees its captives. Dick supplies what the RCU's Gnostic templates (Chapter Two) presuppose: the suspicion that the world itself is a text that one must read one's way out of.

The RCU synthesizes these precursors and adds one element none of them possesses fully: the reader. In Borges, Eco, and Le Guin, the fiction acts through its author, its believers, or its dreamer. In *Alan Wake 2*, it acts through being *read*: the manuscript pages Saga collects are the means by which the story enters her world, and her reading is the condition of its taking effect. Chapter Five develops the consequence.

ϕ 4.4 The law of genre

The RCU's most original contribution to the theory of narrative causation is its insistence that narrative power is constrained by genre. *Alan Wake 2* makes the constraint explicit: the story by which Alan may escape the Dark Place must be a horror story, and a horror story requires victims. The writer cannot write a happy ending into the wrong genre; the world will not accept it. Genre is not a style. It is a physics.

Derrida's "The Law of Genre" (1980) begins with the injunction that genres are not to be mixed and proceeds to show that every text participates in genre without belonging to it, that the mark of genre is itself outside every genre, and that the law of genre is therefore haunted by its own contamination. The RCU dramatizes both halves of Derrida's argument. Its stories obey generic law with fatal strictness (a horror story must have its deaths), yet the corpus as a whole is a generic contaminant, a survival-horror game containing a rock opera, a musical number, a talk show, a sitcom laugh-track, and

a Finnish coffee commercial. Tzvetan Todorov's *The Fantastic* (1970) defined its object as the reader's hesitation between a natural explanation (the uncanny) and a supernatural one (the marvellous); *Alan Wake* sustains this hesitation for most of its length (is Alan mad?), and then the game system's physics resolves it, since the player's flashlight demonstrably burns. Mikhail Bakhtin's chronotope, the fused time-space that defines a genre, supplies the RCU's geography: Bright Falls is the idyllic chronotope of the small town, and the Dark Place, with its corridors and elevators and doors, is the chronotope Bakhtin found in Dostoevsky, the threshold, where time is the instant of crisis and decision.

The law of genre distinguishes the RCU's metafiction from its postmodern ancestors. Postmodern metafiction typically demonstrates that because a work is fiction, anything can happen in it. The RCU demonstrates the opposite: because a world is fiction, only certain things can happen in it, those its genre permits. This is also a comment on games. A game system is a genre that has become a physics, and the RCU's insistence on generic law is its medium reflecting on itself.

ϕ 4.5 The Gothic of media

The instruments through which the RCU's fictions act are conspicuously obsolete. Alan writes on a typewriter, not a computer. His broadcasts from the Dark Place appear on cathode-ray televisions. Bright Falls is narrated by a late-night radio host. Jesse's childhood catastrophe was caused by a slide projector. The dead Director is reached through an Object of Power called the Hotline, a telephone. The Dark Place screens films. The RCU's reality-altering technologies are the analog media of the twentieth century, and their selection is a theory.

Friedrich Kittler's *Gramophone, Film, Typewriter* (1986) argued that the typewriter transformed writing by separating it from the hand and standardizing its marks, and he made emblematic Nietzsche's remark, typed in 1882 on a Malling-Hansen writing ball, that our writing tools also work on our thoughts. Heidegger, in his *Parmenides* lectures (1942–1943), lamented that the typewriter withdraws the word from the hand, its essential realm. The RCU accepts the diagnosis and inverts the valuation: the typewriter's mechanization is what makes Alan's writing impersonal enough to act on the world. Marshall McLuhan's *Understanding Media* (1964) held that media are extensions of the senses that reshape the sensorium; David Cronenberg's *Videodrome* (1983), whose prophet is a McLuhan figure named Brian O'Blivion, made the television screen an organ of perception and finally of flesh. Alan's broadcasts from the Dark Place are Videodrome's signal reversed: not media entering the body, but a body entering media in order to escape.

Analog media are chosen because they are indexical: they bear the physical trace of what they record. André Bazin's "The Ontology of the Photographic Image" (1945) located the origin of the plastic arts in a mummy complex, the desire to preserve the body against time, and described the photograph as a kind of decal or death mask of the real. The RCU's live-action interpolations are its death masks, and their distribution is telling. Live action is reserved for the departed and the other side: Dr. Casper Darling's research films, recorded by a man who has vanished; Alan's appearances from the Dark Place; Mr. Door's studio; the uncanny commercials of a theme park. The medium with the strongest claim to reality marks the layer of the diegesis with the weakest. The RCU thus inverts photographic realism: the indexical image is the medium of the dead. Derrida's hauntology, in *Specters of Marx* (1993), and Mark Fisher's *Ghosts of My Life* (2014), which heard in the crackle of obsolete media the lost futures of the twentieth century, explain the affect. The RCU's analog apparatus is haunted not because it is old but because it records, and what is recorded can return.

ϕ 4.6 Summary: a theory of fiction in four propositions

The RCU's theory of fiction can be stated in four propositions. Narrative is causal: a story told under the right conditions makes itself true. Narrative causation is constrained: it acts only through plausibility and within the law of its genre. Narrative causation is mediated: it passes through instruments that carry the trace of bodies, and its preferred instruments are those whose futures were cancelled. And narrative causation is sustained: it depends on belief and attention, on readers, and its power is proportional to theirs. The fourth proposition opens onto time, because to be read is to be read again.

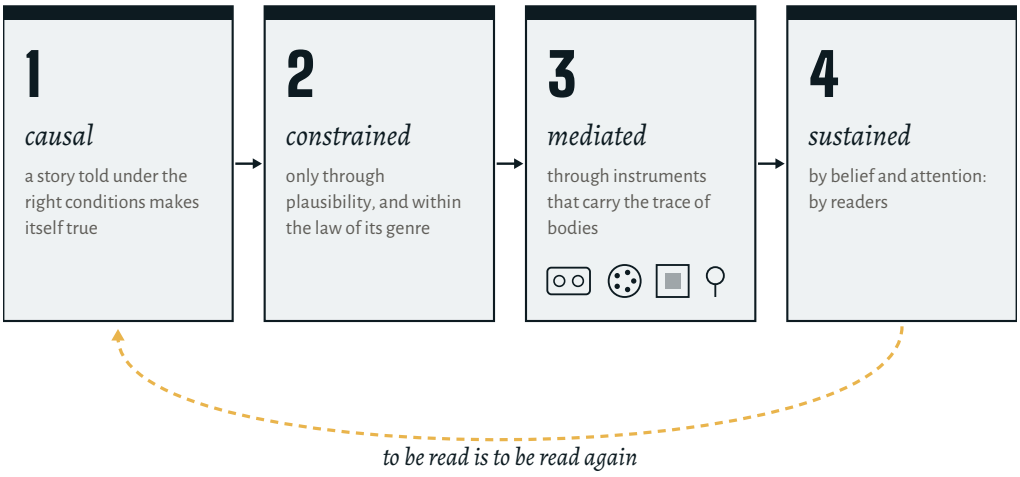


Figure 4.1 A theory of fiction in four propositions. Under the third stand the instruments the corpus prefers, those whose futures were cancelled: the cassette, the reel, the slide, the typewriter key.

Chapter Five

5

Helical Recurrence

It's Not a Loop

5.1 Five forms of recurrence
5.2 Infernal loops, purgatorial spirals
5.3 Acting out and working through
5.4 The axis is the reader
5.5 The spiral as Finnic prosody
5.6 The horror and the hope of the spiral
5.7 The Helical Axiom

"It's not a loop, it's a spiral" is the most philosophically consequential sentence in the RCU, and this chapter treats it as a thesis in the philosophy of time. It constructs a typology of recurrence, locates the RCU's choice within it, grounds the choice in Dante and Freud, and then advances the dissertation's central original claim: that the axis which converts a loop into a spiral is supplied by a reader.

ϕ 5.1 Five forms of recurrence

Five models of recurrence organize the relevant literature. The first is the *eternal return of the same*. Nietzsche's demon in §341 of *The Gay Science* (1882) offers the thought that one's life will recur innumerable times, identical in every detail, as "the greatest weight"; Mircea Eliade's *The Myth of the Eternal Return* (1949) described archaic societies' cyclical time as a refuge from what he called the terror of history. Popular culture's emblem of this model is the line spoken by Rust Cohle in the first season of *True Detective* (2014), "time is a flat circle": the loop as nihilism. The second is the *fixed timeline*, governed by what physicists call the Novikov self-consistency principle, according to which any closed causal loop must be consistent and the past cannot be altered. Remedy's own *Quantum Break* (2016) is rigorously Novikovian: its characters travel in time only to fulfil what has already occurred, and its antagonist, having seen the end of time, has become a fatalist. Ted Chiang's "The Merchant and the Alchemist's Gate" (2007) gives the model its consolation: the past cannot be changed, only known more fully. The third is *branching*, from Borges's "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941) to Hugh Everett's many-worlds interpretation (1957), a model the RCU adopts for its *Night Springs* multiverse. The fourth is the *knot*, exemplified by the German series *Dark* (2017–2020), in which a loop is sustained by an origin that must be unmade for the knot to dissolve. The fifth is the *helix*: repetition displaced along an axis, so that each return occurs at a different level.

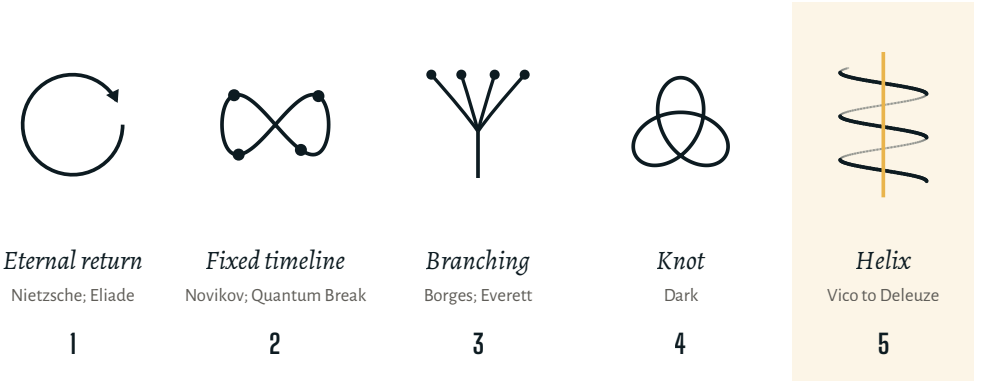


Figure 5.1 Five forms of recurrence. The RCU's tagline chooses the fifth against the first two.

The helix has a distinguished philosophical lineage. Giambattista Vico's *New Science* (1725; 1744) described history as a sequence of *corsi e ricorsi*, cycles that recur without merely repeating. Goethe's late essay on the spiral tendency of vegetation (1831) found the spiral in the growth of plants. Hegel described philosophy as a circle of circles, and Lenin, reading him, called dialectical development a spiral. Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) distinguished recollection, which repeats backward, from repetition proper, which recollects forward. Yeats's *A Vision* (1925; 1937) built a cosmology of interpenetrating gyres, and "The Second Coming" (1920) opens on its image: "Turning and turning in the widening gyre." Gilles Deleuze's *Difference and Repetition* (1968) reread Nietzsche against himself: the eternal return is not the return of the same but the return of difference, a selective test that only what differs survives. And Jung, in *Psychology and Alchemy* (1944), described individuation not as a straight path but as a circumambulation of the centre, a development he characterized as cyclic or spiral. By Aniela Jaffé's account, Jung found unexpected confirmation of the idea in 1928, in the Chinese "circulation of the light" described in *The Secret of the Golden Flower*, translated by Richard Wilhelm (Jaffé, reproduced). In the lineage the RCU inherits, the spiral is a path traced by light, which is exactly what Alan's Angel Lamp performs when it carries light from place to place to remake the Dark Place (§5.4).

The RCU's tagline chooses the fifth model against the first two, and in doing so it revises Remedy itself. *Quantum Break* was a loop; *Alan Wake 2* is a spiral. The studio's metaphysics of time has undergone exactly the transformation its tagline describes.

The choice also has a technical description. J. M. E. McTaggart's "The Unreality of Time" (1908) distinguished the A-series (past, present, and future: time as lived passage) from the B-series (earlier and later: time as a fixed order). *Quantum Break*'s fixed timeline is a B-series world, a block in which every event already has its place. The helix restores the A-series without abandoning order. It is Henri Bergson's *durée* in *Time and Free Will* (1889), lived duration in which each moment carries the past forward, and Edmund Husserl's internal time-consciousness (lectures of 1905, published 1928), in which every present holds the just-past in retention and leans toward the about-to-be in protention. Ted Chiang's "Story of Your Life" (1998) gives the fixed timeline its most humane form: a linguist acquires a language that grants her knowledge of her whole life, including her daughter's early death, and chooses that life anyway. *Quantum Break*'s fatalism is Chiang without consent; *Alan Wake 2*'s spiral is Bergson with a reader. The first season of *True Detective*, which the sequel's makers have named among its influences (Wikipedia), therefore stands at the head of this typology as the precise position the RCU set out to refute.

ϕ 5.2 Infernal loops, purgatorial spirals

Dante supplies the ethical meaning of the distinction. The *Inferno* is a funnel descended by turning, almost always, to the left; the *Purgatorio* is a mountain climbed by turning to the right. In Hell, the damned repeat their sins eternally under the law of *contrapasso*: the punishment is the sin made permanent, repetition without the possibility of difference. In Purgatory, the penitent also repeat (they recite, they carry, they fast), but their repetition purifies, and each terrace leads to the next. The difference between a loop and a spiral is the difference between Hell and Purgatory. Flann O'Brien's *The Third Policeman* (written 1939–1940; published 1967) is the modern infernal loop: its narrator, dead without knowing it, cycles through an absurd parish, and O'Brien characterized his hell as circular, interminable, and repetitive. Kubrick's adaptation of *The Shining* supplies the loop's emblem in writing: Jack Torrance's manuscript, a single proverb typed over hundreds of pages, is the absolute zero of authorship, repetition without difference, the text that has no reader.

The medium has its own emblem of the infernal loop. *P.T.* (2014), the playable teaser that Kojima Productions released for a *Silent Hills* that was later cancelled, confines the player to a single L-shaped suburban hallway, in a house where, a radio broadcast reports, a father murdered his wife and children. The hallway repeats with small, accumulating alterations, and its notoriously obscure exit can be reached only by reading those alterations. *P.T.* is an infernal loop that harbours a spiral: it can be escaped only by a player who reads its differences.

The comic counter-emblem is Harold Ramis's *Groundhog Day* (1993), whose day repeats identically while its protagonist does not; the external loop conceals an internal spiral, and the loop ends when the spiral is complete. *Alan Wake's American Nightmare* (2012) is *Groundhog Day* as an action game: Alan relives one night three times in the Arizona town of Night Springs, retaining his knowledge, and escapes by using what he has learned. *Alan Wake* 2 retroactively reframes that game as one of Alan's attempts, a draft. The Dark Place's thirteen years are thus purgatorial rather than infernal, because each draft differs from the last.

ϕ 5.3 Acting out and working through

Freud's paper "Remembering, Repeating and Working-Through" (1914) supplies the RCU's psychology of time. The patient who cannot remember a repressed experience repeats it instead, not as memory but as action (*agieren*), and the analytic task is to convert repetition into remembering through *Durcharbeiten*, working-through, a laborious and recursive process. *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) generalized the repetition compulsion and described the game of an eighteen-month-old boy who threw a spool on a string out of his cot with a sound Freud interpreted as *fort* (gone) and pulled it back with

a joyful *da* (there), mastering his mother's absences by staging departure and return. The RCU's whole architecture is a *fort/da*: Alice gone and returned, Alan gone and returned, the manuscript titled *Departure* and the sequel's chapters titled "Return."

Cathy Caruth's *Unclaimed Experience* (1996) defined trauma as an event not fully experienced when it occurred, which therefore returns belatedly and literally, in the same words and images. The Taken speak the speech of trauma: they repeat the literal fragments of their former lives (a greeting, an instruction, a complaint) without comprehension. Sherwood Anderson's *Winesburg, Ohio* (1919) opens with "The Book of the Grotesque," in which an old writer imagines that each person seized upon a single truth, clung to it, and was made grotesque by it; the Taken are Anderson's grotesques, each frozen around a single repeated phrase. The loop, in the RCU's psychology, is acting-out. The spiral is working-through.

The corpus's most exact instance of repetition with difference is a wound. In 1970, Thomas Zane, having written the drowned Barbara Jagger back from the Lake and found that something else had returned in her, bound the revenant to a chair and cut out her heart, then sank with her body into the Lake in his diving suit (Giant Bomb). In 2010, Alan defeats the Dark Presence wearing her form by driving the Clicker into the hole where her heart had been and switching it on (Giant Bomb). In 2023, the Koskela brothers' cult tears out the heart of Robert Nightingale as he emerges from the water (Alan Wake Wiki), and the chapter in which Saga recovers it is titled "The Heart" (Destructoid). The wound recurs across fifty-three years; what is put into it changes. Zane's knife is acting-out, violence repeating the violence that produced the revenant. Alan's light is working-through, the same wound filled with the transitional object of his childhood. The cult's ritual is institutional repetition, the knife become procedure. The helix is legible in a single anatomical site.

ϕ 5.4 The axis is the reader

A helix differs from a circle by one dimension: displacement along an axis. The decisive question is where the RCU's axis comes from, and the answer is the dissertation's central original claim. The axis is not supplied by the author. An author alone can only loop: this is Torrance's condition, and it is Alan's in the Dark Place, writing draft after draft, trapped in the narrative economy of a Night Springs episode. The axis is supplied by a second consciousness that reads the loop from outside it. *The spiral is a loop plus a reader.*

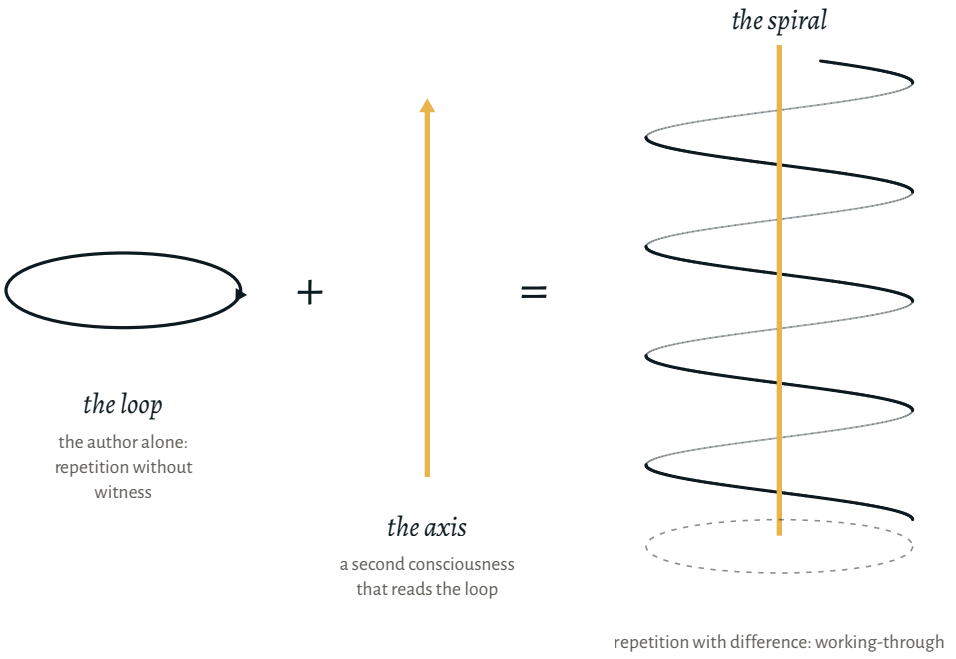


Figure 5.2 The dissertation's central claim, drawn: the spiral is a loop plus a reader.

Three emblems demonstrate the claim. The first is M. C. Escher's. *Drawing Hands* (1948), in which two hands draw each other into existence, is the canonical image of the strange loop that Douglas Hofstadter made the subject of *Gödel, Escher, Bach* (1979) and *I Am a Strange Loop* (2007), and it is an apt figure for the relation between Alan, who writes Saga into his story, and Saga, whose investigation brings Alan back. But Escher's hands remain a loop. *Print Gallery* (1956) is the spiral: a young man in a gallery looks at a print of a harbour town that, through a twisting expansion, contains the gallery in which he stands; at the centre, where the image would have to contain itself, Escher left a blank and put his signature. Bart de Smit and Hendrik Lenstra showed in 2003 that the blank could be filled by a self-similar spiral repeating inward without end. The RCU's spiral has such a centre, the unrepresentable point at which the viewer is inside what he views, and its name is the Lake.

The second emblem is Michael Ende's *The Neverending Story* (1979). Atreyu reaches the Old Man of Wandering Mountain, who writes down everything that happens as it happens; at the Childlike Empress's command, he begins to recite the story from its beginning, which includes his reciting it, and the story enters an infinite loop. The loop is broken only when Bastian, the boy reading the book in an attic, calls out the new name the Empress needs and so enters the story himself. The reader converts the loop into a narrative. Ende's fable is the Helical Axiom in the form of a children's book.

The third emblem is *Alan Wake 2* itself, whose dual protagonism is the axiom's formal embodiment. Alan's chapters ("Initiation") take place inside a recursive Dark Place that rewrites itself; his instrument is the Writer's Room, a plot board on which scenes are recomposed, and his raw material is Echoes, glimpses of moments from Alex Casey's investigation, another man's deeds and words, which supply the plot elements with which he revises scenes. The name is exact: in the third book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, the nymph Echo is condemned to repeat only the last words of others, the loop in its purest acoustic form, and Alan's labour is to transmute echoes into plot, repetition into difference. Saga's chapters ("Return") take place in a world that the manuscript is changing; her instrument is the Mind Place, a reader's hermeneutic machine in which clues are arranged until they disclose a pattern. Alan produces; Saga reads; the spiral requires both. The *Final Draft* mode (2023) completes the demonstration at the level of the player: the game replayed, with revised manuscript pages and a revised ending, is the same text reread as a different work, as Borges's Pierre Menard rewrote *Don Quixote* word for word and produced, in Borges's account, a richer book. The medium's own grammar confirms the claim. Death and respawn are the game's loop; New Game Plus is its spiral; and what converts one into the other is the player's memory, which is to say reading.

Saga's Mind Place has a long genealogy. The classical art of memory, which Cicero's *De oratore* traced to Simonides of Ceos identifying the guests crushed in a collapsed banquet hall by recalling where each had sat, and which the *Rhetorica ad Herennium* systematized as places (*loci*) furnished with images, became in the Renaissance, as Frances Yates showed in *The Art of Memory* (1966), an occult technology: Giulio Camillo's memory theatre and Giordano Bruno's magical memory systems were instruments not merely for recalling the world but for reorganizing it. The Mind Place is a Brunian theatre in a detective's office. Alan's instrument is named after a different institution, the writers' room of television, in which scripts are composed collectively: his Writer's Room is one man's simulation of collective authorship, the lake rehearsing to become an ocean. Italo Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler* (1979), whose protagonist is the Reader, addressed as "you," and whose novel consists of interrupted beginnings, is the literary precedent for the sequel's alternation of interrupted chapters between author and reader.

The sequel's coda supplies the axiom's third embodiment. Alice, whose video diaries record years of haunting, turns out to have been watching Alan's loops from outside them, which is to say reading them; Alan learns that the haunting she endured was produced by his own compulsive returns, draft after draft, to the apparition of their apartment, so that the cost of his loop fell on the person he loved. Her final tape reveals that she staged her death to move him, and frames his choice as "destruction" or "ascension"; Alan's answer is the tagline (Wikipedia). At the decisive moment, the spiral's axis is supplied by the one person who had read every turn of the loop (Chapter Six).

Even the author's instrument comes from outside him. The Angel Lamp, the lamp from which the Clicker was cut, reached the Dark Place because Rose Marigold, the fan, sent it there after seemingly receiving messages from Alan (Alan Wake Wiki). And Mr. Door, on his talk show, suggests that the true Alan Wake is another one, writing in another room, and asks whether they are all in Alan's story (TechRadar): the question of Borges's "The Circular Ruins" (1940), whose dreamer discovers that he too is being dreamt. The author is not the origin of his own light.

The claim reorients a famous argument. Roland Barthes concluded "The Death of the Author" (1967) by declaring that the birth of the reader must be ransomed by the death of the Author. The RCU agrees that the reader is born, and denies that the author must die for it. In the RCU, the reader's birth is the author's rescue.

ϕ 5.5 The spiral as Finnic prosody

The Helical Axiom has a prosody, and it is Finnish. The runosong tradition behind the *Kalevala* is built on parallelism: each line is followed by a restatement that varies it, so that the poem advances by saying the same thing differently, and in performance a second singer would often take up the lead singer's line in turn. The epic's first couplet is itself a demonstration: "Mieleni minun tekevi, / aivoni ajattelevi" ("my mind desires, / my brain considers"; Lönnrot 1849, 1.1–2), the second half restating the first a quarter-turn on; and the metre frequently binds a line's words by alliteration, so that each line also returns on its own sound. Parallelism is the spiral at the scale of the verse line: return with displacement. The RCU's episodic recaps ("Previously on *Alan Wake*") are runic restatements at the scale of the episode; each game restates its predecessor with roles redistributed (a writer, a lake, a missing loved one, now carried by two protagonists); and the *Kalevala*'s own plot, ending with Väinämöinen's departure under promise of return, is the helix at the scale of the epic.

Western prosody knows the same device. The villanelle, a nineteen-line form built on two refrains that return in altered contexts until they meet in the closing quatrain, is the spiral as fixed form; its most famous modern instance, Dylan Thomas's villanelle of 1951, turns its refrains on a dying father and on the extinction of light, the RCU's master image. T. S. Eliot's "Little Gidding" (1942), the last of the *Four Quartets*, closes on the conviction that exploration is completed by a return to the point of origin, now understood as if for the first time: a return that is also a first knowledge, the helix in a sentence.

The corpus spirals even at the level of its titles, and the sequence has a postal prehistory: in *Max Payne* 2 (2003), *Address Unknown* airs as a marathon called *Return to Sender*, the title that Alan's third Casey novel later borrows (§1.1). At the end of *The Writer* (2010), Alan begins typing a manuscript called *Return*; the *Night Springs* episode he writes himself into in *American Nightmare* (2012) bears the same title (PlayPile); the live-action pitch

film for an unmade sequel, hidden inside *Quantum Break* (2016), is called *Alan Wake: Return*; and in *Alan Wake 2* (2023), "Return" names both the manuscript and half of the game's chapters (Wikipedia). One word returns four times across thirteen years, each time displaced into a new medium (manuscript, television episode, film, game): the Helical Axiom stated as a bibliography.

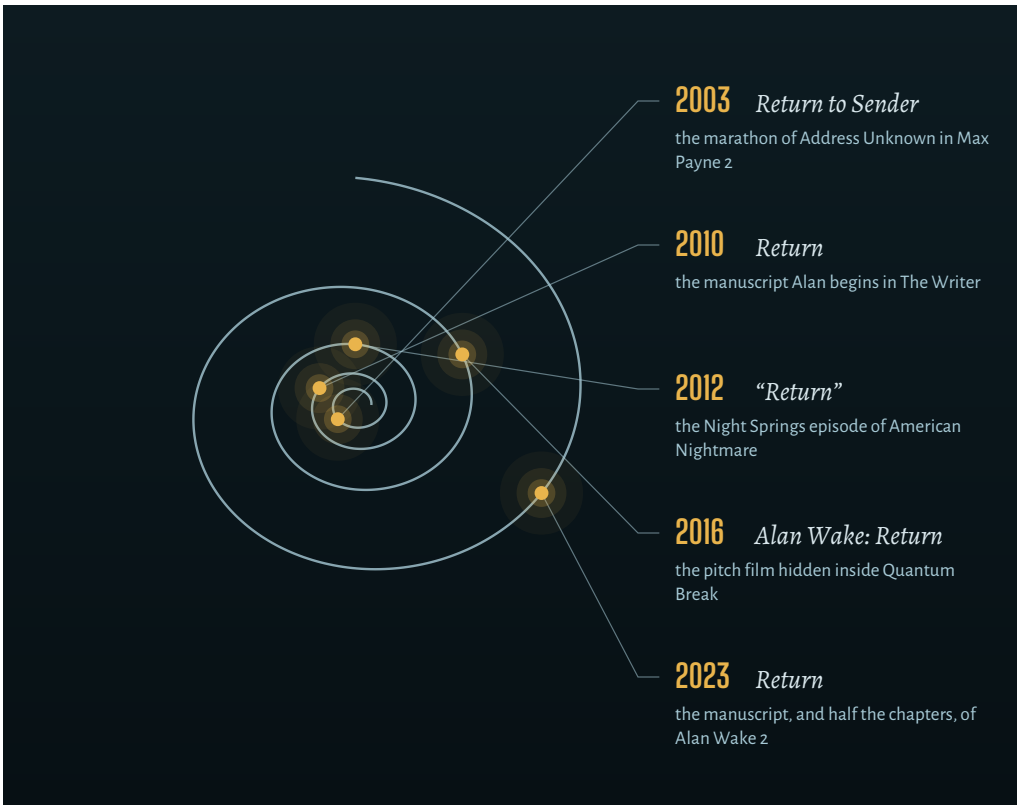


Figure 5.3 One title in five turns. Each return of the word occurs a level higher than the last.

Umberto Eco's essay "Innovation and Repetition: Between Modern and Post-Modern Aesthetics" (1985) distinguished several forms of seriality: the retake, the remake, the series (in which the same situation recurs with variations), and the saga, in which characters age and history accumulates, so that repetition takes on the dimension of time. Eco's saga is serial repetition become historical: a spiral. That the RCU's reader is named Saga is, under the protocol of amplification, a resonance to be flagged and kept.

ϕ 5.6 The horror and the hope of the spiral

The spiral is not inherently redemptive. Junji Ito's *Uzumaki* (1998–1999) makes it the shape of horror: a town is consumed by an obsession with spirals that twists its inhabit-

ants' bodies and finally its whole geography, and the curse, it is revealed, recurs in cycles. Ito's spiral is entropy, the vortex that draws everything into its centre. Edgar Allan Poe had imagined both possibilities. In "MS. Found in a Bottle" (1833), a narrator's ship is drawn toward a vast polar whirlpool, and the manuscript he casts into the sea is all that escapes. In "A Descent into the Maelström" (1841), a fisherman drawn into the vortex survives by observing its law, that cylindrical objects descend most slowly, and by lashing himself to a barrel. He emerges with white hair, and with a story. The maelstrom is survivable by attention to its laws, which is exactly the RCU's teaching about the Dark Place.

Finnic cosmology had already placed the spiral at the bottom of the world: Kinahmi, the whirlpool churned at the foot of the world pillar, through which one descends to Tuonela (§2.8). The RCU's Lake is that vortex given a shoreline, and its survivors are those who, like Poe's fisherman, attend to its law.

The medium has absorbed the lesson. *Outer Wilds* (2019) traps its player in a twenty-two-minute loop in which only knowledge persists, and resolves it by the creation of a new universe, a cosmic spiral. *Returnal* (2021), by the Finnish studio Housemarque, binds a grieving astronaut to a recursive planet whose loops her persistence converts into progress. That two of the most rigorous meditations on recursion in contemporary games should come from studios in the Helsinki metropolitan area is suggestive of a regional poetics of the spiral, whose deepest root is the runosong.

ϕ 5.7 The Helical Axiom

The axiom may now be stated in full. In the RCU, recurrence takes the form of a helix whose axis is supplied by reading. The loop is the authorial condition, repetition without witness: Torrance's typescript, the Taken's echolalia, Hell. The spiral is the readerly condition, repetition with difference: working-through, purgation, revision, Purgatory. The passage from loop to spiral cannot be accomplished by the author alone. It requires another, and the RCU's sequels, protagonists, replays, and players are that other.

Chapter Six

6



The Double and the Author-Function

6.1 A genealogy of the double
6.2 Mr. Scratch: the author-function made flesh
6.3 Alex Casey and the authorial face
6.4 The repertory of faces
6.5 From receptacle to reader: the women of the RCU
6.6 The RCU's theory of the person

A universe in which writing makes worlds must also be one in which writing makes selves. This chapter reads the RCU's theory of the person through four figures: its doubles, above all Mr. Scratch; its practice of authorial self-insertion, condensed in Alex Casey; its repertory of recurring faces; and its gendered distribution of agency, which the corpus first exhibits and then revises. It argues that the RCU's subject is constituted by doubling, endangered by its own public name, multiplied across worlds as a face, and redeemed only by being read.

ϕ 6.1 A genealogy of the double

Jean Paul coined *Doppelgänger* in *Siebenkäs* (1796) for the one who sees himself. The Romantic and Gothic double proliferated thereafter: E. T. A. Hoffmann's *The Devil's Elixirs* (1815–1816), whose monk is shadowed by a mad brother who commits his crimes; James Hogg's *The Private Memoirs and Confessions of a Justified Sinner* (1824), in which a shape-shifting companion named Gil-Martin flatters a self-righteous zealot into murder, and whose manuscript the novel's editor recovers by opening a suicide's grave; Poe's "William Wilson" (1839), whose narrator kills the double who is his conscience and thereby himself; Dostoevsky's *The Double* (1846); Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886). Cinema gave the double its modern body in *The Student of Prague* (1913), in which a student sells his reflection to a sorcerer who turns it into a murderous rival. Otto Rank opened *Der Doppelgänger* (1914) with that film and argued that the double, originally an insurance against death, reverses into death's harbinger, a reversal Freud adopted in "The Uncanny" (1919). Lacan's mirror stage (1949) generalized the structure: the ego forms through identification with an external image, so that the self is constituted as other from the start. Jung's Shadow names the disowned portion of the personality that, unintegrated, returns as an autonomous figure.

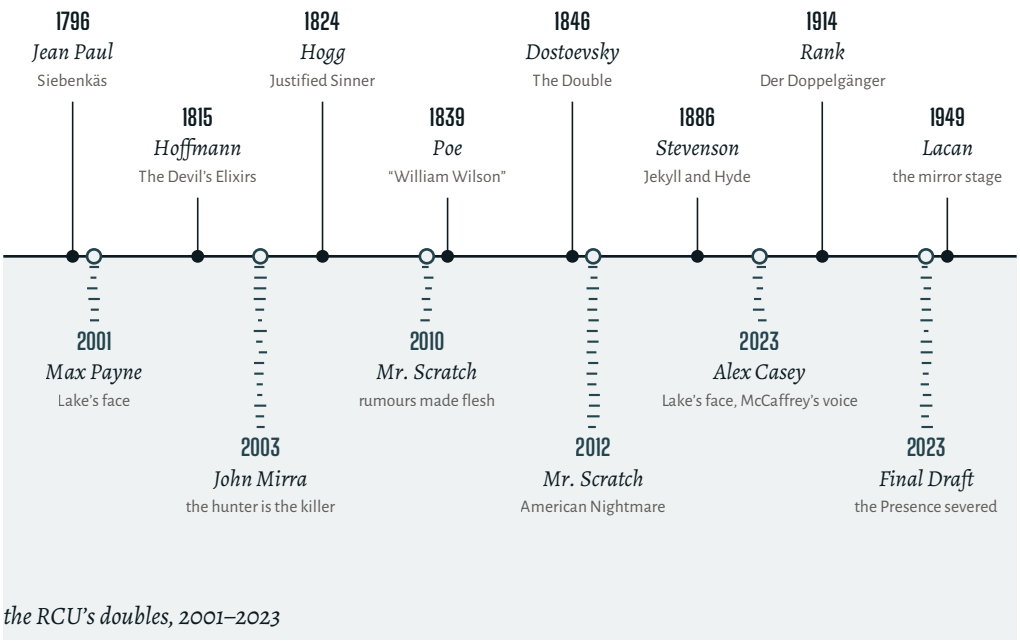


Figure 6.1 The double and its reflection. Above the waterline, the literary genealogy from Jean Paul to Lacan; below it, the RCU's doubles, drawn in broken strokes as reflections are.

The RCU inherits all of these and adds a determination none of them supplies. Its doubles are not repressed impulses or reflected images. They are *written*.

ϕ 6.2 Mr. Scratch: the author-function made flesh

The name carries three senses. Old Scratch is an American folk name for the Devil: Washington Irving's "The Devil and Tom Walker" (1824) uses it, and Stephen Vincent Benét's "The Devil and Daniel Webster" (1936) calls him Mr. Scratch, the creditor who comes to collect a New Hampshire farmer's soul and is defeated by eloquence before a jury of the damned. Scratch is also the sound of writing, the noise of a nib on paper, the first mark. And "from scratch" means from nothing: Scratch is the demiurge of *creatio ex nihilo*, who writes from nothing because the darkness he embodies possesses nothing of its own.

The American Scratch has a second genealogy, which a study of the RCU's doubles must state precisely. In the blues legend of the crossroads, a musician waits at midnight where two roads meet, and a figure takes his guitar, tunes it, and returns it in exchange for his soul. The folklorist David Evans recorded the story in the 1960s from LeDell Johnson, who told it of his brother, the Mississippi bluesman Tommy Johnson; it later at-

tached itself to Robert Johnson, whose death in 1938, at twenty-seven, sealed the myth, and Elijah Wald's *Escaping the Delta* (2004) has shown how much of it was constructed by later writers and promoters. In LeDell Johnson's telling the figure at the crossroads is a black man, and some scholars, notably Julio Finn in *The Bluesman* (1986), have read in him a demonized memory of Legba (§2.9), recast as the Devil by a Christianizing gaze; others regard the derivation as unproven, a disagreement the Mississippi Encyclopedia's entry on the myth records. Either way, the legend transposes Faust's bargain of knowledge for the soul into a bargain of art for the soul, which is the bargain the Dark Presence offers every artist who comes to Cauldron Lake. Scratch inherits the bargain but not the figure: the face at the RCU's crossroads is the artist's own.

Alan Wake's American Nightmare and its sequel present Scratch as a double fashioned by the Dark Presence from what the world came to believe about Alan Wake after his disappearance. The difference from King is decisive. George Stark in *The Dark Half* is Thad Beaumont's pseudonym made flesh, the violence his writing sublimated. Scratch is not Alan's pseudonym but his *reputation*: the public name made flesh. Michel Foucault's "What Is an Author?" (1969) argued that the author is not a person but a function of discourse, which classifies texts, guarantees their unity, regulates their circulation, and serves as a principle of thrift in the proliferation of meaning. Scratch is the author-function detached from the man and set loose: "Alan Wake" the bestselling name, the brand, the rumour, acting on its own. The RCU's insight is that the Dark Presence feeds most richly not on writers but on author-functions, because the public name of a famous author is the densest concentration of narrative belief the world contains. Barthes's "The Death of the Author" (1967) attacked the Author-God whose intention guarantees a text's single meaning. Scratch is that Author-God without the goodness theology ascribed to its original: an author who wants to author everything.

The game's own account is more exact still. *American Nightmare* explains that Scratch was created when false rumours about Alan spread after his disappearance, and that the power of the Dark Place turned this misinformation into reality (Wikipedia); at release he was described as an urban legend come to life (Route 66 News, quoting VentureBeat); and the game's framing narration names him the herald of darkness. Scratch is misinformation made flesh: W. I. Thomas's theorem (Chapter Four) incarnated as a serial killer, and the author-function as rumour.

Two precedents clarify the sequel's resolution of the double. In Le Guin's *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968), a gifted student, out of pride, summons a spirit of the dead and releases a shadow that hunts him; on his master's counsel he turns to hunt it in return, pursues it to the edge of the world, and names it with his own name, so that the two become one and he is made whole. The shadow cannot be destroyed without destroying the self; it can only be acknowledged. The *Hymn of the Pearl* ends identically, with a robe in which the prince sees himself as in a mirror. And in the second part of *Don Quixote* (1615), Cer-

vantes answered the spurious sequel published in 1614 under the name of Avellaneda by having his knight learn of it, alter his route to falsify it, and finally meet one of its characters, Don Álvaro Tarfe, whom he persuades to swear before the town's mayor that the knight he had known was an impostor. The authentic text wages war on its apocryphal double. Scratch writes the apocryphal sequel to Alan's life, and the war of drafts in *Alan Wake 2* is Cervantes's war with Avellaneda transposed into metaphysics. The sequel's most celebrated sequence, the rock opera in which Alan and Mr. Door share a stage to perform "Herald of Darkness," a song in praise of Alan's double, belongs to what Bakhtin called the carnivalesque: the register in which the self may sing of its other before an audience.

The sequel stages both outcomes of the doubling tradition in sequence. In the Dark Place, Alan, mistaking his own past self for Scratch, kills him, and the killing perpetuates the cycle instead of ending it: Poe's William Wilson, who destroys his double and thereby himself, re-enacted as a time loop. His despair then opens him to possession. The *Final Draft* supplies Ged's ending instead: Alan completes *Return* and severs the Dark Presence, which the ending discloses was born of his own darkness, and the Bullet of Light destroys it (Wikipedia). The double is defeated only when it is recognized as one's own.

Accounts of the scene disagree about whom Alan kills: the current Wikipedia summary calls the victim his own past self, while an earlier revision of the same article called him Thomas Zane, driven mad by captivity in the Dark Place (Wikipedia). The disagreement is itself evidence. The precursor poet and the protagonist's former self occupy the same position in the loop: Ahti greets Alan as "Tom" (§2.9), and the sequel's cast listing credits a single performer as Alan, Scratch, and Zane (§6.4). Bloom's anxiety of influence has become an identity: the precursor is a previous turn of the spiral.

ϕ 6.3 Alex Casey and the authorial face

Alex Casey is the hero of Alan's thrillers and, in *Alan Wake 2*, an FBI agent partnered with Saga: a character who exists in two ontological registers at once. The tradition behind him is the tradition of the character who meets the author. In Miguel de Unamuno's *Niebla* (1914), Augusto Pérez travels to Salamanca to consult his author about his own suicide; Unamuno informs him that he is a fiction and will die, and Augusto retorts that Unamuno, too, may be a fiction dreamt by God. Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921) gives the abandoned characters the stage. Flann O'Brien's *At Swim-Two-Birds* (1939) lets the characters of the novelist Dermot Trellis drug him and author his torment. Marc Forster's *Stranger than Fiction* (2006) makes its protagonist hear the voice of the novelist who intends to kill him.

Casey's face is Sam Lake's; his voice was James McCaffrey's, the voice of Max Payne. The nesting is triple: the author plays the character of his character, and through the actor's voice summons a protagonist whose rights the studio does not own. Paul Auster's *City of Glass* (1985) is the uncanny prototype. Its protagonist, Daniel Quinn, writes detective novels under the pseudonym William Wilson, which is the name of Poe's double, featuring a detective named Max Work; mistaken by a telephone caller for a private detective named Paul Auster, he accepts the case, becomes a detective, and dissolves into the labyrinth of New York; a writer named Paul Auster also appears. Quinn, Wilson, and Work map onto Wake, Scratch, and Casey with startling exactness (a writer, a doubled name, a detective called Max), and Auster's New York, in which the self is lost among streets, anticipates the Dark Place's Manhattan. Three films complete the constellation. Spike Jonze and Charlie Kaufman's *Adaptation* (2002) shows a blocked screenwriter writing himself into his screenplay while his invented twin, author of a hack thriller, coincides with the film's own descent into thriller in its final act: the double as genre. The Coen brothers' *Barton Fink* (1991) confines a blocked playwright in an infernal hotel whose genial neighbour is a killer and whose wall bears a picture that becomes real at the end: the Oceanview Hotel's ancestor. Kaufman's *Synecdoche, New York* (2008) shows a director building a life-size replica of New York in a warehouse, casting actors to play actors who play him, recursively, until the work consumes the life: the Dark Place's New York in its purest form.

Two further precedents complete the constellation, and the makers' own testimony converts one resemblance into documented influence. Among the sequel's literary sources they have named Auster's *New York Trilogy*, Danielewski's *House of Leaves*, King's *Dark Tower* and his memoir *On Writing*, and Bret Easton Ellis's *Lunar Park* (2005) (Wikipedia). *Lunar Park* is a horror novel narrated by a writer named Bret Easton Ellis, whose suburban house begins to change its shape and who finds himself stalked by murders modelled on his own fiction: the novelist haunted by his own author-function, in a house that will not hold still. Fernando Pessoa's heteronyms, the poets Alberto Caeiro, Ricardo Reis, and Álvaro de Campos, each with a biography, a style, and opinions on the others, supply the modernist precedent for an author distributed across invented authors: Alan the novelist, Alan the author of the Casey books, Alan the drafter of the *Night Springs* episodes and of *American Nightmare*, and Scratch.

ϕ 6.4 The repertory of faces

The RCU's casting is a metaphysics, and its makers have said as much. James McCaffrey, who died on 17 December 2023, voiced Max Payne, Thomas Zane, Director Zachariah Trench, and Alex Casey (Wikipedia); in his tribute Lake listed the roles in sequence, "James was Max Payne, Thomas Zane, Zachariah Trench and finally Alex Casey," and ad-

ded that he had shared Max's and Casey's roles with him (GameSpot). The pattern is exact. McCaffrey's is the voice of the RCU's predecessors, the poet who wrote before Alan and the Director who ruled before Jesse, and of its detectives. Matthew Porretta is Alan's voice and Dr. Casper Darling's face; Ilkka Villi gives Alan his face and his live-action body. The sequel's cast listing credits one performer as Alan Wake, Scratch, and Thomas Zane, and another as Alan Wake, Scratch, and Casper Darling (IMDbPro), so that protagonist, double, and precursor poet share a body. Martti Suosalo plays Ahti in both franchises, and Peter Franzén plays the Koskela brothers (Shacknews). Shawn Ashmore plays Jack Joyce in *Quantum Break* and Tim Breaker in *Alan Wake 2*, and in the *Night Springs* episode "Time Breaker," whose title fuses Tim Breaker with *Quantum Break*, a version of himself. Lake's face recurs as Max and as Casey. The repertory company recalls the stock masks of the commedia dell'arte and, more exactly, Moorcock's Eternal Champion, a single being incarnated across a multiverse under many names.

The RCU separates face from voice and recombines them across works: Casey is Lake's face and McCaffrey's voice; Porretta is a voice in one world and a face in another. The Latin *persona* was the actor's mask, and the old folk etymology from *per-sonare*, to sound through, though philologically doubtful, names exactly what the RCU takes a person to be: a mask through which a voice sounds. Personhood in the RCU is a montage. This repertory ontology also explains the logic of the *Night Springs* multiverse, whose worlds are distinguished less by their contents than by their casting, and the corpus itself turns shared casting into cosmology: elements of the sequel and of "Time Breaker" imply that Tim Breaker, Jesse Faden, and Warlin Door are alternate versions of characters from *Quantum Break* (Wikipedia). Fandom reads every recurrence as a clue, which is to say that the repertory is itself a case board and every recurring face a red string.

ϕ 6.5 From receptacle to reader: the women of the RCU

The first decade of the corpus distributes agency along lines of gender, and an honest reading must say so. Barbara Jagger is drowned, revived, and possessed; Alice is taken into the water and must be rescued; Rose Marigold is the obsessive fan; Cynthia Weaver is the eccentric guardian; only Sheriff Sarah Breaker escapes the pattern. Gaston Bachelard's *Water and Dreams* (1942) diagnosed an "Ophelia complex" in the Western imagination, which makes water the element of young and beautiful death, especially women's. Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) anatomized horror's archaic mother and witch, and Barbara Jagger is both. The *khôra* of Chapter Three is a mother in the *Timaeus*, and the first game made its women the receptacle rather than its agents. Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) described the woman writer's anxiety of authorship: confined in male texts as angel or monster, she must kill both in order to write.

The corpus revises this distribution step by step. *Control* (2019) gives the RCU a woman protagonist who becomes Director: not a muse but an administrator, the bearer of the sovereign object. *Alan Wake 2* (2023) makes its reader-detective Saga Anderson, a Black woman played by Melanie Liburd. The manuscript *Return*, which Alan wrote to escape and which Scratch has twisted, rewrites Saga's past so that her daughter, Logan, drowned in an accident; Saga, angered that Alan has written her and her child into his story, refuses the role the horror genre assigns her, an act Chapter Eight calls the reader's veto. *Night Springs* (2024) lets Rose Marigold become the heroine of her own episode, canonizing what Henry Jenkins's *Textual Poachers* (1992) called the fan's poaching of the text; *The Lake House* (2024) gives the investigative lead to Kiran Estevez.

Alice's revision is the most radical, and the sequel conceals it until its final minutes. In the Dark Place, Alan's attempts to escape keep looping back to an apparition of their New York apartment, where he finds Alice's video diaries recording years of haunting. He comes to understand that the haunting was caused by his own repeated returns, finds what appears to be her suicide note, and believes her dead. A final video diary reveals that she tricked him into believing so, in order to move him to break the cycle through "destruction" or "ascension," and that she has been guiding events from within the Dark Place, including Saga's path through it; the *Final Draft* adds that the Dark Presence Alan finally severs was born of his own darkness and tied to Alice (Wikipedia). The woman taken into the water in 2010 returns in 2023 as the architect of her husband's escape: an artist whose recordings are, after the manuscript, the RCU's most consequential texts. Hélène Cixous's "The Laugh of the Medusa" (1975) urged women to write themselves into the texts from which they had been driven; Alice does so on videotape.

The trajectory therefore runs from receptacle (Barbara) through administrator (Jesse), reader (Saga), and author of her own episode (Rose) to author of the author's escape (Alice). The revision is incomplete, and the critique stands in part: the sequel still routes its climax through a drowned child and a woman's staged suicide, and Bachelard's Ophelia complex survives within the corpus's correction of it. But the Helical Axiom acquires a feminist corollary that the sequel makes explicit. The second consciousness that converts the author's loop into a spiral is, twice over, a woman's (Saga's reading and Alice's design), and the spiral depends on their refusal to be merely written.

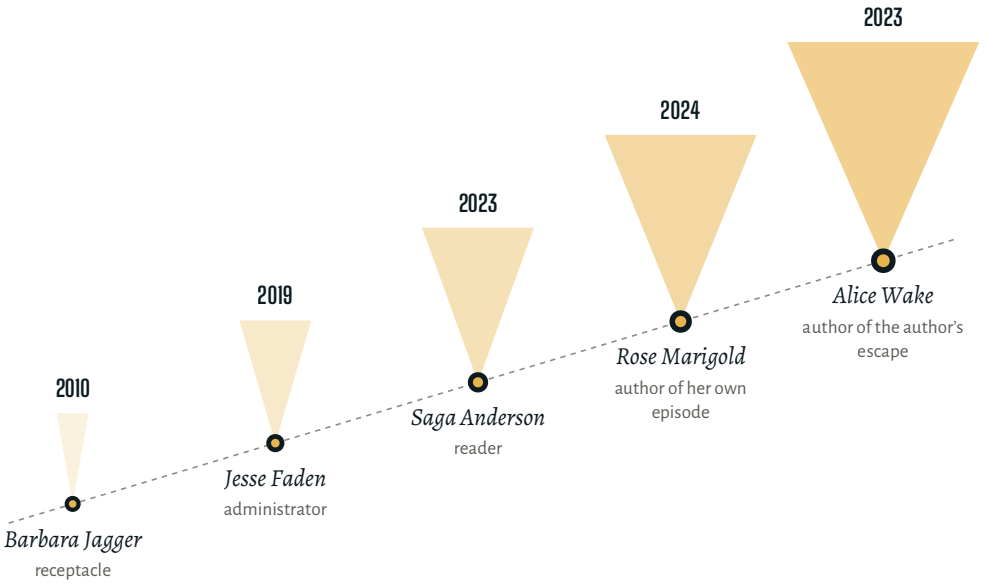


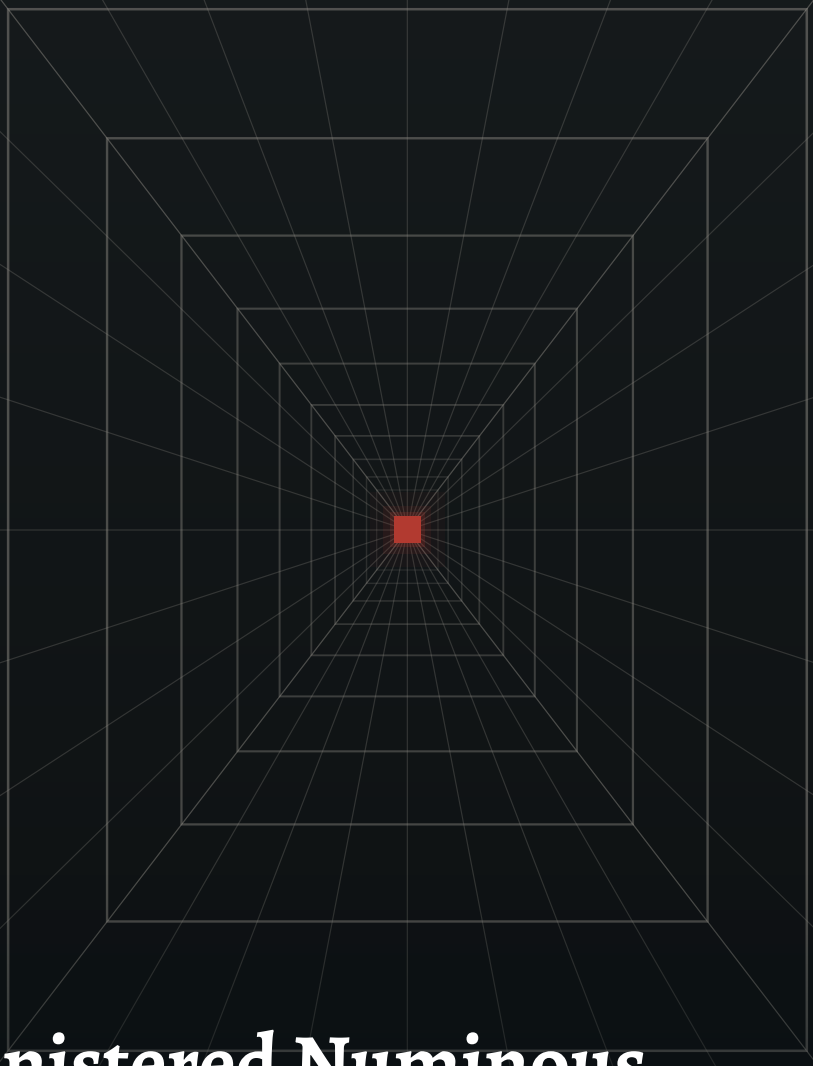
Figure 6.2 From receptacle to architect. The light each figure carries widens as the corpus revises the role it assigns her; the order is the argument's, not the calendar's.

ϕ 6.6 The RCU's theory of the person

The chapter's findings compose a theory in four propositions. The self is constituted by doubling, as Lacan argued. It is endangered by its own public name, as Foucault's author-function, incarnated in Scratch, demonstrates. It is multiplied across worlds as a face, as the repertory shows. And it is redeemed by being read, as Saga's role in the sequel establishes. The double is not abolished but integrated, as Ged names his shadow and the prince of the *Hymn* sees himself in his robe. The RCU's ethics of the person thus anticipates its ethics of creation: the self, like the world, is made by writing, endangered by unbalanced writing, and saved by a reader.

Chapter Seven

7



The Administered Numinous

Control *and the Institutions of Creative Capture*

7.1 AWE
7.2 Weber in the Oldest House
7.3 The sovereign of the exception
7.4 From Panopticon to control
7.5 Archive fever
7.6 Objects of Power
7.7 The house of Being
7.8 Institutions of creative capture
7.9 The institutional corollary

If *Alan Wake* is the RCU's myth of the individual maker, *Control* is its myth of the institution. This chapter argues that *Control* and its successors constitute a political theology of the administered numinous: an inquiry into how a modern state, through a bureau, attempts to classify, contain, and wield awe. It then extends the analysis to the RCU's other institutions of creative capture (the clinic, the cult, the laboratory, the theme park) and derives the institutional corollary of the Equilibrial Axiom.

ϕ 7.1 AWE

Rudolf Otto's *Das Heilige* (1917) described the numinous as *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*, the mystery that repels and attracts at once, the encounter with the wholly other (*das ganz Andere*) that produces in the worshipper a sense of being a mere creature. The Bureau's name for its central category, Altered World Event, abbreviates to AWE: the agency has made the primary affect of religious experience into a file classification. Edmund Burke's *Enquiry* (1757) had located the sublime in astonishment mixed with some degree of horror; Kant's *Critique of Judgment* (1790) distinguished the mathematical sublime, magnitude that defeats the imagination, from the dynamical sublime, might from which reason assures us of our independence. The Oldest House is both: mathematically sublime in its interior, larger than its exterior, reconfiguring its halls, opening onto an Astral Plane without horizon; dynamically sublime in the violence of the paranatural. What is new in *Control* is that the sublime is administered. Its vertigo is not that of mountains but of forms, cabinets, and protocols extending past comprehension: a bureaucratic sublime.

ϕ 7.2 Weber in the Oldest House

Max Weber's lecture "Science as a Vocation" (delivered 1917; published 1919) defined the disenchantment of the world as the belief that there are, in principle, no mysterious incalculable forces at work in it, and *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* (1905) closed with the image of a *stahlhartes Gehäuse* that Talcott Parsons rendered as an "iron cage." *Control* stages re-enchantment inside the iron cage. The incalculable has returned, and the Bureau's response is to calculate it. *Economy and Society* (1922) distinguished three types of legitimate domination (traditional, charismatic, and legal-rational) and described the routinization of charisma, the process by which the extraordinary authority of a chosen person is converted into the ordinary authority of an office. Jesse's legitimacy is charismatic in the strictest sense: she is chosen by an object that confers grace, as Arthur was chosen by the sword. Yet she presides over a legal-rational bureaucracy of sectors, department heads, procedures, and forms, and the ultimate source of authority, the Board, is neither traditional nor rational but numinous. *Control* thus dramatizes the

concealed structure of modern authority as Weber understood it: rational administration resting on a charisma it cannot itself produce.

ϕ 7.3 The sovereign of the exception

Carl Schmitt's *Political Theology* (1922) opens with a definition (*Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet*: sovereign is he who decides on the exception) and argues in its third chapter that the significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts, the exception in jurisprudence being analogous to the miracle in theology. Schmitt's later conduct requires precise statement rather than euphemism. He joined the Nazi Party in May 1933 and became one of the regime's leading jurists. In "The Führer Protects the Law" (1934) he justified the extrajudicial killings of the Night of the Long Knives, ordered by Hitler and carried out by the SS and the Gestapo, and on 3–4 October 1936, in Berlin, he convened and chaired a conference titled "Judaism in Legal Science," which opened with a quotation from *Mein Kampf* and resolved that legal works by Jewish authors be removed from law libraries; Schmitt urged colleagues to avoid citing Jewish authors and, where that was unavoidable, to identify them as Jews, and his closing address was published as "German Jurisprudence in the Struggle against the Jewish Spirit" (U.S. Department of State; Sunstein; I·CONnect). Attacks from the SS cost him his posts in the party's legal organizations late that year (EHRI), though not his Berlin chair, and he never publicly renounced National Socialism. His concepts are invoked here diagnostically, as instruments for analysing sovereignty; the history is stated because, in his hands, a theory of the exception became a licence for killing. The Bureau's taxonomy literalizes his analogy. An Altered World Event is a miracle in Schmitt's sense, an exception to the order of nature, which the Bureau names "paranatural," beside nature. The Bureau's sovereignty consists in deciding what counts as such an exception, and in keeping its decisions secret. Giorgio Agamben's *State of Exception* (2003) argued that the exception has become the dominant paradigm of government in modernity. An agency whose headquarters are imperceptible to the public it governs is a permanent state of exception given a building.

ϕ 7.4 From Panopticon to control

Michel Foucault's *Discipline and Punish* (1975) made Bentham's Panopticon the diagram of disciplinary power: the inmate, permanently visible to an unseen observer, internalizes surveillance and disciplines himself. *Control* names a containment space in its depths the Panopticon, with no apparent irony. Gilles Deleuze's "Postscript on the Societies of Control" (1990) argued that the disciplinary enclosures of the prison, school, and factory were giving way to societies of control: modulation instead of molds, passwords instead of signatures, the corporation instead of the factory, "dividuals" instead of individuals,

continuous control instead of periodic confinement. Alexander Galloway's *Gaming* (2006) proposed that video games are the native allegory of informatic control, since to play is to learn and execute an algorithm. A game titled *Control* is therefore doubly allegorical: it represents control as its content and enacts it as its form, since the player controls Jesse as the Board, through the weapon, controls her.

The Panopticon holds a stranger figure, which turns Bentham's diagram inside out. On its fourth floor, a Bureau agent named Phillip is locked in a cell staring at a malevolent refrigerator; when Jesse tries to cleanse the object, she is drawn into the Astral Plane to fight an entity called the Former, whose weak point is a gigantic eye (GamesRadar; Push Square). In Bentham's prison the inmate is watched; in the Bureau's, the inmate must watch, and behind the watched object waits an eye. What the institution cannot see must nonetheless be seen, by someone, without interruption.

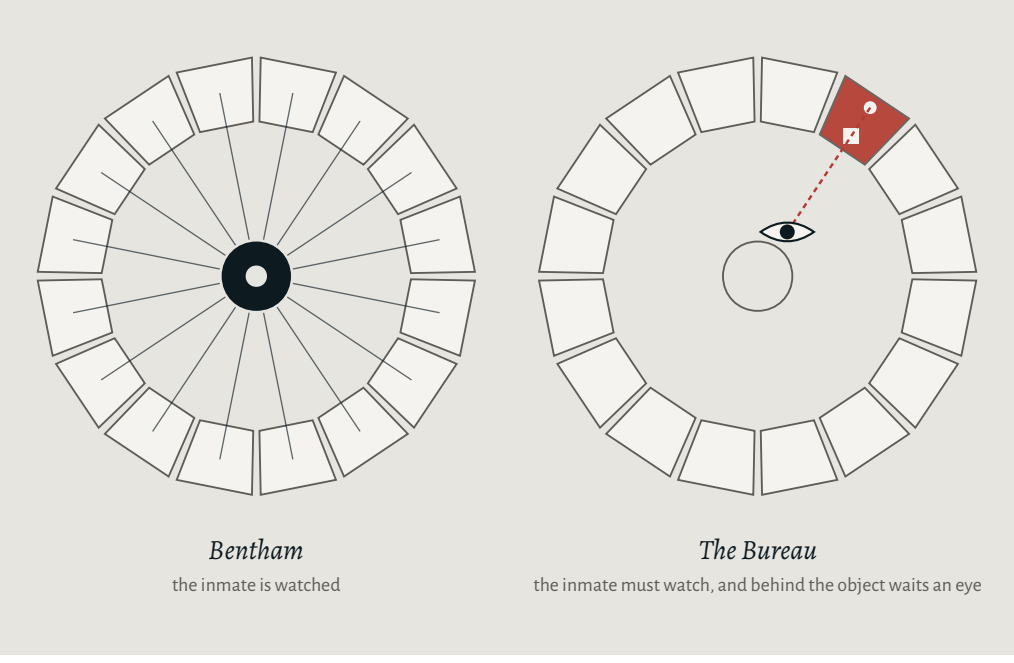


Figure 7.1 Bentham's diagram and its inversion in the Oldest House, where an agent is locked in a cell to watch an object, and behind the object waits an eye.

Two games make Galloway's thesis concrete. *BioShock* (2007) reveals in its final third that its protagonist has obeyed every instruction prefaced by a conditioned phrase, so that the player's sense of choice was itself an effect of control; its city's founder, who dies insisting that a man chooses while a slave obeys, indicts the player along with the protagonist. *The Stanley Parable* (2011; 2013) stages a war between a narrator who dictates the story and a player who can disobey, a war the narrator cannot win and the player cannot

leave. *Control* inherits both: its Director acts within a script she did not write, whose author, the Board, speaks to her in brackets.

The Hiss is not an inmate of the Panopticon but a modulation: a resonance that spreads through recited speech, synchronizes possessed agents who hover in chanting choirs, and converts bodies into relays. Deleuze's society of control arrives as a contagion inside a disciplinary building, and Jesse's labour (cleansing Control Points, reclaiming sectors) is the restoration of discipline against modulation. Its literary kin are the language viruses: William S. Burroughs's figure of the word as a virus in *The Ticket That Exploded* (1962); the Sumerian *nam-shub* of Neal Stephenson's *Snow Crash* (1992), a linguistic program that rewrites the minds that hear it; Bruce McDonald's *Pontypool* (2008), whose infection travels through English words. The Hiss is the RCU's *nam-shub*, and its relation to the Lake is exact. The Lake turns writing into world; the Hiss turns speech into possession. It is the shadow of performative language: incantation without an author and recitation without a reader, the loop of Chapter Five in its purest acoustic form. The title of the sequel, *Control Resonant*, names the antagonist's mode, and its premise, in which the Hiss and the Mold have spread beyond the Oldest House into Manhattan, marks the failure of enclosure: the passage from a disciplinary building to an open city.

ϕ 7.5 Archive fever

Jacques Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) recalled that the archive derives from the Greek *arkheion*, originally a house, the residence of the superior magistrates, the archons, who held the official documents and possessed the authority to interpret them; archival power unites the place of deposit with the right of interpretation, and it is haunted by a death drive, the *mal d'archive*. The Oldest House is an *arkheion*, and the Board is its council of archons. Gnostic cosmology preserves the ambiguity, for there the archons are the rulers of the lower spheres who keep spirit imprisoned: the question of whether the Board is the Bureau's protector or its warden is left open by design.

The Bureau's documents are redacted, and the redaction is a philosophical device. The SCP Foundation's black bars, and the passages about the Minotaur that are struck through in Danielewski's *House of Leaves*, share with *Control*'s files a single gesture: the inscription of darkness into text. The black bar is the Lake's shield of darkness transposed into typography. A partly redacted document is a Taken text, its core withheld beneath an opaque coat, and the Bureau writes darkness into its own records as a technology of containment. Kafka is the presiding genius of this archive: *The Castle* (1926), with its officials who are never reached and its village governed by a building it cannot enter; *The Trial* (1925), with its law that is everywhere and nowhere. Borges's "The Lottery in Babylon" (1941), in which a secret Company administers chance until all of life becomes lottery, anticipates the Board's inscrutable directives, and "The Library of Babel" (1941)

the infinite archive. David Graeber's *The Utopia of Rules* (2015) analysed bureaucracy as a structure of imaginative blindness underwritten by force. The corporate horror of Thomas Ligotti's *My Work Is Not Yet Done* (2002), the secret postal system of Pynchon's *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966), the Dharma Initiative of *Lost* (2004–2010), a research bureaucracy studying an island at whose heart lies a source of light, and the Bureau of Reclaimed Spaces housed in a former church in *Kentucky Route Zero* (2013–2020) complete the genealogy. The Bureau even has its prophet. The Director dead at the game's opening is Zachariah Trench, and among the visions of the biblical Zechariah are a golden lampstand fed by two olive trees and a flying scroll of curses twenty cubits long: a prophet of lamps and flying pages, admitted here as amplification.

Television had prepared the genre. *The X-Files* (1993–2002) made a federal bureau the institution of the paranormal and its partnered agents the template for Saga and Casey; *Fringe* (2008–2013) gave such a bureau a parallel universe; and *Stranger Things* (2016–2025) made the institutional corollary literal: a government laboratory whose experiments on a child open the way to a dark dimension.

ϕ 7.6 Objects of Power

The first volume of Marx's *Capital* (1867) explains commodity fetishism through a table which, once it emerges as a commodity, "not only stands with its feet on the ground, but, in relation to all other commodities, it stands on its head, and evolves out of its wooden brain grotesque ideas, far more wonderful than 'table-turning' ever was." The allusion is to the spiritualist séances of the 1850s, in which tables turned. The Bureau's Altered Items (a 1960s "Arctic Queen" refrigerator, a rubber duck) and its Objects of Power (a telephone called the Hotline, the slide projector from Ordinary) are mass-produced commodities whose fetish character has become literal. The theological niceties that Marx discovered in commodities have become physics.

Walter Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technical reproducibility (1935–1936) argued that reproduction withers the aura, the unique presence of an object in time and space. *Control* reverses Benjamin. The reproduced object is re-auratized by mass attention; aura returns, through the collective unconscious, to precisely those objects that mechanical reproduction had stripped of it. Henri Hubert and Marcel Mauss's *General Theory of Magic* (1902–1903) analysed *mana*, the power residing in persons and things, which Lévi-Strauss would reinterpret as a floating signifier. Mircea Eliade's *The Sacred and the Profane* (1957) described the hierophany, in which the sacred manifests in a profane object that remains what it is while becoming wholly other. Heidegger's lecture "The Thing" (1950) showed a jug gathering earth and sky, divinities and mortals. Graham Harman's object-oriented ontology holds that objects withdraw from all their relations, and his *Weird Realism* (2012) read Lovecraft as the poet of that withdrawal: an Object of

Power is an object whose withdrawn excess has erupted. Borges's "The Zahir" (1947), a coin which, once seen, can never be forgotten and which gradually crowds out the world, is the Object of Power reduced to its essence: an object made powerful by attention alone.

Christopher Nolan's *Inception* (2010) supplies the inverse case. Its totems are small objects whose behaviour certifies that their owner is awake (a spinning top that, in reality, eventually falls), and its limbo is the unconstructed depth of shared dreaming, raw and unbounded, in which a mind can lose itself for decades. The totem is an anti-Object of Power, an object whose ordinariness guarantees the ordinary; the limbo is a Dark Place without an author.

The argument of Chapter Three returns here in its full force. Objects of Power are the props of a culture made sacred by its attention, and the RCU understands its own iconography this way: the Clicker, the manuscript page, the thermos, and the rubber duck circulate among players as collectibles and relics, and the RCU's cameos and Easter eggs function as Objects of Power within the economy of fandom. The weapons complete the theory. The Director's weapon is named for office: service, the duty of the officeholder, Weber's *Amt*. The weapon of *Control Resonant*'s protagonist, the brother the Bureau confined, is named the Aberrant. Foucault's lectures *Abnormal* (1974–1975) traced the formation of the "abnormal individual" as the object of a fused psychiatric and juridical power. Service and Aberrant are the sovereign object of office and the weapon of the one that office excluded.

ϕ 7.7 The house of Being

The Oldest House is Brutalist, and Remedy's world design director, Stuart Macdonald, has named among the "origin points" of its design 33 Thomas Street in Lower Manhattan, the windowless AT&T Long Lines tower designed by John Carl Warnecke and completed in 1974, which reporting in *The Intercept* in 2016 identified as a node of NSA surveillance. Its architecture is the architecture of the classified state. Its imaginative ancestors are Piranesi's *Carceri d'invenzione* (1750; 1761), imaginary prisons of impossible vaults and stairs; Danielewski's house larger on the inside; and, most closely, Susanna Clarke's *Piranesi* (2020), a House of endless halls, statues, and tides whose amnesiac inhabitant keeps journals to understand it and loves it as a world. Bachelard's *The Poetics of Space* (1958) described the house as a vertical being polarized between the rational attic and the irrational cellar; the Oldest House has the Board above and the Foundation below. Foucault's lecture "Of Other Spaces" (1967; published 1984) defined heterotopias, counter-sites in which all the other sites of a culture are represented, contested, and inverted, and among his examples he named the American motel room, where illicit sex is

at once sheltered and hidden. The Oceanview Motel of *Control* and the Oceanview Hotel of *Alan Wake 2* are heterotopias by Foucault's own example.

Macdonald's account (Game Developer) also credits Marcel Breuer's Met Breuer, which Remedy visited during its research, and the Long Lines building's secretarial pool, whose rigid rows of desks recur throughout the House: the architecture of the classified state and the architecture of clerical labour, fused into one building.

The House is also a labyrinth, and *Control*'s most celebrated sequence answers the labyrinth in an unexpected way: in the Ashtray Maze, the corridors reconfigure themselves to the Old Gods of Asgard's "Take Control" as Jesse fights through them, a threshold that yields to the right song, as Baba Yaga's hut yields to the right words. Daedalus's labyrinth was answered by Ariadne's thread, and the Director's surname, Faden, is the German word for thread. Jesse Faden is, under the protocol of amplification, Ariadne's thread made a person: the one who passes through the labyrinth so that others may follow. Finally, Heidegger's "Letter on Humanism" (1946; published 1947) declared that language is the house of Being, in whose home human beings dwell. In a universe in which language is ontologically primary, the oldest house must be language itself. The Oldest House is Heidegger's house of Being, operated by the federal government.

The Bureau's term "Place of Power" has its own genealogy, and it is not a respectable one. Carlos Castaneda's *The Teachings of Don Juan* (1968), whose narrator is taught to find his "spot" on a porch, gave the idea of a place charged with personal power its popular currency, and Richard de Mille's *Castaneda's Journey* (1976) made a persuasive case that the ethnography was largely invented. Alfred Watkins's *The Old Straight Track* (1925) proposed that ancient British sites were aligned along "ley lines," which later earth-mysteries enthusiasts recast as channels of energy; and the "thin place" of modern Celtic-revival spirituality names a site where the barrier between worlds is unusually permeable. The RCU borrows this vocabulary knowingly, from the margins of modern belief rather than from scholarship, which is itself consistent with the corpus's thesis that collective belief, not truth, charges a place.

ϕ 7.8 Institutions of creative capture

The Bureau is the largest of the RCU's institutions of creative capture, but not the first. Dr. Emil Hartman's Cauldron Lake Lodge in *Alan Wake* presents itself as a retreat for blocked artists and functions as an apparatus for extracting the Lake's power through them. Le Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971) is its exact precursor: a psychiatrist, William Haber, discovers that his patient's dreams alter reality retroactively and uses them to engineer a better world; each improvement produces a catastrophe (a plague to cure overpopulation, an alien invasion to unite humanity, a universal grey to abolish race) until

Haber, attempting to dream effectively himself, opens a void. Le Guin sets against him her patient's Daoist refusal to impose, and takes her title from Zhuangzi. Hartman's fate is archival: in *Control*'s *AWE* expansion he reappears in the Oldest House transformed into a monster, the clinic's failure filed and contained. Neil Gaiman's "Calliope" (*The Sandman*, no. 17, 1990) names without euphemism the violence latent in such captures. A blocked novelist, Richard Madoc, receives the Muse Calliope from the aging writer Erasmus Fry, who had bound her on Mount Helicon in 1927 by burning her scroll, so that the binding is worked by the destruction of a text, and who had held her captive and abused her ever since; like Fry before him, Madoc rapes her repeatedly in exchange for the ideas she gives him; Dream, her former husband and the father of her son Orpheus, punishes Madoc with an unstoppable flood of ideas until he releases her (Reactor; DCU Guide). Gaiman's allegory is exact: inspiration extracted from a captive is sexual violence, and the RCU's clinic and laboratory are institutional forms of Madoc's crime, the extraction of art from a person held against their will.

The Cult of the Tree in *Alan Wake 2* belongs to folk horror, but with a twist that only the RCU could supply: it is a performed cult. Its leaders are the twin brothers Ilmo and Jaakko Koskela, entrepreneurs who also run the region's coffee brand and its theme park. Wearing deer masks, its members kill the Taken that emerge from Cauldron Lake, and the sequel opens with them strapping the former FBI agent Robert Nightingale, who has just walked out of the water, to a table and tearing out his heart. When Alan emerges, the brothers order him killed as well. Ilmo later explains that the cult existed to defend Bright Falls from the Taken; Jaakko is killed by Scratch wearing Alan's form, and Bureau agents led by Kiran Estevez arrest Ilmo and his followers (Wikipedia). The cult is a fiction of a cult, a frightening name and costume deployed to manage reality: limnopoiesis practised by entrepreneurs, as Coffee World is simulacrum practised by the same hands. Its dark mirror is the Cult of the Word, the New York murder cult that Alex Casey says he investigated, which re-enacted the killings in Alan's books in order to bring their author back, and which reappears in the Dark Place under Scratch: imitation as summoning.

The cult's kin are precise in what they show. In Robin Hardy's *The Wicker Man* (1973), an outsider policeman, Sergeant Howie, investigating a disappearance on a pagan island, discovers that he was lured there as the ideal sacrifice, and he is burned alive inside a wicker effigy by the islanders at the direction of Lord Summerisle. In Shirley Jackson's "The Lottery" (1948), the villagers, her own family among them, stone to death the woman their annual drawing selects, Tessie Hutchinson. In Ari Aster's *Midsommar* (2019), a Swedish commune kills its foreign guests over the course of its midsummer rites, the last of them burned in its temple at the choice of the grieving American woman it has crowned. Adam Scovell's Folk Horror Chain (landscape, isolation, skewed belief systems, and a happening or summoning) applies to Bright Falls link by link. Saga, the outsider

investigator whom the story needs, is Hardy's policeman redeemed: chosen by the narrative, she survives its choosing. The cult's emblem recalls Tolkien's "Leaf by Niggle" (1945), in which a painter who cannot finish his painting of a great Tree passes through a purgatorial workhouse and finds the Tree real in the country beyond.

The Lake House (2024) brings the Bureau to the Lake itself, and it is the institutional corollary at its most literal. The Bureau's research station on Cauldron Lake was run by a married couple, Jules and Diana Marmont, who used the Oldest House's lockdown to pursue rival experiments without oversight. Jules drugged and abused Rudolf Lane, a painter and former patient of Hartman's, to harness the Dark Presence through painting; Diana tried to reproduce Alan's style with automated typewriters and then with a ghostwriter recruited under false pretences, mechanizing precisely the impersonal writing that Chapter Four found in Kittler's typewriter. Lane, broken, took his own life, leaving a final self-portrait painted in his own blood; Jules used the painting to open a Threshold into the Dark Place, and the facility was Taken. The Taken Marmonts killed Estevez's team; she witnessed Diana kill Jules, then destroyed Diana herself and sealed the Threshold (Wikipedia). Poe's "The Oval Portrait" (1842), in which a painter's wife dies at the moment he completes her portrait, Morrison's "The Painting That Ate Paris" in *Doom Patrol*, and King's *Duma Key* stand behind the expansion, but the RCU's version is darker than all three: the artist's life is not drained by his work but extracted from him by an institution, and the work it produces is a door.

Coffee World, the Koskela brothers' attraction in the town of Watery, is the RCU's theme park, and Jean Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981) explains it: Disneyland is presented as imaginary in order to make us believe that the rest is real. Coffee World is Bright Falls' deterrence machine, the simulacrum that conceals the fictionality of the town around it. *FBC: Firebreak* (2025), finally, shows the institution from below: a cooperative game in which ordinary employees, not the Director, respond to crises in the House. It generalizes Ahti's mop into a whole genre of maintenance labour, and it reads, without strain, as an allegory of game development itself: small teams patching a world that keeps breaking.

The details are exact. Firebreak's teams are volunteers from the Bureau's own staff, sent in without combat training (Engadget); its missions are called "Jobs"; and after a commercially disappointing launch, its final major update, released in March 2026, was titled "Open House" (Wikipedia). Six months later, *Control Resonant* opened the House onto Manhattan. The studio's production history did not merely parallel its cosmology; it scheduled it.

ϕ 7.9 The institutional corollary

Every institution that would capture the Lake's economy without paying its price reproduces the hubris it was built to contain. The clinic produces a monster. The cult produces murders. The Bureau produces the Hiss: its researchers used the slide projector recovered from Ordinary to reach a dimension in which they found an entity they called Hedron, and its Director, Zachariah Trench, fearing that entity, used one of the burned slides from Ordinary to open the doorway through which the Hiss entered (Control Wiki). The laboratory produces its own catastrophe. And the sequel to *Control* begins with containment failing and the paranatural loose in Manhattan. Institutions in the RCU are not villains; they are repetition compulsions, repeating the errors of Zane and Hartman at scale. This is the institutional corollary of the Equilibrial Axiom, and it requires an account of what the right price is. Chapter Eight supplies one.

Chapter Eight

8

The Pharmacology of the Remedy

Balance, Contraction, and the Ethics of Creation

8.1 Plato's pharmacy and the studio's name
8.2 Balance
8.3 Contraction
8.4 Melancholy and genius
8.5 The theodicy of the author
8.6 The posology of fiction

The RCU repeatedly names the law under which creation proceeds: there must be balance. This chapter reconstructs the ethics that the law implies. It argues that the RCU's account of writing is pharmacological in Plato's and Derrida's sense; that its "balance" is a doctrine of reciprocity with deep comparative roots; that its highest ethical act is contraction, the author's withdrawal; that its psychology of creation is a theory of melancholy; and that its answer to the theodicy of authorship is a reader's veto. It concludes by stating the helical pharmacology as a posology of fiction, a science of dosage.

ϕ 8.1 Plato's pharmacy and the studio's name

In the *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), the god Theuth presents his inventions to King Thamus of Egypt and offers writing as a *pharmakon* for memory and wisdom. Thamus refuses the gift. In Benjamin Jowett's translation, "this discovery of yours will create forgetfulness in the learners' souls, because they will not use their memories; they will trust to the external written characters and not remember of themselves." Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) showed that the *pharmakon* is undecidable, remedy and poison at once, and that its semantic field includes the *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled from the city to purify it.

Alan Wake enacts Thamus's verdict with clinical precision. Its protagonist writes a novel and remembers nothing of having written it: writing has produced forgetfulness. He is also the *pharmakos*: the town's restoration and his wife's return are purchased by the writer's expulsion beneath the Lake. Umberto Eco's *The Name of the Rose* supplies the most literal version of the theme, a lost book of Aristotle on comedy whose pages are poisoned so that readers who moisten their fingers to turn them die, guarded by a blind librarian named Jorge of Burgos, whose name honours Borges. A studio named Remedy has built its universe on the other face of its own name. The name is a self-diagnosis: every remedy is a *pharmakon*, and the RCU is the extended study of the conditions under which it heals.

The studio has drawn the pun itself. In the *Night Springs* episode "Time Breaker," the actor Shawn Ashmore, playing a version of himself, discovers his own dead body while starring in a video game made by a developer called Poison Pill Entertainment, a parody of Remedy (Wikipedia). Remedy's fictional double is named for the remedy's other face. The *pharmakon* is not a reading imposed on the studio's name from outside; it is a joke the studio has already told about itself.

ϕ 8.2 Balance

The RCU states its moral law within its fiction. What the Lake gives, it takes; Alice's return requires Alan's remaining; a creation demands a payment commensurate with its

reach. The law has ancient form. The earliest surviving sentence of Western philosophy, the fragment of Anaximander preserved by Simplicius, says that things pass away into that from which they came, as is necessary, for they pay penalty and retribution to one another for their injustice according to the ordering of time. The fortieth chapter of the *Daodejing* teaches that returning is the movement of the Dao. Le Guin made balance the metaphysics of Earthsea: every act of magic alters the Equilibrium of the world, the wise mage acts only when he must, and Ged's shadow is released by an act of pride that violates it. *The Lathe of Heaven* opposes its dreamer's Daoist forbearance to his psychiatrist's will to improve.

Marcel Mauss's *The Gift* (1925) gave the law its anthropology: the threefold obligation to give, to receive, and to return. Following a Maori informant's account, Mauss described the *hau*, the spirit of the gift, which seeks to return to its place of origin and brings harm if it is not reciprocated. The Lake's gifts carry *hau*. Inspiration, resurrection, and prophecy all seek return, and the Taken are what unreturned gifts become. Moorcock's Cosmic Balance between Law and Chaos, served across the multiverse by the Eternal Champion, supplies the law's fantastic form. And Norse myth supplies its history: poetry was born from Kvasir, whom the gods made from their spittle at the truce that ended their war, so that poetry is the offspring of balance; Kvasir was then murdered, brewed, and stolen. The history of poetry, in the Norse account, is the history of a broken balance, and every poet drinks from a stolen cup.

ϕ 8.3 Contraction

If balance is the law, contraction is the virtue. Luria's *tzimtzum* holds that the infinite must withdraw to make room for the world, so that creation begins as an act of self-limitation. Simone Weil's *Gravity and Grace* (1947) described creation as God's abdication, a withdrawal so that something other than God might exist, and made the human task "decreation," the consent not to be everything. The Christological hymn of Philippians (2:7) speaks of one who emptied himself, the *kenosis* that theology has made the pattern of divine humility. Prospero, who has authored every event of *The Tempest*, abjures his magic in the fifth act, breaks his staff, and promises: "And deeper than did ever plummet sound / I'll drown my book." The author-magician returns to the human world only by drowning his book, and the RCU's author drowns with his. Väinämöinen, departing, leaves his kantele behind for the people. Tolkien's "On Fairy-Stories" (1947) described the human artist as a sub-creator who makes by the law by which he was made, and his poem "Mythopoeia" figured human making as refracted light, splintered from a single white into many hues: creation as derivative and humble, light passed on rather than possessed.

The ethics of authorship that follows is exact. The author must withdraw for the characters to live. Alan's withdrawal into the Dark Place is the condition of Alice's freedom; in the sequel, the limitation of the author is the condition of Saga's agency. The converse is the RCU's definition of evil. The Dark Presence, and its incarnation as Mr. Scratch, is creation without contraction: the Author-God who would write everything and withdraw from nothing. In the RCU, evil is total authorship.

ϕ 8.4 Melancholy and genius

The pseudo-Aristotelian *Problemata* (XXX.1) asked why all those who have become eminent in philosophy, politics, poetry, or the arts are melancholic. Marsilio Ficino's *Three Books on Life* (1489) made melancholy the Saturnine temperament of genius; Albrecht Dürer's engraving *Melencolia I* (1514) set a winged figure brooding in shadow amid instruments of measurement, a great polyhedron at her side; Raymond Klibansky, Erwin Panofsky, and Fritz Saxl reconstructed the tradition in *Saturn and Melancholy* (1964), and Robert Burton's *The Anatomy of Melancholy* (1621) had already made it an encyclopedia. Gérard de Nerval's sonnet "El Desdichado" (1854) gave the condition its emblem, "le Soleil noir de la Mélancolie," the black sun of melancholy. Julia Kristeva took that image as the title of *Black Sun* (1987), a psychoanalysis of depression in which the melancholic mourns a lost Thing that was never symbolized; depression is a kind of asymbolia, a failure of language, and sublimation (the finding of words, forms, and rhythms) is the melancholic's way back.

Alan Wake opens on a writer who has not written for two years, in the condition Coleridge mourned in "Dejection" and that the psychoanalyst Edmund Bergler named writer's block in 1947, deriving it from "psychic masochism," an unconscious wish to defeat one's own conscious aims (Zachary Leader's *Writer's Block*, 1991, traces the history). Bergler, whose clinical theories also pathologized homosexuality and have not survived scrutiny, cast the writer as "a perpetual defendant accused before the high tribunal of his unconscious conscience," an image the RCU stages when it seats its blocked author as the guest of Mr. Door's talk show, a tribunal in the costume of entertainment (§5.4). The Dark Place is the melancholic's world rendered as geography: light fails, every exit loops, the familiar city becomes hostile. The RCU's remedy is not the abolition of darkness but its articulation. The Dark Presence wants words, and so does depression, and the cure Kristeva prescribes (to find the forms in which the lost Thing can be spoken) is the cure the RCU enacts. The remedy is the word. Under the protocol of amplification, *Control*'s Hedron may be read as Dürer's polyhedron, the emblem of geometric melancholy. The entity is named for a geometric solid (the Greek *hedra*, face or seat, survives in "polyhedron"), yet the game never shows it: what the player sees is its container, a vast concrete sphere, and the entity itself is deliberately left unrevealed (Control Wiki). Melancholy's

emblem sits at the heart of the archive as an absence, like the blank Escher left at the centre of *Print Gallery* (Chapter Five).

Among contemporary games, Ninja Theory's *Hellblade: Senua's Sacrifice* (2017) is the RCU's nearest relative in this respect. It stages a Pict warrior's descent into a Norse underworld through her experience of psychosis, was developed in consultation with clinicians and with people who have lived experience of psychosis, and treats Norse myth and mental suffering as a single landscape, as the RCU treats Norse myth and the writer's melancholy.

Milton's Satan is the archetypal melancholic of English literature ("Which way I fly is Hell; myself am Hell"), and Lucifer's name means light-bearer. The town of Bright Falls carries in its very name the fall of a bright one, and the sequel's Angel Lamp, through which Alan captures and moves light to reshape the Dark Place, and from which, the lore records, the Clicker itself was cut, is literally a light-bearing angel: a Luciferian instrument turned to redemption. The RCU's melancholy is luciferian in this precise sense. The bearer of light is the one who has known darkness most intimately, and only such a one can carry light into it.

ϕ 8.5 The theodicy of the author

Leibniz's *Theodicy* (1710) argued that God chose the best of all possible worlds, and that its evils are justified because a world without them would be worse as a whole. The author's version of the argument is the law of genre: a horror story requires victims. The rule that the sequel makes explicit (Chapter Four) is a theodicy, justifying the deaths within the story by the necessity of the form that makes escape possible. The RCU registers the moral cost of that justification more honestly than most of its genre. The Taken, the cult's victims, the bodies that emerge from the Lake, the families the manuscript threatens: all are casualties of narrative, and the sequel's Alan must confront the violence his pages have authored. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) imagined a city whose happiness depends on the suffering of a single child, and the citizens who, learning this, walk away.

Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) located the origin of ethics in the face of the Other, whose nakedness addresses a prohibition against murder. The RCU's combat is a tragic Levinasian scene. The faces of the Taken are hidden in darkness; burning the darkness away reveals the human face, and is the precondition for shooting it. The mechanics both honour Levinas, since one must see the face, and violate him, since one sees it in order to kill. This is not hypocrisy but the game's honesty about its genre: horror's theodicy demands that the face be revealed and destroyed.

The RCU's ethical climax answers that theodicy with a reader's veto. The manuscript *Return*, written by Alan and twisted by Scratch, rewrites Saga's past so that her daughter,

Logan, drowned in an accident. Saga, angered that Alan has written her and her child into his story, refuses to accept the revision and fights to bring the story to an ending that restores her daughter. The original ending withholds the outcome, cutting to black as Saga calls Logan to learn whether reality has been restored; the *Final Draft* answers the call, and Logan picks up (Wikipedia). The reader does not merely supply the spiral's axis (Chapter Five). She supplies its direction, and she can refuse a descent.

ϕ 8.6 The posology of fiction

Posology is the branch of pharmacology concerned with dosage. In the RCU, the undecidability of the *pharmakon* is resolved not in theory but in practice, by two variables. The first is *dosage*: the proportion between a creation's reach and the cost its maker accepts, governed by balance and achieved by contraction. The second is *direction*: whether repetition acts out or works through, loops or spirals. Writing in excessive dose and in the looping direction is poison: Torrance's typescript, Hartman's clinic, Scratch's sequels, the Bureau's experiments, the Hiss's recitation. Writing in a measured dose and in the spiralling direction is remedy: Alan's withdrawal, Saga's reading, the *Final Draft*. A *pharmakon* becomes a remedy when its dose is balanced and its direction is helical. That is the helical pharmacology of fiction, and it is the RCU's ethics.

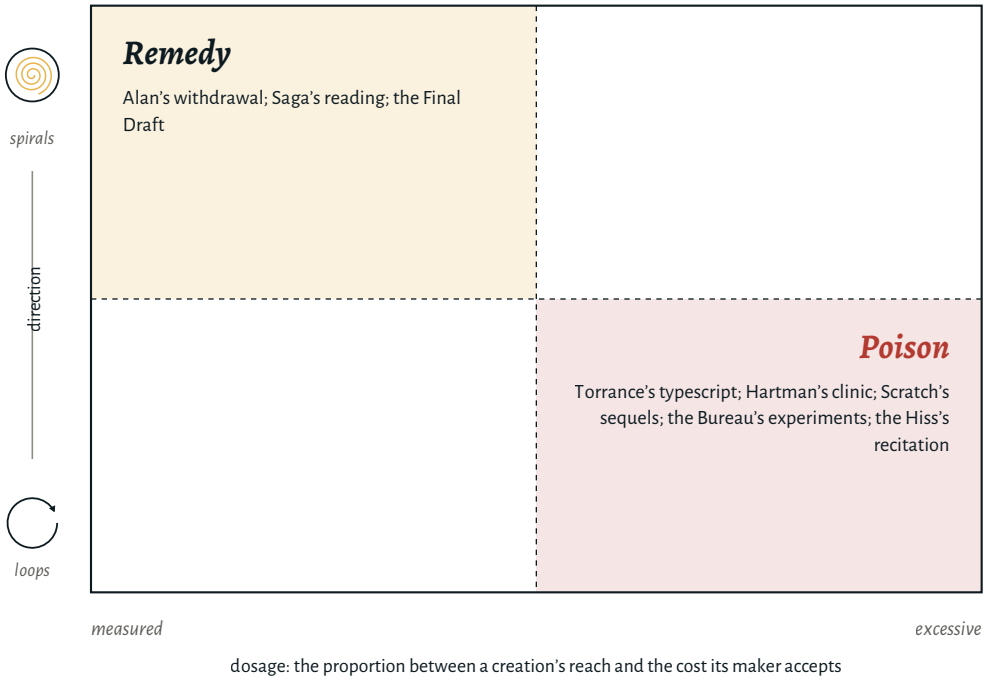


Figure 8.1 The posology of fiction. A pharmakon becomes a remedy when its dose is balanced and its direction is helical.

Chapter Nine

9



The Wake of the Lake

Toward a Helical Mythopoetics

9.1 The system of axioms
9.2 The Auto-mythographic Axiom
9.3 *Control Resonant* as a test of the model
9.4 Helical mythopoetics
9.5 The Sampo and the ocean

The preceding chapters reconstructed three axioms from the corpus and deferred a fourth. This chapter states the four together and demonstrates their interdependence, develops the Auto-mythographic Axiom in full, tests the resulting model against *Control Resonant*, and proposes helical mythopoetics as a critical category for serial fiction. It closes with the Sampo.

ϕ 9.1 The system of axioms

The *Lacustrine Axiom* (Chapter Three): reality is precipitated at the illuminated surface of a receptive and appetitive darkness by acts of form. The *Helical Axiom* (Chapter Five): every act of form recurs, and recurrence becomes revision only when displaced along an axis supplied by a reader. The *Equilibrial Axiom* (Chapters Seven and Eight): every creation exacts a cost proportionate to its reach, its highest virtue is contraction, and institutions that would capture its economy without paying the cost reproduce the hubris they contain. The *Auto-mythographic Axiom* (this chapter): the RCU writes the conditions of its own production into its cosmology.

The four are not a list but a structure, because each presupposes the next. Limnopoiesis without the helix would be Jack Torrance's typescript: a receptacle receiving the same form forever. The helix without balance would be Scratch's endless sequels: revision without cost, an author who never withdraws. Balance without auto-mythography would yield a moral fable, a story with a lesson. With it, the RCU becomes a myth in Eliade's sense, a narrative of origins that founds the very practices by which it is retold; for a myth accounts for the conditions of its own telling, and the RCU's account of origins includes its own production. Ontology, temporality, ethics, and reflexivity: this is the complete structure of a mythology.

ϕ 9.2 The Auto-mythographic Axiom

The first evidence is onomastic. Sami Järvi became Sam Lake, translating a common Finnish surname into its English meaning. His protagonist is Alan Wake, and the word "wake" carries three senses that the RCU activates together. A wake is the trace a moving body leaves on water. A wake is also the vigil kept over the dead, as in the nineteenth-century Irish ballad "Finnegan's Wake," in which a hod-carrier presumed dead revives when whiskey splashes on him at his own wake, and in Joyce's *Finnegans Wake* (1939), which begins in mid-sentence with "riverrun" and ends with the sentence that its first page completes, a book that is a loop on the page and, through Vico, a spiral in history. And to wake is to awaken, the command that reaches the sleeping prince in the *Hymn of the Pearl*. Alan Wake is the author's wake on the water of his own name, a vigil over an author presumed dead, and an awakening. The protagonist is the visible disturbance produced by an author's passage through his own medium. The Lake/Wake rhyme lies

on the surface; the derivation from Järvi is biography; their convergence within a single cosmology is the RCU's signature.

The second evidence is chronological. Alan's captivity in the Dark Place lasts from 2010 to 2023, exactly the interval between *Alan Wake* and *Alan Wake 2*: years in which an early sequel was shelved, *American Nightmare* was made in its place, *Quantum Break* intervened, and the publishing rights to *Alan Wake* returned to Remedy from Microsoft in 2019. The Dark Place is development limbo. The sequel's incorporation of *American Nightmare* as one of Alan's drafts is the studio's production history written as cosmology, its abandoned and substitute projects converted into in-world drafts. Federico Fellini's *8½* (1963) made a director's block into a film; King wrote himself into *The Dark Tower*. The RCU does something larger: it converts a corporate history into a metaphysics.

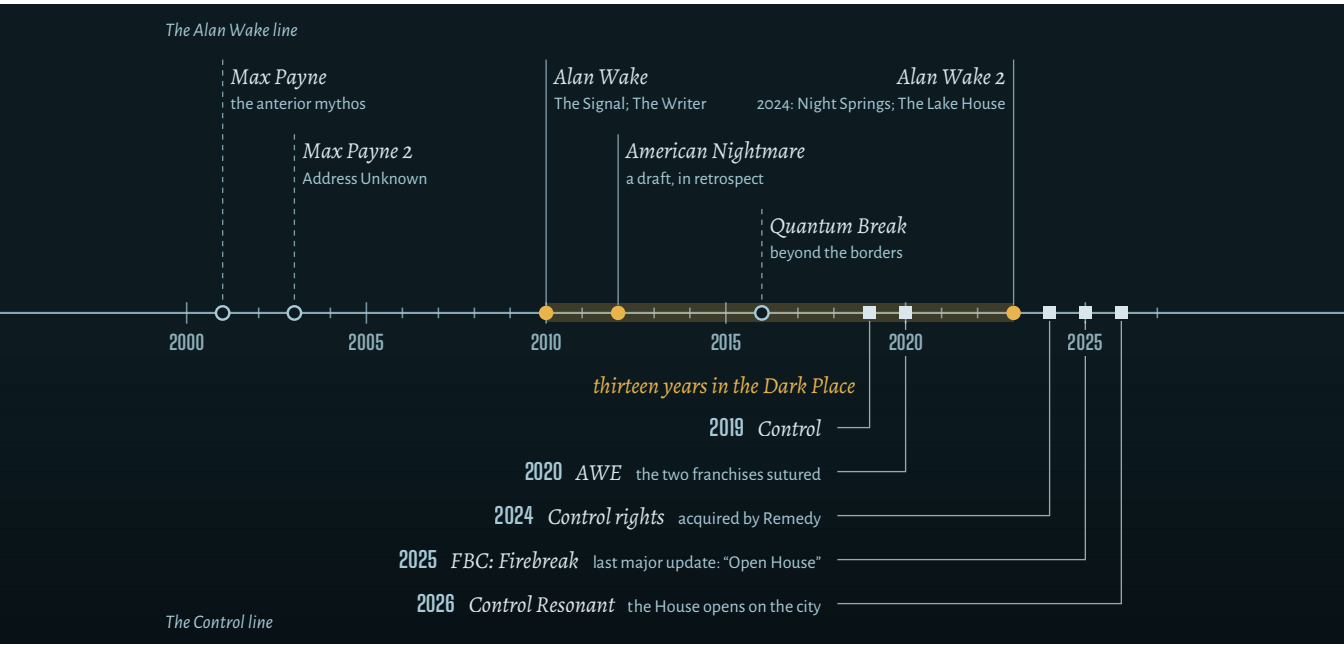


Figure 9.1 The corpus from the anterior mythos to *Control Resonant*. Hollow markers stand outside the RCU's declared borders; the amber span is Alan's captivity and the studio's.

The production history is more literal still. When Microsoft declined Remedy's early pitch for an *Alan Wake* sequel and commissioned *Quantum Break* instead, Remedy placed inside that game a short live-action film, *Alan Wake: Return*, made to help promote the sequel to publishers, in which two FBI agents, Alex Casey and Saga Anderson, investigate Wake's reappearance; Saga was then played by Malla Malmivaara, and was later recast with Melanie Liburd. The RCU's reader-protagonist was thus born as a pitch, smuggled into a game whose rights Remedy did not hold, under the title that would become half of the sequel. The sequel's development is commonly counted at thirteen

years, a span Lake has discussed in interviews. And the *Night Springs* expansion makes the doctrine explicit: its three episodes are implied to be drafts that Alan rejected, one of them ("North Star") a compressed retelling of *Control* itself, and its third places a version of Shawn Ashmore inside a game made by Poison Pill Entertainment, a parody of Remedy (Wikipedia). The studio has written itself into its own multiverse under the name of its pharmacological opposite (Chapter Eight).

The third evidence is juridical. *Quantum Break*, owned by Microsoft, stands outside the RCU's declared borders, and yet the *Night Springs* episode "Time Breaker," whose title fuses Tim Breaker with *Quantum Break* and whose star played both, winks across the border. *Max Payne*, owned by Rockstar, stands outside, and yet Alex Casey, with Lake's face and McCaffrey's voice, smuggles its protagonist's ghost inside. The RCU's multiverse is bounded by law rather than by metaphysics: the connected universe is a juridical object, its borders are the borders of intellectual property, and its ghosts are the ghosts of property. *Control*'s history follows the same pattern. Announced in 2022 as a co-production with 505 Games, its franchise rights were acquired outright by Remedy in 2024, after which Annapurna agreed to fund half of the sequel's development and to collaborate on film and television adaptations of both *Control* and *Alan Wake* (TheSixthAxis). The return of a franchise to its maker is the corporate form of the Return.

The fourth evidence is institutional. Remedy is a publicly listed company governed by a board of directors; *Control*'s cosmos is governed by a Board that appoints its Directors through an object and communicates in bracketed directives. The convergence is overdetermination, not allegorical intention: an institution of creative labour answerable to a board has written a cosmology in which a bureau of creative objects is answerable to the Board. *FBC: Firebreak*, in which the rank and file keep the House running, is the employees' game, and its last major update was titled "Open House" (§7.8). And the fifth evidence is the studio's name, whose pharmacology Chapter Eight reconstructed.

The RCU is therefore an auto-mythography: a cosmos that encodes the conditions of its own making. This is not a failure of immersion but the fourth axiom's fulfilment. In a universe where stories make worlds, the story of the world's making must include its makers.

ϕ 9.3 *Control Resonant* as a test of the model

A model is tested by prediction. The model of this dissertation was formed on the corpus through 2025; *Control Resonant*, released in September 2026, supplies a test at the level of premise. Its premise, as documented at release, is this: Dylan Faden, held by the Bureau for years under the designation P6, emerges into a Manhattan reshaped by a cosmic force that bends physical law and extends into his psyche; the Hiss and the Mold are loose in the city; his search reunites him with his sister Jesse, the Director; he wields a

shape-shifting melee weapon called the Aberrant; and the series changes genre, from shooter to action role-playing game (KitGuru; Hitmarker; TheSixthAxis).

Each axiom is borne out. The Lacustrine Axiom predicts that a psyche externalized as world is the RCU's basic act; *Control Resonant* performs limnopoiesis at the scale of a city, transposing the Dark Place's New York into the *Control* branch. It also predicts that each franchise's second movement expands its scale, as the lake became an ocean; here the House becomes Manhattan, the paranatural overflowing its container as the Lake overflowed into the sea. The Helical Axiom predicts that a sequel restates its predecessor with roles redistributed; as *Alan Wake* 2 divided its predecessor between an author and a reader, *Control Resonant* makes the confined brother its protagonist and the Director the figure sought. Its first major update was reported to add a mode called New Game ++, the medium's spiral given a second turn. The Equilibrial Axiom's institutional corollary predicts that what an institution captures without paying its price returns as catastrophe; the Bureau's confinement of a paranatural person returns as a crisis that the Bureau can no longer contain. And the Auto-mythographic Axiom predicts that the series will inscribe its own production; a franchise reacquired by its maker and co-financed by a film company changes its genre, and its weapon is named for deviation, so that the series names its own aberration from its earlier form.

Two further facts sharpen the test. *The Lake House* had already planted the premise: in its course, Kiran Estevez meets Dylan Faden, briefly transported by way of the Oceanview Motel, who warns her of a coming cataclysm in New York City (Wikipedia). And the medium supplies the premise's nearest precedent in Konami's *Silent Hill* 2 (2001), whose fog-bound town reshapes itself around the repressed guilt of its protagonist, James Sunderland, who comes to the town because of a letter from his dead wife, Mary, and learns at the end that he smothered her as she lay terminally ill. *Silent Hill* 2 made a town the externalized conscience of one man; *Control Resonant* makes a city the externalized psyche of one confined brother. The difference is the RCU's own: the city is not only his but collective, shared with the Hiss and the Mold, a lake become an ocean.

The makers' own descriptions confirm the reading. Remedy's team has said that what the Oldest House is to a normal office building, the sequel's Manhattan is to a normal New York (Shacknews), and that the sequel reverses the first game's journey, since Dylan, unlike Jesse, has always been inside the House (GameWatcher): scale expanded, roles redistributed, exactly as the Lacustrine and Helical Axioms predict. Published accounts of the ending go further. They report that Dylan restores his mind by playing through his childhood in Ordinary as a retro-style role-playing game, from the discovery of the slide projector onward (GamingBolt). The sequel's climax is a replay that becomes a recovery: working-through staged as a game within the game, the Helical Axiom in its plainest form.

Amplification adds a final resonance. In the Fourth Branch of the *Mabinogi*, a child named Dylan, as soon as he is named, makes for the sea and takes on its nature, swimming like a fish; he is called Dylan Eil Ton, Dylan Son of the Wave. The brother whom the House held apart returns, like the wave, to an ocean. The model's predictions for the RCU's future are offered here for falsification: each second movement will expand scale; protagonism will pass to those previously written, contained, or read; and production history will continue to enter the diegesis as draft.

ϕ 9.4 Helical mythopoetics

Helical mythopoetics may be defined as a mode of serial myth-making in which each instalment restates its predecessors with a displacement along an axis supplied by readers, so that the series accumulates meaning rather than merely extending content. It is distinguished from two alternatives. *Orbital seriality* is the series in Eco's sense, in which the same situation recurs with variations and without accumulation; it is what Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer, in *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944; 1947), condemned in the culture industry as the eternal recurrence of the ever-same. *Linear seriality* is the chronicle, in which events accumulate without reinterpretation.

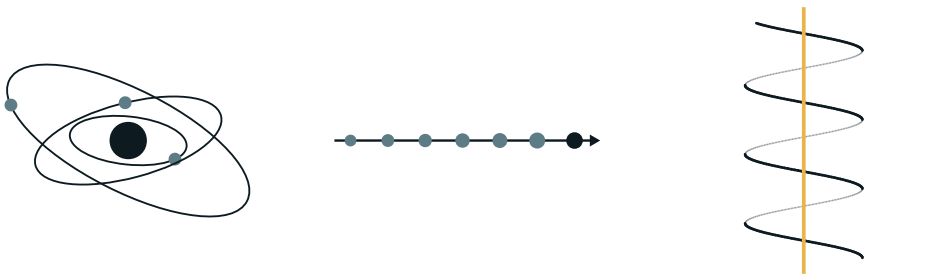


Figure 9.2 Three serialities. Only the third accumulates meaning rather than merely extending content.

Four criteria identify the helical mode. The first is *revision over continuation*: each instalment rereads its predecessors, as *Alan Wake 2* rereads *Alan Wake* and *American Nightmare* as drafts and the *Final Draft* rereads *Alan Wake 2*. The second is the *reader-axis*: the community of readers and players functions as a hermeneutic participant whose reading

converts loops into spirals; this is the ocean of the tagline. The third is *legislative reflexivity*: the universe's laws are laws of storytelling, as narrative causation and genre-as-physics are in the RCU. The fourth is *acknowledged cost*: the series registers what its storytelling demands, as the RCU's doctrine of balance and its theodicy of genre do.

The RCU is not alone in the mode. King's *Dark Tower* ends with a return marked by difference. *Twin Peaks*, between 1990 and *The Return* (2017), became a rereading of itself. Hideo Kojima's *Metal Gear Solid 2* (2001) restaged its predecessor's mission as a deliberate simulation, making a sequel into a commentary on the control that sequels exert. Hideaki Anno's *Rebuild of Evangelion* (2007–2021), a remake that became a sequel, ended by releasing its protagonist from a cycle into a rewritten world. Moorcock's Eternal Champion is the mode's ancestor in prose. The RCU differs from all of these in scale, and in the explicitness of its doctrine: it is the first transmedia franchise to state its theory of seriality as its own cosmology. Its contrast with the Marvel Cinematic Universe is instructive. The MCU's multiverse is a mechanism of orbital seriality, a device for returns and variants without revision, in which death is reversible without cost. The RCU's multiverse, in *Night Springs*, is a laboratory of variation in which every variant costs something.

ϕ 9.5 The Sampo and the ocean

The last great quest of the *Kalevala* is the recovery of the Sampo, the mill that Ilmarinen forged to grind out grain, salt, and coin. The heroes sail north to steal it; Louhi, mistress of the North, pursues them in the form of a monstrous eagle; in the struggle the Sampo shatters and falls into the sea. Its fragments wash ashore on the coasts of Kalevala, where Väinämöinen gathers them and sows them for the land's prosperity, while Louhi carries home only its bright lid.

The RCU is a shattered Sampo. Its world-mill does not stand whole in any single work. Its fragments (manuscript pages, Objects of Power, cassette tapes, recurring faces, songs, cameos, a light switch called the Clicker) wash up along the shoreline of a dozen games and as many media, and each fragment still grinds. Its unity is not given but gathered: by Saga at her case board, by the player across replays, by a community that pins red string between fragments. The RCU's deepest claim about itself is that its unity is the work of its readers. The wake of the Lake reaches the shore as an ocean.

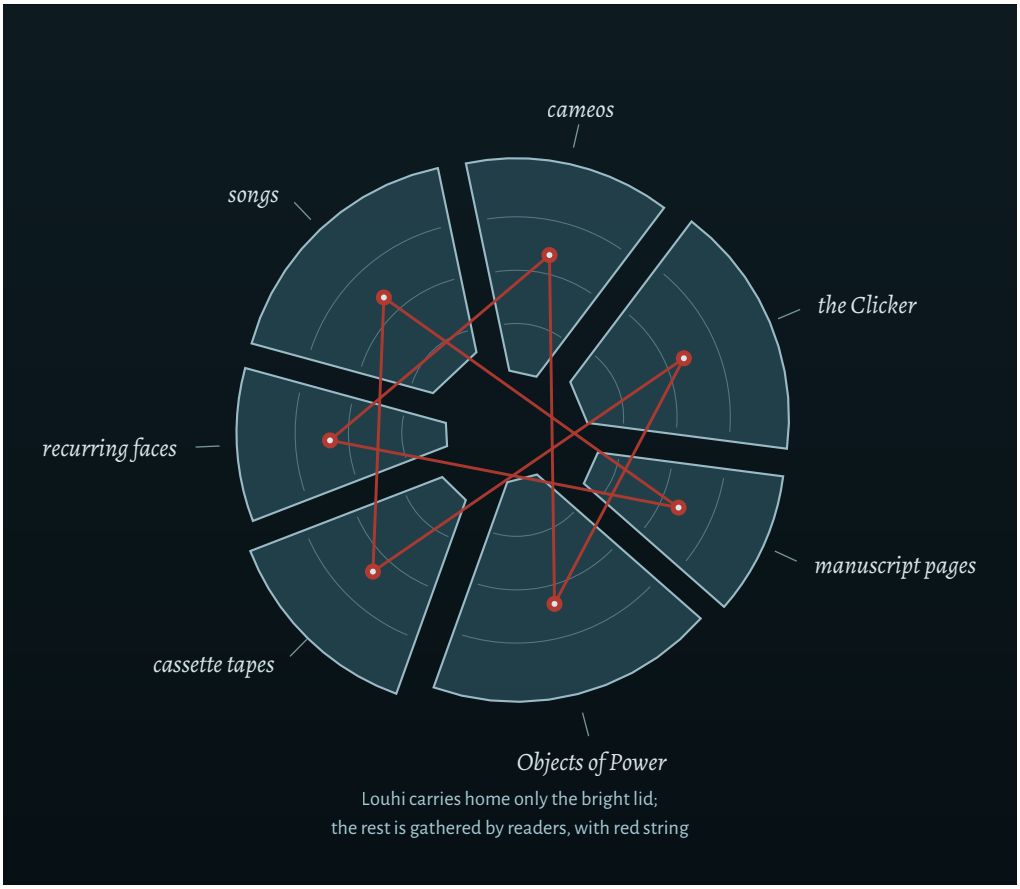


Figure 9.3 The Sampo shattered. Its fragments still grind; its unity is not given but gathered, as Saga gathers hers at the case board.



Not a Loop

This dissertation has itself been a case board, and by its own Helical Axiom it cannot stand outside the spiral it describes. A reading of the RCU is one more turn of the RCU: a displacement along an axis that the corpus did not, and could not, supply for itself. If the argument is right, its own status is that of a reader's pass across a loop, and its value lies not in closing the circle but in raising it by one turn.

The epigraphs return, transformed. Prospero drowns his book in order to return to the human world; Alan Wake's book is drowned with its author, and what returns is a reader. Coleridge's sacred river runs down to a sunless sea; the RCU names that sea and finds it hungry. Milton's Satan claims that the mind is its own place, able to make a heaven of hell or a hell of heaven; the RCU divides the mind into two places, a Dark Place and a Mind Place, and stakes its ethics on the traffic between them. And Yeats's gyre widens until the falcon cannot hear the falconer. The RCU's gyre widens too, from a lake to an ocean and from a House to a city, but the RCU denies that widening must mean dispersal. The falcon hears the falconer when the falconer is a reader.

One recorded voice belongs in this coda, because the RCU's own media theory claims it. When James McCaffrey died in December 2023, two months after the sequel's release, the voice that had joined Max Payne to Alex Casey became what Chapter Four argued recorded voices are in this universe: a trace that outlives the body that made it, a death mask in sound, kept in the archive and returning whenever it is played.

The RCU began with a writer who could not remember what he had written. Its latest instalment follows a brother whom no institution could contain. Between them stretches a theory: that stories make worlds; that worlds recur; that recurrence can rise; that rising costs; and that the cost is borne by those who make and redeemed by those who read. It is not a lake. It is not a loop. It is a wake: the trace a maker leaves upon the water, which outlasts the passage that made it, and which reaches, in time, every shore.

Onomastic Concordance

Appendix

Twenty-seven names in the corpus and the resonances this dissertation reads in them. "Textual" marks a connection the corpus makes explicit; "Paratextual," one documented outside the games; "Amplification," a parallel admitted to enrich a symbol rather than claimed as authorial intention.

Sam Lake (born Sami Järvi)
Creative director and writer
Finnish *järvi*, "lake"; Cauldron Lake
■ Paratextual Chapters 1, 3, 9

Alan Wake
Novelist-protagonist
A wake on water; the funeral wake (*Finnegans Wake*); awakening (*Hymn of the Pearl*)
☐ Amplification Chapters 2, 9

Alice Wake
Wife, taken into the Lake
Carroll's Alice; "Which Dreamed It?"
☐ Amplification Chapters 2

Barbara Jagger
Vessel of the Dark Presence
Baba Yaga
☐ Amplification (widely held deliberate) Chapters 2

Bird Leg Cabin
Cabin on Diver's Isle
Baba Yaga's hut on chicken legs
☐ Amplification (widely held deliberate) Chapters 2

Thomas Zane
Poet; the Diver
Acts of Thomas (*Hymn of the Pearl*); the diver for the pearl
☐ Amplification (fortuitous) Chapters 2

Cauldron Lake
The Lake
Óðrerir; Ceridwen's cauldron; *Pair Dadeni*; *Macbeth* IV.i; *vas hermeticum*
☐ Amplification Chapters 2, 3

Cynthia Weaver
Keeper of the Well-Lit Room
Cynthia (Artemis, the moon); the Norns weaving at Urðr's well
☐ Amplification Chapters 3

Odin and Tor Anderson
The Old Gods of Asgard
Odin and Thor; Valhalla; *American Gods*
■ Textual Chapters 2

Saga Anderson
FBI profiler; reader-protagonist
Sága of *Grímnismál*; Eco's "saga"
☐ Amplification Chapters 2, 5

Mr. Scratch
Alan's double
Old Scratch (Irving); Mr. Scratch (Benét); the scratch of the pen; "from scratch"; the crossroads bargain of art for the soul
☐ Amplification Chapters 6

Mr. Door
Host of In Between
Janus; Hermes; Kafka's doorkeeper; Blake's doors of perception; Legba, guardian of the gate
☐ Amplification Chapters 2

Ahti
Janitor of the Oldest House

The *Kalevala*'s water god; Latin *ianitor*, doorkeeper; hands Alan a key, calling him Tom

■ Textual; Amplification Chapters 1, 2

Jesse Faden
Director of the Bureau

German *Faden*, "thread"; Ariadne

☐ Amplification Chapters 7

Dylan Faden
Brother; protagonist of Control Resonant

Dylan Eil Ton, "Son of the Wave" (*Mabinogi*)

☐ Amplification Chapters 9

Polaris
Entity bonded to Jesse

The North Star; Finnish Pohjantähti; Estonian *põhjanael*, the nail of the north

■ Textual; Amplification Chapters 2

Hedron
Entity in the House, never shown; kept in a concrete sphere

The polyhedron of Dürer's *Melencolia I*

☐ Amplification Chapters 8

Zachariah Trench
Former Director

Zechariah's lampstand and flying scroll

☐ Amplification Chapters 7

The Oldest House
Bureau headquarters

Derrida's *arkheion*; Heidegger's "house of Being"

☐ Amplification Chapters 7

Altered World Event (AWE)
Bureau category

Otto's numinous awe; Welsh *awen*, inspiration

☐ Amplification Chapters 2, 7

Service Weapon; Aberrant
Weapons of the two Control *games*

Excalibur; Weber's office; Foucault's abnormal

☐ Amplification Chapters 2, 7, 9

Bright Falls; Angel Lamp
Town; light-bearing instrument

Lucifer, "light-bearer," and his fall

☐ Amplification Chapters 8

Echoes
Glimpses of Casey's investigation used to rewrite scenes

Ovid's Echo

☐ Amplification Chapters 5

The Clicker
Childhood light switch

Winnicott's transitional object; a switch cut from Zane's Angel Lamp; *fiat lux*

■ Textual; Amplification Chapters 3

Alex Casey
Character and FBI agent

Lake's face and McCaffrey's voice; Auster's Max Work

■ Paratextual; Amplification Chapters 6

Ordinary
Jesse's hometown

King's Maine; the sacred in the profane

☐ Amplification Chapters 1

Night Springs
In-world television series

Serling's *The Twilight Zone*; a spring of night

■ Textual; Amplification Chapters 1, 4

B Typology of Recurrence

Appendix

The seven forms of recurrence discussed in Chapter Five, with their temporal logic, sources, exemplars, and place in the RCU.



Eternal return of the same

Identical recurrence without end

Philosophical sources	Nietzsche (1882); Eliade (1949)
Fictional exemplars	*True Detective* season 1 (2014); *The Third Policeman* (1967)
In the RCU	The Taken's echolalia
Ethical valence	Infernal: acting-out



Fixed timeline

Past unalterable; loops self-consistent

Philosophical sources	Novikov self-consistency principle; Chiang (2007)
Fictional exemplars	*Quantum Break* (2016)
In the RCU	*Quantum Break*, at the corpus's edge
Ethical valence	Fatalist



Branching

Divergence into many worlds

Philosophical sources	Borges (1941); Everett (1957); Lewis (1986)
Fictional exemplars	"The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941)
In the RCU	The *Night Springs* multiverse
Ethical valence	Plural



Knot

A loop sustained by an origin that must be unmade

Philosophical sources	The bootstrap paradox
Fictional exemplars	*Dark* (2017–2020)
In the RCU	Not adopted
Ethical valence	Tragic



Concealed spiral

External repetition, internal change

Philosophical sources	Kierkegaard (1843)
Fictional exemplars	*Groundhog Day* (1993); *Outer Wilds* (2019)
In the RCU	*Alan Wake's American Nightmare* (2012)
Ethical valence	Educative



Helix

Repetition displaced along an axis supplied by a reader

Philosophical sources	Vico (1725); Goethe (1831); Yeats (1925); Freud (1914); Jung (1944); Deleuze (1968)
Fictional exemplars	*Purgatorio*; *The Neverending Story* (1979); Escher's *Print Gallery* (1956); runosong parallelism
In the RCU	*Alan Wake* 2 (2023) and *Final Draft*; *Control Resonant* (2026)
Ethical valence	Purgatorial: working-through



Vortex

A spiral that draws everything to its centre

Philosophical sources	Freud's death drive (1920)
Fictional exemplars	*Uzumaki* (1998–1999); "MS. Found in a Bottle" (1833)
In the RCU	The pull of the Dark Presence
Ethical valence	Horror, survivable by attention ("A Descent into the Maelström," 1841)

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Keywords

Remedy Connected Universe; Remedy Entertainment; Sam Lake; Alan Wake*;* Alan Wake 2*;* Control*;* Control Resonant*; game studies; transmedia storytelling; shared fictional universes; seriality; helical mythopoetics; limnopoiesis; helical recurrence; eternal return; repetition compulsion; working-through; metafiction; narrative causation; philosophy of fiction; genre theory; author-function; the double* (Doppelgänger)*; pharmakon; khôra;* Ungrund*; potential space; floating signifier; collective unconscious; numinous; sublime; political theology; societies of control; archive; Objects of Power; commodity fetishism; hierophany; the Weird; New Weird; cosmic horror; folk horror; hauntology; media archaeology; melancholy; ethics of authorship; comparative mythology; monomyth; liminality;* Kalevala*; Finnish literature; Norse mythology; Arthurian legend; Gnosticism; Lurianic Kabbalah; Romanticism.*

